

Managerial Communication

Open-book exam pack — all 10 sessions, all 18 readings, plus the answer machinery to use them under time pressure.

WHAT'S INSIDE

- **Part A • Exam playbook** — four answer formats with clock plans, the paraphrase engine, the symptom→concept lookup table.
- **Part B • Sessions 1-10** — class slides first, readings layered in, every author named. Concept banks you can scan in seconds.
- **Part C • Cross-cutting** — where the authors disagree, combination plays, worked model answers, drop-in line bank.
- **Part D • Index** — every concept, alphabetical, with page numbers.

THREE RULES FOR THE EXAM HALL

- **Never copy a definition.** Open book is not open quotation. Every concept in this pack has a *say-it-your-way* line — use that, not the textbook wording.
- **Name the source.** "Munter", "Conger", "Stone", "Hofstede", "Hall", "Cialdini", "Steil", "Tannenbaum & Salas". Attribution is cheap and it scores.
- **Concept density beats prose quality.** More correctly-applied concepts, each tied to a concrete detail, beats one elegantly written idea.

COURSE SPINE

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How to use this in the hall

Minute 0-2: read the question twice, underline the *verb* (analyse / recommend / draft / compare / relate to your experience) and the *unit* (a person, a team, a message, a culture). The verb picks your format in **A1**.

Minute 2-5: go to **A4**, find the symptoms in the prompt, list the 8-12 concepts it points at. **Then** open the session pages for those concepts. Do not read this pack front-to-back during the exam.

PART A

Exam playbook

The syllabus moves year to year, so this pack does not bet on one paper shape. Below are the four shapes a managerial-communication paper actually takes, and what a high-scoring answer looks like in each. Identify the shape in the first two minutes; the rest of the pack supplies the content.

A1 · Four formats, four answer shapes

Format 1 — The reflective application essay

"Choose one of the two topics below and relate it to your own experience. Part 1: summarise the experience (min 400 words). Part 2: analyse it using relevant concepts (min 800 words)." This was the shape of the 2023 paper. The syllabus has moved a good deal since, so treat it as one live possibility among the four here — not a prediction.

Section	Words	What must be in it
Part 1 — Narrative	400–500	Context (who, where, stakes, your role and formal position) · the trigger event in sequence · what you were trying to accomplish communicatively (state the objective explicitly — "I needed X to agree to Y by Friday") · what actually happened · the outcome. Write it flat and factual. Plant the hooks: mention the silences, the seating, the interruptions, the words people chose, the delays — every detail you plan to analyse in Part 2 must first exist in Part 1.
Part 2 — Analysis	800–1000	Six to nine labelled analytical moves, each one: <i>name the concept</i> → <i>one-line definition in your own words</i> → <i>quote the specific moment from Part 1</i> → <i>say what it explains</i> → <i>say what you would do differently</i> . Use sub-headings. End with 3–4 transferable learnings written as rules, not feelings.

Structure to write on your rough sheet before you start

- ▶ Part 2 · §1 **Framing the episode** — what kind of communication problem was this really? (content vs relational dimension; stated issue vs real issue)
- ▶ Part 2 · §2 **What I assumed** — assumptions, levels of perception, the "everybody knows" bias
- ▶ Part 2 · §3 **The channel and the structure I chose** — direct vs indirect, oral vs written, point-first vs build-up
- ▶ Part 2 · §4 **What the non-verbals and the silences did** — contradiction, regulation, chronemics, proxemics
- ▶ Part 2 · §5 **Listening / face / power** — who had the floor, who had legitimacy, psychological safety
- ▶ Part 2 · §6 **Where it broke** — the single mechanism that caused the failure, named precisely
- ▶ Part 2 · §7 **Redesign** — the same episode run again using the frameworks, step by step
- ▶ Part 2 · §8 **Transferable rules** — 3–4 one-line principles

Format 2 — Case / scenario diagnosis

You get a vignette (a manager, a team, an email, a transcript) and are asked what went wrong and what to do.

Move	What to write
1. Diagnose	Two or three named failure mechanisms, not adjectives. Not "poor communication" — "a failure of <i>uptake</i> : her point was made, then re-attributed to a senior colleague and entered the minutes under his name."
2. Layer	Separate individual (skill/willingness), interpersonal (face, trust, power distance) and systemic (norms, incentives, channels, structure) causes. Most answers stop at the first layer; marks live in the third.
3. Apply	Name the framework and map the case onto it explicitly. "On Munter's five credibility factors, she has expertise credibility and no rank or goodwill credibility — which is why the same argument from the VP landed."
4. Recommend	Specific, sequenced, owned. <i>Who</i> does <i>what</i> , in <i>which channel</i> , by <i>when</i> . Add one structural fix (a norm, a system, an incentive) so it does not recur.
5. Trade-off	One paragraph naming the cost of your own recommendation and why you accept it. This is the single cheapest way to look like a senior thinker.

The five-beat formula to write at the top of every case answer — D · F · A · C · R

- ▶ **DIAGNOSE** — state the exact communication failure, not a vague one. "*The problem is a lack of feedback and poor channel fit,*" not "*communication is bad.*"
- ▶ **FRAMEWORK** — name the model and define *only* the part the case needs.
- ▶ **APPLY** — connect each important case fact to the framework, one by one.
- ▶ **CONSEQUENCE** — say what it did to shared meaning, acceptance, credibility, decision quality or action.
- ▶ **RECOMMEND** — an *observable* managerial behaviour, and why it fixes the mechanism you diagnosed.

- **Never end on "communicate better."** A strong recommendation changes a specific behaviour, channel, sequence, feedback loop, framing choice or listening condition.

Format 3 — Draft the message

"Write the email / the feedback conversation opening / the pitch / the refusal." Usually paired with "and justify your choices."

- **Always split the page.** Left/top: the artefact itself, formatted as a real message (subject line, salutation, sign-off). Right/bottom: a short "design notes" list keyed to the choices — *"Buffer: appreciation, not thanks-for-your-email (trite opener trap). Bad news embedded mid-paragraph in a subordinate clause. Passive voice to depersonalise. Alternative offered so the refusal isn't terminal."*
- The design notes are where the marks are. A perfect email with no justification scores like a decent email.
- Decide direct vs indirect **out loud** and say why, using the receiver-reaction test, not your own comfort.

Format 4 — Concept, compare, illustrate

"Explain X." / "Distinguish X from Y." / "Illustrate X with a managerial example."

- **Definition in your own words (1 line) → the mechanism, i.e. why it works that way (2 lines) → a concrete managerial example (2 lines) → the boundary condition or critique (1 line).** The fourth element is what separates a 7 from a 9.
- For "distinguish", always give the **axis of difference** first ("these differ on *who controls the meaning*"), then the two poles, then a case where the distinction changes what a manager should do.

A2 • The 90-minute clock plans

Minutes	Reflective essay (1200+ words)	Case / mixed paper
0-5	Choose the topic you have the richest single episode for — not the topic you know best theoretically. Detail beats theory here.	Read the whole paper. Allocate marks-to-minutes. Attempt the highest-mark question first.
5-12	Skeleton on rough sheet: 8 events for Part 1; 7-9 concept labels for Part 2 (pull from A4).	Per question, jot 4-6 concept labels before writing a word.
12-35	Write Part 1 straight through. Don't analyse yet. Plant every hook.	Answer 1 and 2.
35-80	Write Part 2, one sub-heading per concept cluster. Keep a count of concepts used in the margin.	Answer 3, 4 ...
80-88	Learnings paragraph + word count check (count by sampling : words in 3 lines ÷ 3 × total lines).	Return to the thinnest answer and add one framework + one trade-off.
88-90	Scan for any sentence that reads like the textbook. Reword it.	Same.

Word-count calibration: ordinary handwriting runs 9-11 words a line. 400 words ≈ 38-44 lines ≈ 1¼ sides. 800 words ≈ 75-90 lines ≈ 2½ sides. Write "400" and "1200" at the top of your answer book and tick off sides as you go — running short on a stated minimum is a pure, avoidable loss.

A3 • The paraphrase engine — how to use an open book without copying

The rule that catches people

Open book means you may **consult**. Lifting a definition or an explanation verbatim from a reading is plagiarism even with the book legitimately in front of you. The exam usually says so explicitly. Every concept table in Part B therefore carries a **"say it your way"** column written in plain, non-textbook language — that column is safe to reproduce closely because it is already a paraphrase, but the reliable habit is to transform it again using the four moves below.

Move	Textbook form	Your form
Change the grammar	"Cohesiveness is the degree to which group members identify with the group and wish to remain in it."	"A group is cohesive when people actually want to stay in it and see themselves as part of it."
Lead with the mechanism	"Closed-loop communication involves call-out, check-back and close."	"The loop only closes when the receiver says back what they heard and the sender confirms it — otherwise 'I said it' gets mistaken for 'we agreed it'."
Anchor in your own case	"Chronemics is the study of how time communicates meaning."	"Time was doing the talking: the meeting was pushed twice and finally given fifteen minutes at 7 p.m., which told the vendor exactly where he ranked."
Compress to a rule	Three paragraphs on the indirect strategy.	"Indirect is a judgement about the receiver's likely reaction, not about how uncomfortable the sender feels."

The transfer move — use a fresh example, not the class one

Class examples (IKEA, Ashwatthama, the Refrigerator, L'Atelier, Scott & Todd, Ford-Ferrari, Cosmos Electronics) are there so you **recognise** the concept. Reproducing them shows recall. Supplying your own

parallel example shows **transfer**, which is what separates the top band. Use the class example to name the concept in one clause, then immediately give your own: *"This is the Ashwatthama problem — a true statement missing the qualification that would have blocked the wrong inference. In my own case, 'the client approved the budget' was read as the full annual budget when only Phase 1 had been signed."* Part C6 has a bank of fresh examples ready to adapt.

Safe to reproduce as-is: the *name* of a concept, a scholar's name, the labels of a framework's parts (buffer / reasons / bad news / close), and short technical terms (kinesics, proxemics, chronemics, FTA, groupthink). You cannot paraphrase a proper noun, and you shouldn't try.

A4 • Symptom → concept lookup

The fastest route from "here is what happened" to "here is what to call it". Scan the left column for what the prompt (or your own story) actually describes; the right column gives you the concept labels to build the answer from.

What the situation looks like	Concepts to name (session)
Message was clear but landed completely differently	Interpretive model; "we create meaning, we don't receive it"; decoding; psychological noise; assumptions vs behaviour (S1)
The words were fine but the relationship soured	Content vs relational dimension; face-threatening act; facework; confirming messages (S1, S7)
Two people arguing about what each <i>thinks the other thinks</i>	Levels of perception; the "And Stance"; third story (S1, S8)
A change was announced clearly and nothing happened	Compliance vs acceptance; Miller's five conditions (backing, accessibility, specificity, cultural receptivity, propitiousness); Barrett's five practices; linear vs interpretive strategy (S2)
The organisation is being blamed publicly	Benoit's five repair strategies — deny, evade, reduce offensiveness, corrective action, apologise (not ranked); plural stakeholders; interpretive and critical lenses (S2)
"Consultation" that changed nothing	Critical lens — whose interests the framing serves, whether feedback can influence the decision; the suggestion-box test (S2)
The recommendation was buried; nobody acted	Audience memory curve; buried conclusion; point-first vs build-up; thinking vs structuring (S3)
Argument sounded plausible but didn't hold up	Logical defects — hasty generalisation, false cause, either/or, circular reasoning, false analogy, skirting the issue; claim-reason-evidence; Toulmin warrant (S3)
Junior person spoke but was ignored / talked over / re-attributed	Floor: invitation, entry, continuity, audibility, credibility, uptake; legitimacy; power distance; psychological safety (S3, S7, S10)
The same event described two ways to two audiences	Framing; words activate interpretation; social construction of reality (S3, S9)
Said the right thing, body said otherwise	Contradicting function; congruence; leakage; "when channels conflict the receiver believes the body" (S4)
Room / seating / office / lateness sent a signal	Proxemics (fixed vs semi-fixed space); chronemics; artefacts; environment as message (S4)
Someone was judged from one gesture	Cue-expectation-inference; read the cluster not the cue; baseline problem; the Mehrabian 7-38-55 misuse (S4)
Manager heard it and did nothing	Hearing is not listening; Steil's LAW (ability + willingness); the five pitfalls — haste, defensiveness, invisibility, exhaustion, inaction (S5)
Bad news never reached the top	Information bubble; success theatre; filtered upward communication; macro listening climate; grapevine (levelling, sharpening, assimilating) (S5)
Feedback was given and rejected / triggered defensiveness	Sandwich failure; ask-tell-ask; bridge; behaviour→impact formula; relevant / no surprises / engaged; giver's own emotions distorting the message (S6)
Someone avoided asking how they were doing	Fear of feedback; maladaptive responses (procrastination, denial, brooding, jealousy, self-sabotage); reframing; the four-step proactive process (S6)
Team talked constantly and still missed things	More is not better; quality over quantity; unique information; "everybody knows" bias; automaticity; closed-loop / the convey (S7)
Team agreed too fast; nobody dissented	Conformity; group polarisation (Sunstein); groupthink conditions & symptoms; devil's advocacy; dialectical inquiry; misgivings meeting (S7)
One person knew the thing and didn't share it	Unique information; information hoarding when hoarding is rewarded; psychological safety; handoff risk (S7)
Conversation was postponed and then exploded	Cost of avoidance is systematically under-weighted; avoidance is itself a communication act; the hand-grenade image (S8)
The stated issue wasn't the real issue	Three conversations — what happened / feelings / identity; identity conversation in disguise (S8)
Bad news delivered bluntly, or so gently it was missed	Direct vs indirect strategy; buffer-reasons-bad news-close; cushioning techniques; the implied-refusal risk; clarity is the first responsibility (S8)
An apology made things worse	Weak vs strong apology; conditional wording; naming the problem vs naming your regret; empathy is not accepting their account (S8)
Good idea, wrong audience, rejected	Conger's four failure modes; frame for common ground; the four-step process; Sussman's frame; head-heart-hands (S9)

Facts presented, minds unchanged	Beliefs / attitudes / opinions (Rokeach); aim where movement is possible; emotionally-acquired positions resist rational argument; the retraction problem (S9)
Persuasion worked in the room, decayed by Monday	Durability: refute-commit-forewarn; one-sided vs two-sided argument; reinforcement to prevent backsliding (S9)
Deal collapsed after the contracts arrived	High vs low context (Hall); oral vs written agreement; goodwill vs expertise credibility; Ford-Ferrari (S10)
Directness read as rudeness / "yes" didn't mean yes	Message structure by context; face-saving; connotation (<i>hai, mañana</i>); semantics (<i>kibun, sissu</i>); saying "no" across cultures (S10)
Deadline slipped and nobody seemed troubled	Monochronic vs polychronic time; locus of control (internal/external, <i>insha'allah, bahala na</i>); realistic objective & timeframe (S10)
Assumed the foreign colleague thought like you	Universality myth; Burger & Bass finding; ethnocentrism; convergence at structure, divergence in behaviour (Child, Laurent) (S10)

A5 • Sentence architecture that scores

Every analytical paragraph should be able to answer: *which concept, which moment, so what, now what*. Four shapes that do this reliably:

Paste-ready shapes (swap the bracketed parts)

- **Diagnose:** "What looks like [surface reading] is better described as [concept] — [one-line mechanism]. The evidence is [specific detail from the case/experience]."
- **Attribute:** "[Author]'s account of [concept] explains this: [mechanism in your words]. In this episode that shows up as [detail]."
- **Contrast two frameworks:** "[Framework A] would read this as [X]; [Framework B] would read it as [Y]. The second is the better fit here because [specific feature of the situation]."
- **Counterfactual redesign:** "Run again, I would [specific action] — not because [obvious reason], but because [concept] predicts that [consequence]."
- **Concede then hold:** "The cost of this is [real cost]. I would still choose it, because [priority], and I would offset it by [mitigation]."
- **Level-shift (the mark-winner):** "At the individual level this is [skill issue]. But the same failure recurred three times, which makes it a [norm / incentive / channel] problem rather than a personal one."

A6 • What loses marks

Trap	Fix
Narrating without analysing (Part 1 swallows the answer)	Hard-stop the narrative at the word limit. Every analytical paragraph must contain a concept label in bold or underlined.
Concept-dropping without applying ("this shows groupthink")	Always add the evidence sentence: which behaviour, by whom, when.
Copying a definition from the reading	Use the <i>say-it-your-way</i> column; transform again with A3.
Using the 7% / 38% / 55% figure as a general law	Mehrabian tested judgements of <i>attitude</i> from <i>conflicting</i> single-word cues. Keep the insight (body wins a conflict), drop the arithmetic — and say so. Noting the misuse scores.
Attributing high/low context or mono/polychronic time to Hofstede	Both are Edward Hall's. Ch. 12 gets this wrong; the class slides flag it. Correct attribution is a visible marker of careful reading.
Treating conflict, silence, or indirectness as automatically bad	Each has a legitimate managerial use. Say when it is productive and when it tips over.
Recommending "communicate more"	The teams reading says this directly fails. Recommend <i>quality</i> : unique information, closed loops, named channel owners.
One-layer recommendations (train the manager)	Add the structural layer: norms, incentives, channel design, psychological safety, who owns the boundary.
Missing the stated minimum word count	Calibrate with A2. A short answer is capped no matter how good.

PART B

Session notes

Each session opens with **the spine** — the single idea the session is built on — then a **concept bank** you can scan under time pressure, then the material that appeared in class, then reading-only depth, then how to turn it into an answer. Sources are named throughout so you can attribute in the exam.

SESSION 1

Core Concepts of Communication

The spine: communication is not the sending of information — it is the achievement of *sufficiently shared meaning* between two parties in a specific context. A sender controls content far more than interpretation, which is why a technically clear message routinely fails.

Sources: Session 1 class deck · O'Hair, Friedrich & Dixon, *Strategic Communication in Business and the Professions*, ch. 1 "Communication in Organizations" (Reading 1-2.1).

1 • The interactive communication process

Element	Exam definition / function
Source / sender	Creates the message and decides what to communicate and how.
Encoding	Converts an idea into words, tone, gesture, symbols or other signals.
Channel	The medium the message travels through: email, chat, call, meeting.
Noise	Any physical, psychological or situational factor that distorts reception or interpretation. Three types: <i>external</i> (construction outside, a bad line, an open-plan floor) · <i>physiological</i> (tired, hungry, ill, in pain — the 7 p.m. review after a 14-hour day) · <i>psychological</i> (thoughts, mood, bias and prejudice — an employee already angry reads a neutral remark as criticism). Bias against a speaker is noise.
Decoding	The receiver's process of interpreting what arrives.
Receiver	Anyone who picks up the message, intended or not. "Sidestream listening" — unintended receivers — is a real risk, and technology multiplies it.
Feedback	The response that shows the sender what meaning or action actually landed.
Context	Timing, place, culture, relationship and history that shape meaning. Four kinds in the reading: physical, chronological, cultural, social.

Exam-ready line. Communication is interactive rather than one-way: both parties encode, decode and give feedback, while context and noise determine how much shared meaning is actually achieved.

2 • Shared meaning is the real outcome — and it comes in degrees

Shared meaning exists when sender and receiver interpret a message *similarly enough* to coordinate understanding and action. It is not all-or-nothing. A message can be transmitted perfectly accurately and still produce different interpretations, because receivers bring different histories, interests and expectations.

Class example — IKEA

Ingvar Kamprad's phrase "**freedom with responsibility**" is passed down through managers to new employees. The wording stays stable; each retelling and each employee's prior experience shapes how the idea is understood and enacted. **The class point: a message can stay constant while shared meaning varies.**

Your own version (use this, not IKEA, to show transfer): a consulting firm tells teams to "take ownership." One manager reads it as freedom to make client decisions without approval; another reads it as being accountable *after* seeking approval. Identical phrase, partial shared meaning, because each team decodes "ownership" through a different local culture.

3 • Context changes meaning before the words do — class-only framework, high value

The session separates three layers. Most students only analyse the third.

Layer	The question it answers	What determines it
Context 1 — wider context	Is there a message at all? Does this event even count as a signal?	Organisational culture and climate; what normally counts as meaningful here.
Context 2 — individual context	How should this message be read?	The relationship, the timing, the history, and the receiver's prior experiences.
Content	What is the message literally saying?	The words or explicit symbols the sender chose.

Class example — "Mr Y has moved from Sales to Customer Support"

With one context, the move reads as **elevation**: Y is a strong performer and customer retention is strategically important. With another, it reads as a **managed exit**: Y has repeatedly missed targets and similar transfers have preceded exits. **The sentence is unchanged; context reverses the reading.**

Your own version: "Please meet me at 4 p.m. to discuss the project." After a successful client presentation it sounds like recognition. After two missed milestones and a tense morning exchange, the identical line sounds disciplinary. Content is stable; Context 2 flips the inferred intent.

Exam-ready line. A sender controls content far more than interpretation. Effective managerial communication therefore has to carry enough *context* to narrow the range of reasonable readings.

4 • The sender's half of the problem — class-only, three ready-made recommendations

- **Say why, not only what.** Stating intent usually resolves ambiguity better than adding more factual detail.
- **Name the reading you do *not* want.** "This is not a performance warning — I want your input before we finalise the process."
- **Ask what landed, not "is that clear?"** Use a behavioural check: "*What will you do first?*" or "*How are you reading this decision?*"

These three lines are among the most directly usable recommendations in the whole course. Any case where a clear message failed can end with one of them.

5 • Why communication fails

The class deck lists **eight** failures and treats **communication anxiety** and **cultural barriers** as cross-cutting issues that intensify any of the eight. The reading lists all ten as a flat set. Either is defensible — say which framing you are using.

Failure	Meaning	Example	Managerial fix
Inadequate information	Not enough detail to act correctly. Managers sometimes withhold "to avoid confusing them"; people then source it elsewhere.	"Client wants changes" with no scope or deadline.	Specify what, why, owner, deadline and constraints.
Information overload	Too much material obscures what matters. Managers over-send to be safe, so the important item gets ignored.	A 45-page report forwarded when the team needs three decisions.	Prioritise; summarise; separate need-to-know from reference.
Poor-quality information	Unclear, vague, jargon-heavy, outdated, disorganised or unusable.	"Optimise customer touchpoints strategically" with no concrete task.	Precise, plain, actionable language.
Poor timing	The correct message arrives too late to act on — or so early it is set aside and forgotten.	A budget cut announced after teams have committed vendor spend.	Communicate early enough for action; choose the moment.
Lack of feedback / follow-up	No check that meaning or action landed; the sender waits, then re-sends.	A new process is sent and nobody ever checks whether teams adopted it.	Ask for evidence of decoding or action; close the loop.
Problems with channels	The medium is wrong for the sensitivity, complexity or interaction the message needs.	Performance criticism given in a group chat; role eliminations sent to a large distribution list.	Match channel richness and privacy to the message.
Incompetent communication	Weak skill damages meaning and credibility.	A client update full of unexplained shorthand and typos.	Adapt language to audience and professional context.
Ineffective goal-setting	Goal is vague, unrealistic, or lacks method and resources. Too low wastes the opportunity; too high and the audience dismisses it.	"Improve engagement immediately" with no metric or plan.	Set specific, feasible goals; define responsibility and resources.
+ Communication anxiety	Nervousness hampers thinking, speaking, gesturing and listening — including anxiety about new technology.	An employee avoids the new collaboration tool and keeps emailing.	Identify the situations that trigger it; build competence in the channel.
+ Cultural barriers	Bias, accent-based judgement, and reluctance to ask a different-culture sender to repeat.	A colleague nods through an instruction she did not catch.	Build explicit confirmation into the exchange (links to S7 and S10).

Exam use: this list is the fastest way to generate three or four *distinct* causes in a case answer instead of one vague one. Pick three that fit, evidence each, and prioritise the root cause.

6 • Four lenses on organisations

Lens	Core idea	What it explains	Example
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Classical	Structure, rules, control. Taylor's scientific management (science not rule of thumb; harmony not discord; cooperation not individualism; maximum output; developing workers to their greatest efficiency) and Weber's bureaucracy. Weber's three authority types: charismatic (personal qualities), traditional (history, succession, norms), rational-legal (rules and procedure — the basis of bureaucracy). Communication goes by the book, strictly up and down, no level-skipping.	Best when precision and repeatability matter; reads as rigid and impersonal elsewhere. Organisation as machine.	A bank's compliance approval chain for high-value transactions.
Humanistic	Worker needs, relationships, motivation. Mayo's Hawthorne studies: productivity rose with <i>attention</i> , not lighting — informal groups, camaraderie, supervisors' interest and recognition beat economic incentives. McGregor's Theory X (people dislike work, must be coerced, prefer direction, want security) vs Theory Y (work is as natural as rest or play, people self-direct, seek responsibility, and creativity is widely distributed). The human-resources refinement: happy and properly resourced, not happy alone.	Highlights participation, trust and motivation.	A manager invites frontline staff to redesign shift handovers rather than imposing a process.
Systems theory	von Bertalanffy . Three ideas: interdependency (change one part, the rest moves), synergy (the whole exceeds the sum of isolated efforts), environment (the outside world shapes the inside). Open systems let information, people and ideas cross the boundary; closed systems seal themselves off and get overtaken.	Explains ripple effects and external influence. Boundary-spanning matters (straight to S7).	A delivery delay cannot be fixed by sales alone because procurement, warehousing, logistics and customer service are linked.
Organisational culture	"The social or normative glue" — shared values and beliefs. Components: values · rites and rituals · heroes · communication networks · norms · stories, myths and legends · climate .	Explains "how things are really done" beyond the formal chart, and why a system that works in one firm fails in another.	A startup celebrates employees who challenge founders, creating a norm that dissent is safe.

Class synthesis — IKEA through all four lenses

Strict product and quality rules developed in Sweden (**classical**) · responsibility pushed down to employees, "freedom with responsibility" (**humanistic**) · global coordination, the worldwide network and "build-up teams" who arrive before a store opens (**systems**) · managers acting as "ambassadors" carrying Kamprad's vision and norms to new employees (**culture**). **One organisation can be validly read through all four lenses** — which is the point of the question when it appears.

Five components of communication skill (O'Hair, for the information age): **creative insight** (asking the right questions) · **sensitivity** (attending to others' needs, listening empathetically, monitoring reactions) · **vision** (a point to convey) · **shared meaning** (connecting on their level) · **integrity** (if people trust you they believe you; if trust is damaged, communication skill will not save the message).

7 · The rest of the S1 concept bank

Concept	Say it your way	Where it bites
Content vs relational dimension	Every message says something about the topic <i>and</i> something about the relationship — status, respect, closeness, power.	"You forgot to check your messages." Content: a fact. Relational: concern, or reprimand, or a claim to authority. Fights are almost always about the second while pretending to be about the first.
Interpretive model	We don't receive meaning, we make it — from our perceptions, assumptions and the situation.	"This is a good idea" → heard as genuine interest, or as a brush-off. A professor's "Interesting." Use whenever intent and effect diverge.
Assumptions vs behaviour	You can see what someone does; you can never see why. So you supply a why — usually your own.	Silent employee → manager assumes unprepared; reality is he is repeatedly cut off by seniors. The gap between observed behaviour and imputed motive is where most conflict starts.
Common ground	Communication works only on the stock of assumptions two people already share.	"Make the deck more strategic" means two different things to the two people in the room, and neither knows it.
Levels of perception	Three floors: what I think · what I think you think · what I think you think I think.	"I think my idea is good" → "I think you don't like it" → "I think you know that I think you don't like it." People respond to floor three, which is invented.
Irreversibility	You cannot un-send. Retractions sit on top of the original; they don't replace it.	Pairs with the persuasion finding (S9) that corrections rarely dislodge the original story.
Intentional & unintentional	You communicate whether you mean to or not.	The bridge into S4: silence, delay and stillness are messages.

Communication competence

Reading the audience and adjusting — not being articulate.

Four parts: understanding the audience · adaptability (language, tone, level of detail, examples, pace, medium) · empathy / perspective-taking · self-monitoring.

Drop-in lines — Session 1

- ▶ "The message was sent competently; what failed was shared meaning, which is an outcome and not a property of the sender."
- ▶ "Content was stable across both readings. Context 2 — the relationship and the history — is what reversed the meaning."
- ▶ "Before the wording mattered, Context 1 had already decided whether this even counted as a signal."
- ▶ "The dispute was carried on the content dimension but fought on the relational one."
- ▶ "I could observe the behaviour but not the assumption behind it, so I supplied one — my own."
- ▶ "We were not disagreeing about the facts; we were each responding to what we imagined the other believed."
- ▶ "Psychological noise did more damage than any external interference: he had already decided what I was going to say."
- ▶ "I asked 'is that clear?', which only ever returns a yes. The useful question was 'what will you do first?'"
- ▶ "I said what, and never said why — and intent would have resolved the ambiguity that more detail could not."
- ▶ "Read through the systems lens this was never a sales problem; procurement, logistics and support were all inside the loop."

Anticipated questions

- *Why did a clear message still fail?* → Don't say "poor communication." Use **Context 1 / Context 2 / Content** → decoding → shared meaning as a degree → the sender's half (say why, name the reading you don't want, ask what landed).
- *A case lists several communication problems.* → Classify under the eight failures, evidence each, and **prioritise the root cause** rather than listing all of them flat.
- *Compare organisational approaches / analyse this organisation.* → Four lenses, each highlighting a different mechanism, then the IKEA-style point that one organisation can be validly read through all four — and that the lens you choose determines the fix you propose.
- *"Communication is the construction of meaning, not its transfer." Discuss.* → Interactive model → interpretive model → levels of perception → shared meaning in degrees → managerial implication: the competence test is "how is this likely to be understood?", not "was I clear?"

SESSION 2

Strategic Communication

The spine: strategic communication tries to align stakeholders with organisational direction — but the source cannot manufacture acceptance. The receiver decides what the message means and whether to accept it. **Compliance can be imposed; acceptance must be earned.**

Sources: Session 2 class deck · *Organizational Communication: Perspectives and Trends* (Sage), ch. 13 "Strategic Communication" (Reading 1-2.2).

1 • Chaffee's three models of strategy

Model	Definition	Best analytical use	Example
Linear	Strategy = integrated decisions and plans that set and achieve goals. Top management analyses, chooses, then communicates the plan to gain acceptance. Rests on the older machine-like notion of rational control.	When goals and choices can be specified in advance.	HQ decides to exit a low-margin product line and communicates the implementation plan.
Adaptive	Strategy = continuous coalignment of the organisation with its environment — matching opportunities and risks outside to capabilities and resources inside. The organisation is an open system; feedback is central. Communication is not just messages but all the information exchange the adaptation requires.	In uncertain, fast-moving environments.	A food-delivery company changes its city rollout weekly based on demand, regulation and driver supply.
Interpretive	Strategy = the social construction of reality, via cooperative agreements between individuals with free will. The work is managing meaning — supplying orienting metaphors and frames of reference through which stakeholders understand the organisation.	When identity, legitimacy and stakeholder understanding are what is actually at stake.	A university merger requires faculty, students and alumni to build a shared meaning of the new institution — not merely accept a plan.

Exam-ready line. The three models coexist: management may set a linear plan, adapt it through feedback, and simultaneously negotiate how stakeholders interpret the change. Chaffee argues they are interrelated and may form a hierarchy of complexity, with organisations evolving from linear to adaptive to interpretive.

2 • Audience, source and transaction

- **The audience is plural.** Stakeholders are not only shareholders, employees and customers but government, media, activist groups, special-interest coalitions, communities — anyone who can affect or be affected by the organisation. Different groups interpret the same message through different interests.
- **The source is rarely one person.** Executives authorise the strategy, but communication teams, managers and advisers shape the message before it reaches audiences. The GEC-RMC case: executives set the turnaround strategy, then created a 15-person strategic-communication team drawn from across the smaller company, which interviewed 200+ employees to build the change-communication programme. The strategy was top-down; the communication programme was participatory — and that is why it worked.
- **Communication is a transaction, not a line.** It *looks* linear because management sets the objective, but sources gain compliance only through receivers' own choices, and receivers shape the message that reaches them.

Exam-ready line. Compliance can be imposed; acceptance must be earned. A strategically "correct" message can still fail if stakeholders do not grant it legitimacy or meaning. **There is no universal formula that guarantees receivers' choices will match the source's intentions.**

3 • Internal communication — four functional areas

Area	Purpose	Example
Orientation & indoctrination	Onboarding into policies, procedures, operating philosophy, structure, role and values — then continuous socialisation that builds an internal image and reinforces specific beliefs and practices.	New analysts learn not only the expense rules but the firm's norm of escalating client risk early.
Morale & satisfaction	Recognition and relationship-building aimed at members' self-concept, interpersonal relationships and attitudes toward the organisation.	A plant head publicly recognises a team for stopping production to report a safety defect.

Compensation & benefits	Legally required disclosure (ERISA) plus communication that helps people actually understand and use benefits — complicated by a diverse workforce whose expectations differ.	HR explains a revised insurance plan through targeted sessions for different employee groups.
Organisational change & development	Mergers, acquisitions, restructuring, downsizing, reengineering. High-stakes, and often received cynically because change so often arrives as "flavour-of-the-day" management fashion.	A division consolidation communicated with role impact, timeline, decision logic and two-way Q&A.

4 • Miller (1997) — five conditions for strategic change

Condition	Meaning	How the failure shows up in a case
Backing	The people who authorise the change visibly support it.	Senior leaders announce a change, then disappear the moment resistance begins.
Accessibility	Managers understand what they are working toward.	Middle managers cannot explain the new operating model in their own words.
Specificity	Planning is detailed enough to act on.	Employees know the goal but not the roles, milestones or decision rights.
Cultural receptivity	Those affected are receptive enough to facilitate it.	A high-control culture is handed a sudden empowerment initiative.
Propitiousness	Favourable circumstances — bluntly, some luck.	A well-planned launch collides with an unexpected external crisis.

All of it assumes the organisation also has the experience, resources, structure and flexibility to manage implementation.

Exam use: this is the cleanest checklist in the course for diagnosing a failed change programme — run the five and name which are missing.

5 • Barrett (2002) — what effective employee communication looks like

- **Management is involved and responsible** — top and middle management own communication rather than being merely its subject. Roberts calls executive involvement the single most critical factor, and adds: cascade through every level of management.
- **Integrated with strategy** — communication professionals are close to the issues and inside the strategic planning, not downstream of it.
- **Consistent but targeted** — messages reinforce strategic objectives to all employees, adapted to each audience yet consistent across them.
- **Face-to-face privileged** — use all appropriate media, but personal presence is favoured over print and electronic, especially when stakes are high. Roberts' qualifier: content matters more than the medium.
- **Assessed formally and frequently** — measure whether it worked rather than assuming it did. Roberts adds a fifth: coordinate internal and external programmes toward the same goals.

The caution the reading itself supplies

These practices may be **necessary** for successful strategic initiatives, but that does not make them **sufficient**. Effectiveness advocates tend to blame failed initiatives on ineffective communication and claim there are "best practices" — the interpretive lesson is that there aren't guaranteed ones. Smith & Eisenberg's Disneyland study is the standing counter-example: Walt Disney's "family" metaphor was adopted so thoroughly that employees extended it to themselves and cast themselves as caretakers of the founding vision. When management later tried to redefine the metaphor to support cost containment ("families sometimes have to make sacrifices"), employees rejected the new version and read the bottom-line view as a breach of Disney's caring philosophy — culminating in a 22-day strike. **Management does not control the meaning of its own metaphors.**

6 • Benoit (1995) — five image-repair strategies

Benoit's premise: what matters is not whether the organisation is responsible but whether relevant audiences **believe** it is responsible for an offensive act.

Strategy	What it does	How to evaluate it in an answer
Deny	Reject responsibility entirely.	Only if the denial is credible. A false denial destroys trust permanently.
Evade responsibility	Shift or diffuse it: accident, provocation, good intentions, another party's failure.	May reduce blame, but easily reads as excuse-making.
Reduce offensiveness	Acknowledge the event but minimise its severity or harmfulness.	Risks angering affected stakeholders when the harm is obvious.
Corrective action	Fix the problem and commit to preventing recurrence.	Most useful when stakeholders need evidence of future protection.
Apologise	Accept responsibility fully and seek forgiveness.	The strongest accountability signal when responsibility is clear.

The point the class made explicitly

These strategies are not ranked. There is no universal "best" response. Fit depends on what the audience already believes — which is why the analysis has to start from stakeholder perception, not from a hierarchy of virtue.

Class exercise — the delayed festive-season deliveries

The retailer's statement mixes **evasion** ("our shipping partner"), **reduction of offensiveness** ("delays happen at this time of year"), **corrective action** ("we are reviewing partner contracts") and **apology**. The task: identify which clauses worsen the situation for which stakeholders, then rewrite it in under 80 words.

Your own version: a fintech app has a six-hour outage. "A cloud provider failed" reads as evasion. A stronger combination acknowledges the impact, states what is known without speculating, offers corrective action (redundancy and monitoring) and apologises for the disruption — *in that order*, because acknowledgement before explanation is what stops the explanation sounding like a defence.

7 • Two lenses that critique your own recommendation

Lens	The core question	What to look for
Interpretive	How will different stakeholders make meaning from this message?	Different interests; whether dialogue is repeated; whether consensus is genuinely built or merely declared. Strategic consensus (Rapert et al.) does not mean everyone agrees — it means members have constructed a <i>common understanding of what the strategy is</i> , and it is critical to implementation. Hendry: a decision must not only be communicated but re-communicated , and continually refined through dialogue, because speech is ephemeral and even texts are short-lived.
Critical	Whose interests does this framing serve, and is the "dialogue" real?	Power, accountability, vague commitments, and whether feedback can actually influence action. "We are reviewing partner contracts" may sound accountable and be pure performance unless responsibility and timing are named.

The class used *The Office's* "Health Care" scene to force three questions: who is the source? which Miller condition is missing? and **is a suggestion box dialogue, or merely the appearance of dialogue?** That last question is the critical lens in one line, and it works on almost any consultation exercise in a case.

Class case — DRW, "Two Months of Silence"

Plant managers receive an email from a VP they have never met, demanding prior sign-off on something. **They do not openly refuse. They simply submit nothing.** The sender saved travel time and believed the email was perfectly clear; two months later there is no action at all.

What it demonstrates: correctness and formal authority are not sufficient for acceptance. Reading the failure through Miller — *backing* and *cultural receptivity* are absent — and through Barrett — *face-to-face was not privileged* and *nothing was assessed* — gives you a complete diagnosis without ever saying "poor communication". **Your own version:** a retail CEO emails stores that discount exceptions now need regional approval. Store managers understand the rule perfectly and quietly keep using old practice because they believe it will damage customer relationships. The linear message is clear; cultural receptivity, dialogue and feedback are weak.

8 • The external-communication block — reading depth, lower class priority

Calibrate before you memorise this. The class deck *names* image building / PR, issues management, risk communication and crisis planning, but keeps only the **repair-strategy framework** at the level of what managers actually say. Do not overbuild an answer on this block from the slides alone. It is here because the reading covers it and a question could reach for it — treat it as depth to deploy if the case demands it, not as core.

Topic	Content
Image building	Creating the identity an organisation wants its publics to perceive — cultivating the impression that a set of positively valued features defines its essential character. Usually a public-relations function, alongside media relations, marketing, publicity and internal communication.
Issues management	"The organised activity of identifying emerging trends, concerns or issues likely to affect an organisation in the next few years and developing a wider and more positive range of responses." Ewing: the horizon is typically 18–36 months before legislation or regulation becomes likely. Tracking techniques: trend extrapolation • trend impact analysis • scanning • monitoring • scenario writing . Two possible actions follow: organisational change (adaptive — GE's "ecomagination", adapting to climate change rather than denying it) or issues advocacy (arguing your position publicly — which, unlike bland image-building, addresses specific controversial issues to influence political decisions).

Post's modes of corporate response	Two axes: the firm's stake in the status quo, and the perceived legitimacy of critics' complaints. Low stake / low legitimacy → avoidance . High stake / low legitimacy → stonewalling (cover-ups, distortions). Low stake / high legitimacy → accommodation . High / high → collaboration with critics . The warning: executives' <i>perception</i> of legitimacy may have nothing to do with the issue's actual impact, which is exactly why issue tracking exists.
Risk vs crisis	Risk = the chance of loss <i>before</i> it happens; a crisis is the event a risk produces. Barton's definition: "a major, unpredictable event that has potentially negative results and may significantly damage the organisation," plus urgency, media observation and interruption of normal operations. Risk communication manages the divide between expert (quantitative) and lay (qualitative) judgement — and lay audiences weight involuntary risks far more heavily, even when a voluntary risk carries larger consequences.
Sturges — match the message to the stage	Internalising before (build positive opinion) → instructing as it becomes imminent and breaks (tell people what to do) → adjusting as it subsides (help people cope) → back to internalising . The common error is assuming all crisis communication has one objective and all publics take one strategy.
Englehart — five planning steps	Identify potential crises → evaluate impact, including public response (the worst-case scenario technique) → assign specific responsibility and one spokesperson ("if you manage crisis by committee, you are doomed to failure") → put the plan in writing, but not too much → rehearse with drills .
Cosmology episode	The moment when every existing way of making sense of the situation fails at once. Red River flood, 1997 : officials stayed locked in a "certainty-seeking" mode, treated the National Weather Service gauge forecast as absolute, and communicated that false certainty onward; the crest topped the dikes and 50,000 people were evacuated. The lesson : pre-existing sense-making structures produced inappropriately unequivocal predictions and degraded the whole region's crisis communication. Self-organising is the counterpart: new order, new interagency cooperation and new structures emerging out of the chaos.

Drop-in lines — Session 2

- ▶ "Compliance can be imposed; acceptance must be earned — and this message secured neither."
- ▶ "The plan was linear and the problem was interpretive: the work was not announcing the decision but renegotiating what the change meant."
- ▶ "Run against Miller's conditions, backing and cultural receptivity were both absent, which is why a clear instruction produced two months of silence."
- ▶ "Barrett's finding is that face-to-face should be privileged when stakes are high. This was a restructuring announced by email."
- ▶ "The statement mixes evasion with corrective action in a single paragraph, which lets stakeholders read the corrective action as an extension of the excuse."
- ▶ "Benoit's strategies are not ranked; the fit depends on what this audience already believes about responsibility."
- ▶ "Read critically, 'we are reviewing our processes' is accountability-shaped language with no owner, no date and no consequence attached."
- ▶ "The suggestion box is the appearance of dialogue, not dialogue — nothing in the process lets feedback change the decision."
- ▶ "Management authored the metaphor and then lost control of it, exactly as Disney's 'family' was extended by employees in a direction management never intended."

Anticipated questions

- *A change was communicated clearly and still failed. Why?* → Compliance vs acceptance → run Miller's five and name which are missing → run Barrett's five → add the transactional point that receivers shape the message → recommend a participatory communication design even where the strategy itself was not participatory (GEC-RMC).
- *Multiple stakeholder groups reacted differently to the same message.* → "The audience is plural" → interpretive lens → different interests produce different meanings → recommend targeted-but-consistent messaging with a genuine feedback route per group.
- *Evaluate this corporate statement after a public failure.* → Tag each clause with a Benoit strategy → evaluate fit against what stakeholders already believe → note that the strategies are not ranked → rewrite, leading with acknowledgement and putting corrective action before apology only if responsibility is still contested.
- *Critique a communication plan.* → Interpretive lens (how will each group make meaning?) then critical lens (whose interests does the framing serve; can the promised dialogue actually influence the decision?). Finish with the Hendry point: a decision has to be re-communicated, not communicated once.

SESSION 3

Verbal Communication — Thinking → Structuring

The spine: clarity is *designed before it is worded*. Thinking and structuring solve different problems: thinking makes the conclusion deserve to be believed; structuring makes it findable. And word choice is never neutral — framing decides what the audience even sees.

Sources: Munter, "The Message: Structure", *Business Communication*, pp. 91–113 (Reading 3.1) · Bell & Smith, "A Process for Management Writing", pp. 53–79 (Reading 3.2) · class slides (Prof. Avani Desai), which add framing, floor and legitimacy.

The class opener — the Mahabharata assumption

Fact: Bhima kills an elephant named Ashwatthama. **Message:** Yudhishtira says "Ashwatthama is dead."
Assumption: Drona hears "my son is dead." **Consequence:** Drona lays down his weapons and is killed. **The gap:** what the communicator knew is not what the listener assumed — the missing qualification ("the elephant"), plus battlefield context and Drona's emotional state, did the work. **The managerial question it leaves you with:** *before you communicate, ask what your audience could reasonably assume from this.* A technically true statement can be a lie by omission of a qualifier.

Part 1 — Thinking (three moves, Munter)

Move	What it means	How to use it in an answer
1. Be aware of your assumptions	Assumptions are the foundation everything else rests on; change them and the whole structure changes. Awareness buys you two options: question it ("is this necessarily true? what if it isn't? what evidence would disprove it?") or state it explicitly ("this recommendation assumes that...").	The goal is not to eliminate assumptions but to know which ones your reasoning depends on. In a case: identify the load-bearing assumption nobody stated.
2. Draw valid conclusions	Deduction: general principle → specific case → conclusion. If the premises hold and the reasoning is sound, the conclusion <i>must</i> be true — so everything depends on the main principle being right. Induction: specific observations → pattern → general conclusion. The conclusion is only <i>likely</i> — so everything depends on the specifics being reliable, relevant and representative .	Say which one the arguer used and where it is exposed. "This is inductive and the sample is neither representative nor relevant — two acquaintances' jobs are not evidence about the profession."
3. Avoid logical defects	Three families: don't jump too fast, don't hide, don't oversimplify . Full list below.	Naming the specific fallacy is worth far more than saying "the logic was weak".

The logical defects, named

Defect	What it is	Example
Hasty generalisation	One observation treated as enough for a broad claim.	"Strategy X raised sales 13% in Atlanta — let's run it in Fairbanks."
False cause	Event 1 preceded event 2, therefore caused it. Other explanations never examined.	"Sales rose 42% as soon as we hired him."
Non sequitur / unrelated ideas	Causal words (therefore, because, thus) bridging statements with no causal link.	"She works for an international firm, so she can't be prejudiced."
Hidden questionable assumption	The argument rests on an unstated premise that wouldn't survive daylight.	"We'll market X in trade journals because we marketed Y there."
Skirting the issue	Evading the main point by attacking a minor one.	Workers allege unsafe conditions; management discusses a pay rise.
False analogy	Two things alike in one way assumed alike in others.	Skyscraper height / lightning → hierarchy depth / economic disaster.
Exaggeration (reductio)	Stretching the opponent's idea to absurdity to dismiss it.	"Cut 17 cents? Why not give them away?"
Irrelevant attack	Attacking the person instead of the idea.	"Anne mishandled the budget, so she can't chair this."
Popular appeal	Substituting a truism or patriotic sentiment for the specific case.	"It's un-American to buy that product."
Either/or	Two options presented as exhaustive.	"Open a new plant by spring or go bankrupt."
Catch-all explanation	One factor isolated and treated as the sole cause.	"The Edsel failed because of the push-button gear shift."
Circular reasoning	The conclusion used as its own support. (Bell & Smith)	"We need this process because it's how things are done here."

Class checklist before you communicate: separate facts from assumptions · ask whether the conclusion actually follows · look for missing evidence · consider an alternative explanation · ask what evidence would change the conclusion. Then: "*what would a sceptical listener challenge here?*"

Part 2 — Planning the writing (Bell & Smith's five questions)

Against the "**inspiration fallacy**" — the belief that the words will come if you wait. They don't; what comes is writer's block, which is almost always a missing plan. Contractors draw blueprints, pilots file flight plans; managers plan too.

Step	Question	Contents
1 Purpose	What am I trying to communicate?	Inform · describe · persuade (the circles overlap — you can have more than one). The manager's four checks: what should the audience know ? what should they feel ? what should they do ? will this serve more than one purpose? "Moving targets are hard to hit with arrows — or words."
2 Audience	To whom am I writing?	Primary vs secondary audience · similar or mixed · size → channel · what they know about you, your credibility · what they already know, should know, want to know · how feedback will reach you · situation and timing · what you want them to do. And the attitude move: hostile / neutral / friendly is partly a choice you make — imagine the neutral reader as a friend and the prose loosens.
3 Exploration	What ideas should I consider?	Two phases, kept apart: exploration (find and create ideas) then selection and organisation . Generate first, argue later. Tools: the idea circle (a pie you fill with wedges so no idea gets privileged too early) and the Classic Questions — why do others care? what are its parts/stages? what forces led to it? who is interested? how would things differ if it didn't exist? best/worst aspects? what larger movement is the background? principal benefits? if it fails, what barriers were to blame? how would you explain it to a ten-year-old? The class exercise ("should your company adopt a 4-day week?") used exactly these: why care / benefits / parts / barriers / forces / 10-year-old. Rule: generate first, do not argue for or against yet.
4 Patterns & outlines	How can I best arrange the ideas?	Find or invent the pattern — the "silver thread" through the chaos. Bell & Smith give 16 patterns of organisation : time · space · cause · emotion · logic · relative significance · hidden significance · perspectives · doubt · contrast · comparison · reputation · variety · opinions · preference · likelihood. Then a rough working outline (not necessarily I, A, 1 form) — outline phrases become headings and topic sentences.
5 Details & examples	How can I support my points?	Details are the " hidden persuaders ". Three roles: provide information · verify an assertion · illustrate an abstraction. Good examples are specific, clearly understandable, brief, focused . Guard against overclaim (the "100 dentists" of 4,532 surveyed) — qualify instead. Use a " shoehorn ": a directed transition telling the reader what the example contains and why it matters.

Part 3 — Structuring (Munter)

The basic architecture of a managerial message (class slide)

1 Communication objective — what must this message accomplish? → **2 Main message** — the single point they should leave with → **3 Supporting information** — the evidence, reasons and detail they need → **4 Desired action** — what they should think, decide or do next.
The order in which you discovered the information is irrelevant. The order of the final message must serve the audience.

Three rules for a sound idea hierarchy

- Each higher level summarises the level below.** The parent idea must generalise every child under it. Test: does the heading still cover the list after you add a point?
- Same level, same kind of idea.** Reasons with reasons, steps with steps, risks with risks. A mixed level is the commonest defect in student memos.
- Five to seven branches, no more.** Working memory holds five to seven points. More than seven means you have not finished grouping — group upward rather than listing everything you know.

A hierarchy that fails any of these reads as a list, not as an argument.

The Audience Memory Curve

Position	Recall	Use it for
Beginning	Highest	The conclusion, when the audience will accept it . Subject lines do the heavy lifting.
Middle	Lowest	Analysis and support — never the point. A buried conclusion is skipped, missed, or hunted for.
End	High	The conclusion, when the audience is likely to resist . Second-best home for your strongest evidence.

Beginning or end — never the middle. This, not habit, is the real reason people argue about where the recommendation goes.

One message, two possible structures

	Point-first (direct)	Build-up (indirect)
Shape	Recommendation → strongest reason → analysis/support	Shared concern or value → rejected alternative → recommendation + reason
Use when	Audience will agree, is busy or distracted, delegated the question to you, sees you as the expert, or the topic is uncontroversial. They want a clear-cut solution.	Audience is likely to disagree, is hostile or threatened, the topic is delicate, your initial credibility is low, or the reader is genuinely interested in your analytic process (R&D audiences).
Why it works	People take in ideas more easily when they have the top-level idea first — and it saves the reader's time.	Three mechanisms: least controversial points first (agree early, agree later) · present rejected alternatives before your recommendation (people don't reject ideas they feel they helped consider, and you look fair-minded) · strongest evidence last.
Cost	Reads as blunt to a resistant audience; hands opponents a target.	Wastes the audience's time. Use sparingly.

Munter's worked pair. Case 1, busy boss who delegated the decision: *"I recommend we cut back on the widget line. The main reason is that widgets lack long-term growth potential..."* Case 2, boss personally invested in the line: *"We don't want to sacrifice future profits for short-term gains. Therefore, although widgets contribute enormously to our current profits, we must consider cutting back on that line because of its lack of long-term growth potential..."* — opens on agreement, concedes the point she is proud of, lands the recommendation last.

Ordering the supporting ideas

First ask Minto's question: am I telling the reader *about* something, or telling them *to do* something?

- **Explanatory ideas** — top-level idea always first. Then order by **time** (history, steps in a process), by **components** (geography, divisions, floors — implies no priority), or by **importance** (requires a value judgement, so anticipate how your audience ranks things).
- **Action ideas** — trickier: consider the topic *and* your credibility *and* the audience's attitude. This is where direct vs indirect is decided.

Idea charts vs outlines — where the two readings disagree

	Bell & Smith: the numbered outline	Munter: the idea chart / issue tree
Form	Sequential I, A, 1, 2 — fixed before you draft	Visual upside-down tree (after Flower and Minto) you can see whole
Strength	Converts directly into headings and topic sentences; arranges what you already know	Easy to add, move or drop a branch; exposes missing links — it generates ideas, not just order
Best when	The content is settled and the document is long	You are still working out the argument

Flower's line, worth quoting in substance: a traditional outline only arranges facts you already have; an issue tree highlights missing links and helps you draw inferences. She also gives **"nutshelling"** — state the whole substance in two or three sentences, which forces you to separate major from minor ideas. Ewing's three tests for finding your second-level ideas: the two-minute street explanation · the expensive telegram · "if someone only skims this, what is the minimum they must learn?"

Claim — Reason(s) — Evidence (Bell & Smith, Fig. 2-5)

Element	Test	Trap
Claim	Specific and contestable — something that <i>can</i> be argued against. "Our company makes the most economical car" is a claim; "the most beautiful car" is an opinion dressed as one.	A vague claim can't be supported, so it can't be believed.
Reason	The "because" test — answers "why do you say so?" and is objectively linked to the claim.	Reasons too far from the claim, or personal rather than objective.
Evidence	Data, experiments, case studies, statistics, testimony, published research. Must be representative of the situation described.	A reason without evidence may not convince; evidence without a clear claim may not communicate.

Toulmin's model (in the same reading): claim · **data** (grounds) · **warrant** (the assumption linking data to claim) · **qualifier** (conditions under which the claim holds) · **rebuttal** (acknowledged deviations) · **backing** (support for the warrant when the warrant itself is contested). The fuel-efficient car: the claim rests on the warrant that the buyer wants to save money on fuel. If the buyer wants luxury, the warrant is weak and the whole argument loses traction — which is exactly Conger's "frame for common ground" (S9) arriving from a different direction.

Class-only material: framing, floor and legitimacy

This block is on the slides and in no single reading. It is the most distinctive content of Session 3 and therefore highly examinable.

Concept	Say it your way	Example / test
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Social construction of reality	Words don't sit in a vacuum — what a category means comes from the social setting it is used in (race, gender identity, sexual orientation, intersectionality).	A person's professional identity is read partly through socially constructed expectations attached to gender, class or language, not only through their qualifications.
Framing	Two true descriptions of the same event point attention in different directions.	The New Orleans flood captions: residents "finding bread and soda" vs a young man "looting a grocery store." Same act, two worlds.
Words activate interpretation	A word doesn't just name a thing, it switches on a set of associations.	"Tax relief" vs "tax cut." "Learning opportunity" vs "failure."
Form · Frame · Floor	The three underlying mechanisms of verbal communication. Form = how the argument is structured. Frame = how wording directs attention. Floor = who gets to speak and be taken seriously.	Form: Problem → Analysis → Options → Recommendation, rather than disconnected information. Frame: "learning opportunity" vs "failure". Floor: a junior may be permitted to speak and still be interrupted out of the conversation.
Gendered language	Language may not serve all speakers equally when some groups did not help shape it.	Mankind, manmade, manpower, manhandle. Mr vs Mrs/Miss encodes marital status for women only. Women often defined relationally to men; men have more autonomous linguistic status.

Framing analysis — five questions (the slide's own checklist)

- What does the term make **immediately visible**? · What does it put in the **background**?
- **Who appears to act?** (does the wording make one party the actor?)
- **Who benefits, suffers or disappears?**
- What **alternative wording** would redistribute attention?

Who gets the floor — seven tests

Test	The question	What failure looks like
Invitation	Is the person expected, permitted or actively invited to contribute?	A junior is allowed to speak but never asked.
Entry	Can they take a turn without being ignored, spoken over, or needing unusual assertiveness?	Repeatedly cut off by senior colleagues.
Continuity	Can they finish, or must they keep repairing interruptions and topic shifts?	The argument never reaches its second half.
Audibility	Is the contribution attended to, regardless of accent or style?	Technically clear, institutionally unvalued.
Credibility	Are they treated as knowledgeable <i>before</i> providing extraordinary proof?	Asked for evidence others were never asked for.
Uptake	Do others respond to the actual claim, preserve attribution, carry it into minutes, policy or action?	The idea survives; the attribution doesn't.
Consequences	Are the costs of speaking or challenging the same for everyone?	The same objection is "robust" from one person and "difficult" from another.

Why are some views accepted more than others? Formal authority · control of resources · seniority and kinship · gendered expectations · caste and class location · language capital (the value attached to particular languages, accents and registers) · employment position · interactional style · coalition and repetition · medium and procedure. **The framing question to carry:** *whose position is normalised, and who has to fight for theirs?*

Drop-in lines — Session 3

- ▶ "I had done the thinking but not the structuring, so the reader received my discovery sequence instead of my conclusion."
- ▶ "The recommendation sat in the middle of paragraph three — the weakest position on the page."
- ▶ "The reasoning was inductive and the sample was neither representative nor relevant."
- ▶ "The load-bearing assumption was never stated, so it was never tested."
- ▶ "Formally she had the floor; in practice she had invitation and entry but no continuity and no uptake."
- ▶ "Calling it a 'learning opportunity' rather than a 'failure' changed who in the room felt accused."
- ▶ "Both descriptions were accurate. They were not equivalent — one made an actor visible and the other made a victim."
- ▶ "I chose build-up rather than point-first, because my initial credibility with this audience was low and the recommendation contradicted a decision they were proud of."
- ▶ "The claim had reasons but no evidence, so it communicated without convincing."

Anticipated questions

- "*Thinking and structuring are different processes.*" *Explain and illustrate.* → The thinking three (assumptions, valid conclusions, logical defects) → the structuring three (hierarchy, placement, order) → the

synthesis line: if the thinking is messy, structure cannot rescue the message; if the structure is invisible, good thinking gets lost. Both are needed.

- *When should a manager put the recommendation first, and when last?* → Memory curve → the agree/disagree test → the three indirect mechanisms → Munter's widget pair → note the cost (indirect wastes time) and the ethical boundary (indirect is not concealment — a point that links to S8).
- *"Word choices do more than name things."* Discuss. → Framing · tax relief · the flood captions · the five framing questions · gendered language · then extend to floor and legitimacy: framing decides what is visible, floor decides whose framing gets adopted.
- *Analyse the reasoning in the following argument.* → Separate facts from assumptions → identify deduction vs induction → name the specific fallacies → apply claim-reason-evidence and locate the missing warrant.

SESSION 4

Non-Verbal Communication — the channel you cannot switch off

The spine: you are always transmitting. Non-verbal meaning arrives through eight channels at once, and when the channels disagree the receiver believes the body — which means congruence, not eloquence, is where credibility is spent or kept. And the meaning is *inferred*, never read off: intention is yours, inference is theirs.

Sources: O'Rourke, "Non-Verbal Communication", *Management Communication: A Case Analysis Approach*, pp. 253-276 (Reading 4.1) · Smeltzer et al., "Nonverbal Communication in Management", pp. 158-171 (Reading 4.2) · class slides (Prof. Avani Desai), which supply the eight-channel taxonomy, the organisational-channel table and the two "handle with care" warnings.

The mechanism: cue → expectation → inference

Step	What happens	Why it matters
Cue	The wordless thing you actually observed — a pause, folded arms, a glance at the door. This part the room shares.	The only objective element.
Expectation	What you hold to be normal, assembled from everyone you have ever watched. This part the room does not share.	Your baseline is personal history, not fact.
Inference	The meaning you assign. You cannot observe an attitude, so you build one.	Built from a cue you share and an expectation you don't — which is exactly why confident misreadings are so common.

The hinge (class slide): what you *intend* → what you *do* → what they *infer*. You are thinking hard about the deadline; you look away, go quiet and frown; they infer you are unwilling or hiding something. **You do not control the third box. You control the second — and only if you plan it.**

The eight channels (class taxonomy)

Channel	What it covers	What it signals at work
Kinesics	Posture, gesture, facial expression, movement	Attitude, emotion, engagement. Five gesture types below.
Oculesics	Gaze, eye contact, its duration and its withdrawal	Attention, confidence, interest, involvement, dominance, credibility — all culture-dependent.
Haptics	Touch — the handshake, the shoulder, and its absence	Warmth, support, dominance, familiarity, respect. Highly dependent on context, culture, relationship and professional boundaries.
Proxemics	Distance, seating, territory, who sits where	Status and hierarchy. Corner office vs open floor; head of table vs side; standing while others sit.
Chronemics	Time — lateness, duration, who is kept waiting	Priority and power. Fifteen minutes vs an hour; replying at 11 p.m.
Vocalics / paralanguage	Pitch, pace, volume, tone, vocal quality, pause, silence	Certainty and permission. The pause before "yes"; volume in disagreement; who is allowed silence.
Artefacts	Dress, objects, screens, what is on the table	Attention and belonging. Laptop open in a one-to-one; printed deck vs screen; what you wear to a plant visit.
Environment	The room itself — layout, lighting, furniture, whose office	Formality, hierarchy, who is at home and who is a guest.

Smeltzer's point, worth quoting in substance: in organisations, the loudest non-verbal channels are the ones with no body in them — space, time, artefacts and the room.

Kinesics up close — five kinds of gesture (Ekman's typology, in both readings)

Type	What it is	Example
Emblems	The one exception to "non-verbals only suggest meaning" — an emblem has a direct verbal translation, almost a dictionary entry. Works without words.	Thumbs-up, palm-out "stop", namaste, "time out".
Illustrators	Gestures that draw the thing you are describing.	Hands measuring a gap; fingers counting off three points.
Affect displays	Face and body reporting an emotion you did not choose to report; usually involves several body parts at once.	Scowl + upright + turned away + arms crossed = you know exactly what they think of the idea.
Regulators	The traffic signals of conversation — who speaks, who stops, when it ends.	Raised palm holding the floor; eyes handing over the turn; a nod that says keep going.
Adaptors	Self-soothing under pressure; adapting to a situation you can't act on.	Twisted ring, clicked pen, arms folded round yourself, a crossed leg making a small walking motion (the intention to leave).

The class line worth reusing: three of these you choose; two of them leak — *and those are the two being read.*

Six functions of non-verbal communication

Function	What it does to the words	Example
Repeating	Says the same thing again in another channel (not simultaneous — that's complementing).	"The room is that way," while pointing. A demonstration after a verbal description.
Substituting	Replaces the words entirely.	Raised palm instead of "wait". A thumbs-up across a loud factory floor.
Complementing	Adds a layer the words don't carry — warmth, gravity, ease.	"Well done" with a smile and a nod. A warm handshake welcoming someone back after illness.
Accenting	Marks one part as the important part.	The pause before "Friday". A desk pounded on the key number.
Contradicting	Sends the opposite of the words — and wins.	"I'm completely comfortable with the decision," said while visibly tense and avoiding eye contact.
Regulating	Controls the traffic: who speaks, who stops, when it ends.	Speaking louder or faster to keep a turn; looking directly at the listener to hand it over.

The structural point (class): five of these *help* the message — that redundancy is how meaning survives noise. One destroys it. Smeltzer frames the same idea as **communication redundancy**: because part of a message is predictable from the rest, it survives interference. Non-verbals are the main source of that redundancy.

The rule that matters

When the channels disagree, the receiver believes the body. "Yes — I'll have it on your desk by Friday" is *discarded*; the sigh, the delay and the eyes going to the door are *believed*. So the managerial question is never "did I say it clearly?" — it is **"did the rest of me agree?"** Smeltzer's version: when verbal and non-verbal disagree, credibility suffers; the non-verbals are the ones to trust.

Six principles of non-verbal communication (O'Rourke)

- It occurs in a context.** Folded arms may be disinterest on one occasion and introspection on another. DeVito: divorced from context it is impossible to say what any given non-verbal behaviour means.
- Behaviours come packaged.** Posture, gaze, gesture, expression, tone, pacing, muscle tone all happen at once. **Read the cluster, never the single cue.**
- All behaviour communicates.** You cannot not behave, so you cannot not communicate. Looking at the clock repeatedly says something whether you mean it to or not.
- It is governed by rules.** A few expressions (sadness, joy, contentment, astonishment, grief) are near-universal; most non-verbal behaviour is learned and cultural.
- It is highly believable.** We trust it even against the words — partly because so much of it (pupil dilation, vocal tension, pulse, sweating, muscle tone) is beyond voluntary control.
- It is metacommunicational.** It is communication *about* the communication — your handshake, tone and gaze tell us what you think of the person you've just met.

Three older categories that still appear in questions (O'Rourke, early studies): **sign language** (gestures, up to full deaf sign systems) · **action language** (movements not primarily meant to communicate but that do — walking out of a meeting) · **object language** (objects, materials, artefacts — jewellery, clothing, décor, cars, and our own bodies).

The dimensions in detail

Dimension	Content you can use
Proxemics — Hall's four zones	Intimate 0–18 in (contact to ~1.5–2 ft): psychologically close only; invasion produces withdrawal or a barrier, often without the person knowing why. Personal 18 in–4 ft: friends; strangers admitted briefly during introductions (watch the one-leg-forward stance and the retreat afterwards). Social 4–12 ft: most daily business; manager–employee relationships often start here and move inward as trust grows. Public 12 ft+: strangers, public speaking. Figures are averages and shift with culture, gender, situation, relationship, status and physical setting.
Fixed vs semi-fixed space	Fixed space (a large desk, a cubicle) reads as territory and barrier — going behind the boss's desk is a violation. Semi-fixed space (a conference table, movable chairs) connotes cooperation and shared responsibility. People stake territory by even spacing or by building small walls of notebooks, jackets and coffee cups. Managers who want open communication sit near their people, minimise status-heavy furniture, and discourage territoriality.
Strategic use of space	Space is allocated, and the allocation speaks: more is better than less, bigger than smaller, new than old, and proximity to the leadership reads as power. A large executive desk set apart says hierarchy; a round table with equal seating says openness.
Gender and distance	Men tend to keep larger personal-space bubbles and to take up more space with bodies and artefacts — a tendency often read as power. Women are more likely to allow closer approach and tolerate temporary intrusions.
Chronemics	Punctuality, waiting, deadlines, response time, duration of interaction. Cultures differ on all five (S10). Whether a 3:00 meeting starts at 3:00 is a cultural fact before it is a personal one.

Paralanguage / vocalics	Pitch, rate, volume, tone, vocal quality, pauses — plus onset (the gap between taking the turn and starting) and duration . A clear, firm, low-pitched voice reads as confidence and draws more attentive listening; nasal, shrill, quiet or harsh voices are devalued; filled pauses ("uh", "well") read as uncertainty.
Dress & artefacts	Dress is a large part of the first impression and often the key to initial credibility. The governing rule is fit the organisation's culture — conservative in financial institutions, forward in agencies, deliberately casual in tech. Be neither first nor last to adopt a fashion. Client-facing work justifies dressing up regardless of the internal norm. Artefacts (office design, contents, what is on the table) communicate hierarchy or accessibility.
Colour, smell, taste, sound	All carry meaning by association and convention: consistent brand colour to evoke an association · scent designed into a retail environment · food preferences signalling cultural identity and group membership · music and background noise shaping perceived atmosphere.
Silence — seven functions	Providing thinking time · hurting · isolating oneself · preventing communication · communicating agreement · communicating rejection · communicating nothing. Useful in an answer because it forces you to say which one it was.

Two things the class told you to handle with care

1 · The "93% non-verbal" claim

What gets repeated: 7% words, 38% tone, 55% body — quoted as if it governed all communication everywhere. You will meet it in interviews, on LinkedIn and in most corporate training decks. (Reading 4.2 repeats it; Munter's cross-cultural article cites Knapp's 65–90% in the same spirit.)

What Mehrabian (1967) actually tested: single words played against mismatched tone and photographs, with listeners asked to judge one thing only — *how the speaker felt about them*. It is a finding about decoding **attitude** from **conflicting** cues.

What to write: keep the insight — conflicting signals get resolved in favour of the body — and drop the arithmetic. Saying this explicitly is a cheap, visible mark.

2 · Leakage and the baseline problem

The catalogue: hand to the mouth, the nose rub, buttoning a coat mid-question, shifting the chair back, pitch climbing. Smeltzer lists the signals of deception across movement (hand-to-face contacts are the most common; gestures become fewer and closer to the body; the hand-shrug emblem roughly doubles), dress (manipulating clothing, tugging a collar), space (leaning or stepping back, barriers such as a bag on the lap) and voice (slower onset, longer and less specific answers, measurably higher pitch).

The condition everyone forgets: leakage is a *departure from that person's normal pattern*. **No baseline, no departure — and therefore nothing to detect.** This is what the small talk at the start of an interview is actually for. Read as a codebook rather than a comparison, the list becomes misleading. **You cannot detect deception in a stranger; you can only notice that someone has changed.** And even then, treat it as a reason to investigate further, not as a verdict.

O'Rourke reinforces this from the research side: Gifford found that people "read much into non-verbal cues that just isn't there, while missing much that is." Interviewers judged applicants' *social skills* fairly accurately and their *motivation* badly — the cues they used (smiling, gesturing, talking more) were not indicators of motivation at all. People get hired for the wrong reasons.

Designing the encounter — four levers (the class exercise)

Lever	Decisions to make before you walk in
Space (proxemics)	Which room. A desk is fixed space and reads as territory; a round table is semi-fixed and reads as shared. How far apart (Hall's zones). Whether anyone stands.
Time (chronemics)	What hour, what day. How long you book. Who arrives first. What happens in the opening sixty seconds and the closing ten.
Artefacts	What you wear. What is on the table. Paper or screen. Whose laptop is open. What is deliberately absent.
Body & voice	The first twenty seconds: posture, hands, where your eyes go, pace, volume, and where you place the silence.

Then the question that finishes the answer: **which single non-verbal choice could destroy this meeting?**

The limit: none of this codebook is universal

- **Eye contact** — sustained gaze reads as confidence in one setting and as disrespect toward a senior in another.
- **The Indian head tilt** — agreement, acknowledgement, or "go on", depending on who is watching.
- **Punctuality** — monochronic cultures spend time, polychronic cultures move through it.
- **Touch and distance** — the same handshake or shoulder-clasp reads as warmth, as intrusion, or as a status claim.

Drop-in lines — Session 4

- ▶ "The words were compliant; the channels were not. When they conflict the receiver believes the body, and that is what happened here."
- ▶ "I shared the cue with the room but not the expectation, so my inference was mine alone."
- ▶ "Nobody said anything about status. The seating did."
- ▶ "Chronemics carried the message: the meeting was rescheduled twice and finally given twelve minutes at the end of the day."
- ▶ "The laptop stayed open throughout, which is an artefact doing more work than anything either of us said."
- ▶ "I read a single adaptor as guilt. Without a baseline for that person, the reading had no basis."
- ▶ "I would keep Mehrabian's insight and drop the arithmetic: his study tested judgements of attitude from deliberately conflicting cues, not communication in general."
- ▶ "The silence was doing one of seven jobs; on the evidence it was preventing communication, not providing thinking time."
- ▶ "Everything except the script was designed — the room, the hour, the seating, what was not on the table."

Anticipated questions

- *"You cannot not communicate."* Discuss with managerial examples. → Principle 3 → action language → the organisational channels with no body in them (space, time, artefacts) → the design argument: since you are transmitting anyway, the only choice is whether the signals are the ones you meant.
- *How should a manager interpret non-verbal cues — and what are the limits?* → cue-expectation-inference → cluster not cue → context → baseline → culture → the Gifford finding that confidence outstrips accuracy → conclusion: treat non-verbals as hypotheses to test verbally, not as evidence.
- *Design the non-verbal environment for a difficult conversation.* → the four levers, each with a justification, then the "what could wreck it" paragraph. Link forward to S8 (timing: not Friday afternoon, not the night before a pitch) and S6 (private setting).
- *Evaluate the claim that 93% of communication is non-verbal.* → State what Mehrabian tested · what the claim gets wrong · what survives · why the corrected version is still managerially important (congruence is credibility).

SESSION 5

Listening

The spine: hearing is automatic, listening costs attention — and most listening failures are not skill failures at all. Steil's LAW splits it: **Listening = Ability + Willingness**. Ability is trainable in an afternoon; willingness is a decision, usually made before the conversation starts. And at senior levels, individual skill is not enough: the information reaching you is the most filtered in the building, so you need a system as well.

Sources: Bell & Smith, "Listening", *Business Communication*, pp. 161–171 (Reading 5.1) · Smeltzer et al., "Managerial Listening", ch. 7, pp. 155–173 (Reading 5.2) · class slides adding Yip & Fisher (HBR 2025), Bryant & Sharer (HBR 2021) and the two-dimensional model.

The class opener — The Refrigerator

A restaurant-chain manager is preparing for a busy weekend. At the morning meeting the kitchen supervisor reports that the main refrigerator has stopped holding temperature and that meat and dairy have been sitting unsafe for hours: "*We should stop using this stock until we can get the refrigerator checked.*" Distracted by sales figures and weekend targets, the manager says "*Okay, okay. Get it sorted,*" asks no questions and checks nothing. The kitchen keeps using the stock. Two days later customers report food poisoning; the restaurant is investigated and shut down; the story spreads online.

What it demonstrates: he *heard* perfectly. The failure is willingness (haste), not ability — and then **inaction**, the fifth pitfall: hearing, then never closing the loop.

Hearing vs listening

	Hearing	Listening
What it is	The physical capacity to sense sound. Automatic, involuntary, hard to avoid — a horn, machinery, a language you don't speak.	The perception of meaning. Requires concentrated physical and mental effort, and it can be skipped in a way hearing cannot.
Cost	Mechanical. Costs nothing.	Effortful. Costs attention.

Stravinsky, quoted in Reading 5.2: "*To listen is an effort, and just to hear is no merit. A duck hears also.*" · Over 35 studies find listening is the communication form most important for entry-level positions, most critical in distinguishing effective from ineffective subordinates, and most critical for managerial competency — and the one most often found lacking.

Why listening is worth the effort (Smeltzer's five benefits)

Much of the data needed for decisions arrives by listening · listening makes you **dependable** (better at following directions, fewer errors) · good listeners are more respected and liked, which supports trust and labour relations · you are better informed overall · it spares you the embarrassments of missed names and unanswered questions. The deepest reason: **relationships** — people need to be heard, and mutual understanding produces the trust any work group requires.

Barriers — two overlapping lists worth having both of

Smeltzer's seven barriers	What it is	Ability or willingness?
Listening-speaking differential (the 25–75 problem)	We speak at roughly 125 words a minute and think at four times that. The spare capacity wanders. Listed first because it partly causes the others.	Ability (manageable by technique)
Motivation	Sustaining continuous listening is hard. Scores on listening tests rise when people know they will be tested — hence the importance of a listening goal .	Ability & willingness
Willingness	Distinct from motivation because it is lost <i>before listening begins</i> . Reasons: most people would rather talk; the listener stereotypes the speaker as having nothing to contribute; the listener doesn't want the bad news; defensiveness treats a challenge to an opinion as a personal attack.	Willingness — and it supersedes the rest
Internal & external noise	Internal: headache, sore feet, empty stomach — the autonomic system insists. External: a noisy floor, a bad line.	Ability
Detouring	A phrase, concept, mannerism or bias distracts you onto a more interesting sub-topic. Closely related to bias: a hand over the mouth, a clicked pencil, an averted gaze.	Ability
Debate	You disagree, start planning the rebuttal, and miss the rest — creating a defensive climate as a bonus.	Willingness

Time	"I don't have time to listen to this." Time pressure produces rushed interactions and hasty conclusions.	Willingness
Yip & Fisher's five pitfalls (HBR 2025, class slide)		
Haste	Responding before understanding. Signals disrespect.	Willingness
Defensiveness	Treating a challenge as a personal attack.	Willingness
Invisibility	Listening without showing any sign of it.	Ability
Exhaustion	No attention left to give; drained managers cannot focus.	Ability
Inaction	Hearing, then never closing the loop.	Willingness

The line the slide makes: three of the five are willingness problems — *no technique on the next slides will fix those*. That sentence, applied to a case, is a complete diagnostic move.

Bell & Smith's five reasons managers fail to listen

Overassertiveness (assertive personalities speak more, find others slow or unclear, and sweep in with "Yeah, I know what you're going to say, but...") · **internal mental competition** (the head is a beehive; 150 wpm spoken against 600 wpm comprehension) · **assumptions about the speaker** ("Frank's such a worrywart") · **assumptions about the situation** (a vivid plan with no room in it for a glitch) · **laziness** (true listening would oblige you to do something; ignorance is comfortable).

Non-listening behaviours (Bell & Smith) — useful labels for a case

Behaviour	What it is
Pseudolistening	Pretending to listen and retaining nothing. Others usually detect it.
Selective listening	Hearing only what serves your interest and ignoring the rest — the speaker feels unheard and new disputes get created.
Interruption	Cutting in to confirm what you already think; worse, finishing their sentences with your idea of what they meant.
Insulated listening	Shutting off the moment a particular uncomfortable topic is raised — "I'm listening, but don't raise X."
Defensive listening	Feeling threatened by a divergent view and countering to justify your position.
Offensive listening	Listening attentively but only for faults and loopholes — ambushing. Turns the other party into a defensive listener.
Stage-hogging	Pushing others off the conversational stage to stay in the limelight.

The student-summary list adds, in similar spirit: not paying attention · listening but not hearing · rehearsing · hearing what is expected · listening for a point of disagreement. **The hierarchy of listening** is a clean ladder to quote: (1) not listening at all (2) listening, waiting to speak (3) listening, waiting to disagree (4) listening to understand (5) listening to create shared meanings.

Types and intensities

Distinction	Content
Active vs interactive (Smeltzer)	Active listening = situations where you cannot respond directly (large audience, a recording); you must get it right the first time. Interactive = you can question, summarise, paraphrase — conversations and meetings.
Three intensities	Casual / marginal — the technical detail isn't critical; still matters, because listening to an employee's personal news says "you are important as a person". Factual — you need specific information; the commonest business level. Empathic — understanding the person from <i>their</i> internal frame of reference, not yours; hard, because we naturally advise, tell, agree or disagree from our own frame. Even a partial attempt can open communication.
Bell & Smith's four types	Passive (no response required; fine for the radio, wrong for a conversation) · attentive (consciously focusing — instructions, briefings) · interactive (reacting visibly and audibly; failing to show surprise is a failure) · empathetic (reactive <i>and</i> participative — sharing the feelings underneath).
Listening goal	A one-sentence statement of the purpose for listening. Decide before you start whether the situation calls for casual, factual or empathic — and adjust as the interaction develops. Andy Wilson, a Walmart regional VP, can need all three inside five minutes on a store walk.

Preparation (Smeltzer's four steps): pick the best possible place · pick the best possible time · think about the personal biases you are bringing · review the listening objective. Note the mapping: place and time reduce internal and external noise; time also drives motivation, emotion and willingness; bias awareness prevents selective hearing. *In a survey of 200+ managers, respondents said they would not be offended by being asked to wait rather than be half-listened to.* Watch out for emotionally loaded trigger phrases — "typical humourless accountant", "we tried that before and it didn't work", "all engineers think alike."

Techniques

Active listening (no chance to reply)	Interactive listening (you can talk back)
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Identify main and supporting points

— the speaker's non-verbals mark them: raised voice, faster pace, repeated key words, gestures.

Organise the message — recognise the speaker's pattern: pros/cons, advantages/disadvantages, similarities/differences, chronology, functional duties.

Summarise — at transition points, not only at the end; fragments are fine.

Visualise — convert to a mental picture; this is what uses up the spare 75% of capacity. (The sixteen new salespeople as sixteen small figures running across a US map.)

Plus **mnemonics** — the acronym CAT for cost, ability, time.

Personalise — "how does this affect my role, my workload, my consequences?" This is what supplies willingness and motivation.

Take notes — short keywords and phrases. Notes organise, visualise and personalise at once; they also give you feedback on your own attention (no notes for a while = attention wandered) and signal sincere interest. Don't overdo it and miss the message.

Paraphrasing — *not* repetition. A paraphrase restates what you think the speaker *meant*, in your own words, including the emotional tone underneath, and invites correction.

Repetition: "So you're saying the client is unhappy about the delayed reports." Returns the words, checks nothing.

Paraphrase: "So your worry is that they've stopped believing our timelines, and the delay is only the trigger. Have I got that?"

Returns the meaning, invites correction.

A paraphrase does two things at once: it checks your understanding *and* it shows the speaker you spent effort.

Three axes of questioning — choose the axis before you open your mouth:

• **Open ↔ closed** — open invites information and digression; closed focuses and calls for commitment ("Will it be done by Wednesday?").

• **Primary ↔ secondary** — a secondary question probes one level deeper than the answer you just got ("What might go wrong?" → "Which part is hard to get?").

• **Neutral ↔ directed** — a directed ("leading") question retrieves confirmation, rarely information. "Wouldn't you agree that..." is not a question.

Listening styles (from the notes): questioning · silent listening (can be avoidance or support; effective silence still needs attention and appropriate non-verbals) · paraphrasing · supporting (offers of help, praise, agreement, diversion, minimising — and **minimising is inappropriate when it dismisses a genuine concern**) · empathising (identifying with their perceptions and feelings) · analysing (offering an alternative reading — should be tentative, plausible, and offered when the person is receptive and your motive is to help) · judgemental (assigning blame instead of examining the situation). *Questions turn toxic when they function as traps, condescension or sarcasm.*

Beyond the individual: the system

Trapped in the information bubble (Bryant & Sharer, HBR 2021)

The paradox: senior leaders have access to more lines of communication than anyone else in the organisation — and the information that actually reaches them is the most filtered in the building. Warning signals are tamped down, facts are omitted, data arrives with a positive spin.

Consequences: "success theatre" — results framed to avoid a hard conversation · blind spots widen, momentum slows, top talent leaves · crises stay undetected until they are catastrophic · decisions get made on filtered information.

Kevin Sharer (CEO, Amgen) — the transformation: *Before* — command-and-control, interrupted people, told them what they were about to say. *Crisis* — the Epogen crisis; profits fell; the company's first mass layoff, 14% of staff. *Epiphany* — poor listening was the root cause; resolved to be present and to ask for context. *After* — built a listening ecosystem: surveys, structured questions, quarterly feedback reports. **The lesson: personal presence and organisational systems. He needed both.**

Two dimensions of leadership listening (the class 2x2)

	Low individual listening skill	High individual listening skill
High organisational systems	Bureaucratic system — surveys and processes exist; personal presence and empathy do not.	Systemic & visible ★ — structured listening plus demonstrated follow-through. The standard.
Low organisational systems	Performative listener — visible signals (nodding, town halls) without substantive action.	Private listener — attentive one-to-one; the action stays invisible to everyone else.

The fourth-quadrant example from class. Fatima Sheikh, a senior nurse, had raised patient-handoff errors four times; each concern was heard individually, logged and forgotten. Dr Vikram Nair, the COO, did four things differently: **cross-referenced first** (nurse feedback, incident logs and survey data — before the meeting, not during it) · **named the earlier failures** out loud · **brought a draft, not a decision**, so Fatima co-authored the protocol change · **made it visible**, sending the change and the reasoning to the whole ward from both of them. Ability, willingness, *and* a system that makes both visible.

The listening climate (Smeltzer)

- **Micro (one-to-one):** give undivided attention, don't interrupt or finish sentences, use appropriate non-verbals — eye contact, leaning slightly in, facial expression responsive to the message, notes. Of 16 irritating listening habits surveyed, **two dominated employee complaints:** "*When I'm talking, he finishes sentences for me*" and

"When I come in, he doesn't put down what he's doing and turn his attention completely to me." **Both complaints are about signals, not comprehension** — which is the whole point of the Invisibility pitfall.

- **Macro (organisational):** physical availability, managing by wandering around, informal huddles, reduced status barriers (titles off doors and business cards), a genuine open-door environment. Peters' point in *Thriving on Chaos*: build listening opportunities into the daily routine. And the warning: "If they have to announce an open-door policy, it probably means there really isn't one."

Listening to informal communication

The grapevine. Rumours = Ambiguity × Interest. If information were complete and clear from formal channels, no rumours would form; rumour requires the message to be both ambiguous *and* interesting — which means **management can read what employees care about by reading the rumours**. Grapevine information is roughly 70-90% accurate, and the core of truth plus some distortion is what makes it believable and durable. Three distortions as a message travels:

- **Levelling** — details, qualifications and context get dropped so the story is simple enough to pass on.
- **Sharpening** — vivid, dramatic, entertaining details get emphasised.
- **Assimilating** — people adjust the story to fit their own needs and interests.

Listening to the total environment: three dimensions of any message, drawn as an equilateral triangle because all three weigh equally — **formal ↔ informal, verbal ↔ non-verbal, obvious ↔ hidden**. Managerial listening goes beyond the literal words: watch which departments get the best budgets, new equipment, extra staff, conference travel — those signals precede the formal announcement. Employees prefer formal channels and turn to informal ones only when the formal ones dry up.

Cultural differences in listening: use of silence, body language, eye contact, interruption norms, formality, and expectations about how people participate in presentations all vary (links to S10).

Drop-in lines — Session 5

- ▶ "He heard it perfectly. On Steil's split this was a willingness failure, not an ability one, and no technique would have fixed it."
- ▶ "Three of the five pitfalls — haste, defensiveness and inaction — are decisions rather than skills."
- ▶ "What I did was repetition, not paraphrase: I returned her words and checked nothing."
- ▶ "I had no listening goal, so I brought casual attention to a factual problem."
- ▶ "The complaint was never about comprehension. It was about signals — I never put down what I was doing."
- ▶ "By the time the information reached the head of the function it had been levelled, sharpened and assimilated three times over."
- ▶ "The rumour told us what people were anxious about, which is exactly what Rumours = Ambiguity × Interest predicts."
- ▶ "We were a private-listener organisation: the listening happened, and it was invisible to everyone except the two people in the room."
- ▶ "He brought a draft rather than a decision, which converted a consultation into a co-authorship."

Anticipated questions

- "Listening is not a skills problem." Evaluate. → LAW → the three willingness pitfalls → Smeltzer's willingness barrier and why it supersedes the rest → concede the ability half (25-75, technique, note-taking) → land on: technique helps a willing listener and does nothing for an unwilling one.
- Why do senior leaders receive worse information than junior ones? → the information bubble paradox → success theatre → grapevine distortions → power distance and psychological safety (S7, S10) → Sharer's ecosystem → the 2×2 as the recommendation frame.
- Distinguish paraphrasing from repetition and explain why it matters. → The definition → the two simultaneous functions (check + effort signal) → the worked pair → the link to closed-loop communication in S7 and the "convey".
- How would you build a listening climate? → micro and macro levels · the two dominant complaints · MBWA, huddles, reduced status markers · then the honest caveat that an announced open-door policy usually signals its absence, and that systems without presence produce the bureaucratic quadrant.

SESSION 6

Feedback — giving it well, receiving it without fear

The spine: two sides of one conversation. On the giver's side, the manager's own unmanaged anxiety distorts the message before the employee ever hears it — usually by making it softer than it should be. On the receiver's side, most people never ask, and in the silence they fill the gap with worst-case guesses that show up as procrastination, denial, brooding, jealousy and self-sabotage.

Sources: Elghanayan, Gallego & Ribera, "Giving Feedback", IESE technical note DPON-148-E, 2018 (Reading 6.1) · Jackman & Strober, "Fear of Feedback", *HBR*, April 2003 (Reading 6.2) · class slides (Prof. Avani Desai).

Part 1 — Giving feedback

Start with the giver's own emotions (the slide's opening move)

Before delivering feedback, managers silently ask themselves questions that set off their own emotions: *Will the worker agree with it? Will they accept it, or push back? Will the reaction be rational or emotional? How do I handle it if they react badly? Have I missed something in my evaluation? Am I actually being fair to this person?*

Managers may be carrying anger, stress or anxiety, or doubting their own ability to manage performance.

Unchecked, this quietly skews the feedback itself — usually making it more positive than it should be (Brown, Kulik & Lim). Fear and low self-confidence produce inaccurate feedback, which invalidates the whole exercise. **Exam use:** this is the least-used and most distinctive point in the session. If a case shows feedback that was too soft, name the giver's emotional management, not the employee's fragility.

The basics (Cardy & Leonard)

Choose the appropriate setting — **in private** · be considerate · keep it **specific and accurate** · tie the employee's behaviour and results to consequences that matter elsewhere in the organisation.

Three conditions for feedback to land

Condition	What it means
Relevant	Stay on performance characteristics that actually matter. Irrelevant points generate anger and rejection.
No surprises	Raise deficiencies in regular informal one-to-ones, not banked up for the annual review. People are also less defensive when feedback is frequent.
Engaged	The giver is actively involved and present. The delivery itself signals how much the task matters.

The feedback formula and the sequencing choice

Formula: "When you do [**behaviour**], it has [**impact**] on [me / the group / others]..." → then discussion and development. Think **behaviour → impact → development**. Avoid global labels ("always", "never"), personality judgements and vague criticism. Use a specific incident + observable action + concrete impact.

Sequence	What it is	Verdict
The sandwich	Positive → criticism → positive.	Don't rely on it. The critique softens the message but also blurs it — the person leaves unsure what the real point was.
Ask-Tell-Ask	Ask for self-assessment → tell the observed behaviour and how it differs from what was expected → ask how they plan to improve.	Sharper. Starts from their frame, so the gap is partly self-identified, and it ends with their ownership of the fix.
Bridge	Connect past → present → future: what went well before, what is happening now, what is expected next.	Sharper. Keeps the person's track record in the room, which protects identity while still naming the gap.

Five tactics for delivering negative feedback (Brown, Kulik & Lim)

Tactic	Manager as...	Essence	Sounds like
Emotive	Helper	Appeal to self-concept, feelings and the need to be a valued part of the organisation.	"I feel uncomfortable telling you this, but it matters because your work affects how your colleagues can do theirs."
Evidence	Judge	Objective data and recorded performance collected across the appraisal cycle; logic rather than feeling.	"In our performance agreement you agreed to these indicators. I don't think you're achieving them."
Communication	Conversationalist	Focus on <i>how</i> it is presented — the balance of positive and negative, and the space given to the employee to respond.	"Before I give you my feedback, I'd like to know how you feel and where you think you need to improve."
Evidence + Communication	Narrator	Evidence plus a forward-looking action plan and training.	"You're at 10%; the goal is 20%. That means trips to the UK, new vendors, and delegating X. The IT platform is live now, so that's no longer an obstacle."

Evidence + Emotive	Cheerleader	Identify the shortfall, then encourage the employee to fix it; make improvement feel like a challenge worth taking.	"Now that you know the budget has to go out each quarter, I'm sure you'll do it. You need to improve your planning, and I know you can."
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How the tactic is chosen — the examinable finding: managers pick on their read of the employee's *personality and ability to handle negative feedback*. **Evidence** was used most with employees *least* able to deal with negative feedback, because objective data reduces the emotional temperature for a sensitive person. **Evidence + communication** was used most with those *best* able to handle it — it encourages subordinates with low self-esteem and gives confident, ambitious ones a forward-looking perspective.

Strengths-based feedback

The shift from weakness-based (what you lack) to strengths-based (what you do exceptionally, and how to do more of it). The manager identifies exceptional performance, skills and talent, explains how those strengths produce success on the job, then asks the person to maintain or extend them. Research (Clifton & Harter; Jawahar) associates it with individual well-being and engagement, lower turnover, higher productivity, job satisfaction, perceptions of fairness and motivation — with few drawbacks found.

Aguinis, Gottfredson & Joo's three implementation rules: link any negative feedback to **knowledge and skills**, not to **talent** (skills can change; talent feels like identity — this connects directly to Stone's identity conversation in S8) · make sure the giver actually knows the receiver's knowledge, skills and talents · **follow up**.

Feedforward (Goldsmith)

Suggestions for the future rather than a review of the past. Why it often works better day-to-day:

- Focuses on a future that **can** change rather than a past that cannot — so it doesn't produce feelings of failure.
- Easier to give and to receive positively, while covering the same ground; less defensiveness, less embarrassment.
- Reads as **objective advice**, not a personal attack.
- Can come from anyone who knows the **task** — knowing the **person** is not required.
- Tries to help people **be right** rather than prove they were wrong.
- Implies no superiority of judgement — easier to accept from a "fellow traveller" than an "expert", so people listen harder.

The caveat you must include: feedforward *complements* feedback and appraisal, it does not replace them. Goldsmith's claim is that it is often preferable in day-to-day interaction.

Part 2 — Fear of feedback (Jackman & Strober)

The starting fact: at least half the executives the authors worked with **never ask for feedback at all**. In its absence people do not stay neutral — they guess, and they guess badly: heated arguments, impossible demands, threats of dismissal. In most companies feedback arrives only through a cursory annual review from which people learn little beyond the size of the raise. So rather than seek it, they avoid the truth and keep guessing what the boss thinks.

Five maladaptive responses — with the class diagnostic cases

Response	What it is	The class vignette
Procrastination	Usually conscious. Delay out of helplessness, anxiety or embarrassment — commonly carrying an edge of anger.	Manager A: a skilled employee sensed trouble but said nothing; instead he obsessed over small details, played games and missed deadlines. (Joe — repeatedly failed to finish on time, and it cost him a promotion.)
Denial	Usually unconscious. Unable or unwilling to face reality or its implications.	Manager B: told her promotion had stalled for several reasons, she fixed each one and was given a new explanation each time. She never questioned why. (Angela — her superiors had no intention of promoting her; accepting that would have required her to leave.)
Brooding	Morbid preoccupation and foreboding; passivity, paralysis and isolation.	Manager C: given goals he privately believed impossible, he stayed silent and withdrew from colleagues, who then began avoiding him too. (Adrian — a self-fulfilling prophecy within six months.)
Jealousy	Normal comparison turning maladaptive when driven by suspicion, rivalry or envy; over-idealising others and thereby disabling yourself.	Manager D: after hearing a colleague praised in a meeting, she began tracking every nod the boss gave. She soon quit, unable to compete. (Leslie.)
Self-sabotage	Usually unconscious. Undermining yourself in ways that make the fear come true.	Manager E: stung by feedback that she couldn't multitask, she made a sharp comment about her manager loud enough for him to overhear. (Nancy — she was eventually fired, which validated her innermost feelings of unworthiness.)

Reframing: turning the emotion into a next step

Feeling	Maladaptive pull	Reframe
Anger	Acting out — stomping around, complaining, irritability	"It's up to me to get the feedback I need."

Anxiety	Brooding; avoiding ("I'm too busy to ask")	"Finding out can open up new opportunities for me."
Fear of confrontation	Denial, procrastination, cancelling the meeting	"Taking the initiative puts me in charge."
Fear of reprisal	Denial — "I don't need feedback, I'm doing fine"	"I need to know honestly how I'm doing."
Hurt	Irritability, jealousy, plotting to get even	"I can still pay attention to what he said even though I feel hurt."
Defensiveness	Acting out by withdrawing support from the boss	"Being defensive keeps me from hearing what matters."
Sadness	Brooding, withdrawal, demotivation	"How I'm doing in my job isn't about whether I'm liked."
Fear of change	Keep doing things the old way	"I need to run the marathon one mile at a time."

Five adaptive techniques

- 1. Recognise your emotions and responses.** Name the fear *and* the maladaptive behaviour. Requires ruthless self-honesty and some detective work — a given behaviour doesn't announce which emotion drives it. Maria: months overdue on three performance reviews; the underlying feeling was resentment that her own boss hadn't completed hers. Once named, she could act despite the anger — and once she did, her relationships with the three subordinates improved and her boss finished her review.
- 2. Get support.** At least two people you feel emotionally safe with — a spouse, a mentor, an old classmate — ideally one with business experience; possibly a coach. Hard, because corporate cultures expect managers to be self-reliant, and near-impossible to change without encouragement.
- 3. Reframe the feedback.** Reconstruct the process in your favour so the negative response loses its grip. Gary, told he wasn't sociable enough with customers, first dismissed it as shallow; then grudgingly acknowledged it; then asked the real questions — how critical is sociability to this role? how much do I want this job? how much am I willing to change? — and concluded that sociability was critical and he wasn't willing. He requested a transfer and became far more successful.
- 4. Break it up.** Divide the change into measurable chunks with realistic timeframes. **Most people cannot change more than one or two behaviours at a time.** Jane, told her presentations were boring, decomposed "interesting presentations" into content, delivery and audience understanding, started with the easiest task (observing good speakers — gestures, organisation, intonation, timing, humour) and then took an introductory course.
- 5. Use incentives.** Reward yourself for each adaptive step, proportionate to the achievement. Nowhere is it written that the feedback process must be wholly negative.

Getting the feedback you need — the four-step proactive process

Step	What to do
1 Self-assessment	Decide which elements of your job matter most. Then recall the informal feedback you have already received from coworkers, subordinates and customers — <i>not only words, but facial expressions, body language and silences.</i>
2 External feedback	Two parts. First, a few trusted colleagues in meetings scheduled for the purpose; ask for both positive and negative, with specific examples. This is not 360° feedback — the point is confidentiality and safety, and it doubles as a dress rehearsal. If colleagues flag something urgent, fix it before seeing the boss; if you trust no colleague, go straight to the boss. Second, the boss : warn them it's coming, assure them criticism will be heard and acted on, set an agenda of three or four questions, ask for specific examples, and end by saying you'll come back with a plan. You may terminate the meeting if it turns counterproductive.
3 Absorb	Stay physically and emotionally neutral. Interrupt only for clarification. Listen for content, tone and body language — feedback can be indirect. Do not react immediately; keep the reaction private until you can replace it with an adaptive response.
4 Act	Convert the information into conclusions, priorities and a plan — and follow through.

The pay-off (worth a closing line): as more executives ask for feedback, their work aligns better with organisational priorities and a feedback-averse environment becomes a more honest one — improving performance across the organisation, not just for the individual.

Drop-in lines — Session 6

- ▶ "The feedback was softer than the performance warranted, and the cause was on my side of the table: I was managing my own discomfort rather than the message."
- ▶ "I used the sandwich, which cushioned the criticism and blurred it — she left knowing she'd been praised and unsure what she'd been asked to change."
- ▶ "Ask-tell-ask would have started from her own reading of the gap, so the fix would have been hers rather than mine."
- ▶ "I attached the criticism to talent rather than to knowledge and skills, which turned a performance conversation into an identity one."
- ▶ "This was feedforward territory: the past couldn't be changed and the next quarter could."
- ▶ "It was not that no feedback existed — it was that nobody asked, so the silence got filled with a worst case."
- ▶ "My procrastination was not a time-management problem; it was anger at not having received my own review."
- ▶ "With this employee the evidence tactic was the right one, precisely because she handles criticism badly and data lowers the emotional temperature."
- ▶ "Breaking it into one behaviour at a time was the difference between a plan and a resolution."

Anticipated questions

- *Why does the feedback sandwich fail, and what should replace it?* → The blurring mechanism → ask-tell-ask → bridge → the behaviour-impact formula → the three conditions (relevant, no surprises, engaged) → plus the giver-emotion point, which explains *why* managers reach for the sandwich in the first place.
- *How should a manager choose how to deliver negative feedback?* → The five tactics table → the selection criterion (the employee's ability to handle it) → the two empirical pairings → then a caution that tactic choice based on personality risks becoming a self-fulfilling label.
- *"People fear feedback." What can an individual and an organisation do?* → Individual: the five maladaptive responses, the reframing table, the five techniques, the four-step process. Organisational: no surprises, frequent informal one-to-ones, strengths-based framing, follow-up — and the S5 point that a listening climate is what makes asking safe.
- *Compare feedback and feedforward.* → Six differences → the boundary condition (complement, not replacement) → a managerial example of each → note the link to Stone (S8): feedforward lowers the identity threat, which is what makes the conversation possible at all.

SESSION 7

Communicating Within Teams

The spine: more communication is not better communication. What drives team performance is the movement of **unique information** — the thing one person knows and the others don't — and the confirmation that it was understood. Chapter 7 explains how information *should* move; Chapter 9 explains whether it *will*, given cohesiveness, norms, roles, conformity and power.

Sources: Tannenbaum & Salas, *Teams That Work: The Seven Drivers of Team Effectiveness*, ch. 7 "Communication: More Is Not Better; Better Is Better", pp. 102–118 (Reading 7.1) · O'Hair, Friedrich & Dixon, *Strategic Communication in Business and the Professions*, ch. 9 "Fundamentals of Group Communication", pp. 260–290 (Reading 7.2) · class slides (Prof. Avani Desai), incl. the L'Atelier exercise, face/facework, inquiry vs advocacy, and the language-choice table.

The opening case — L'Atelier de Joël Robuchon

A full house at a Michelin-starred kitchen. Despite constant activity the kitchen is **quiet**: no superfluous conversation, short targeted requests and confirmations, an occasional bell. Staff watch each other and slide over to help — wiping a plate rim, adding a garnish — with no fixed pattern, just real-time adjustment. Then a party of six arrives with an off-menu request involving expensive white truffles. The team **huddles**; the people with the most expertise regardless of role are involved; the person who knows truffles does most of the talking; someone in a suit is pulled in from outside the kitchen; once a solution is reached they **confirm everyone understands** and shift to execution. The kitchen returns to quiet.

Every concept in the session is in that paragraph: efficient communication under routine conditions · a deliberate shift when deviating from routine · listening to the member with unique information · **boundary spanning** for outside expertise · **closed-loop** confirmation.

Quality over quantity

Finding	Detail
The evidence base	Two meta-analyses: Mesmer-Magnus & DeChurch (72 studies) and Marlow et al. (150 studies, almost 10,000 teams). Together: communication influences team performance and cohesion — and quality does far more work than quantity.
More ≠ better	More messages, meetings and updates is not the same as useful, clear, accurate information arriving on time to the right people. In high-performing teams the <i>quantity</i> of communication is often lower than in poor-performing ones. "Communicate more" mostly creates noise.
Five quality tests	Useful — does it help someone perform, decide or coordinate? Clear — can the receiver understand it without guessing? Accurate — correct enough for the decision at hand? Timely — does it arrive while it can still change the outcome? Right people — who needs to know? <i>Quality is contextual: what is necessary in one situation is confusing, late or superfluous in another.</i>

Unique information — the highest-value content

Information and knowledge that other members do not currently possess, or may not fully understand, but would benefit from knowing. Three kinds: **expertise** (truffles, food costs), **situation status** (the hole in the hull is flooding), **action required** (brace for impact).

- **It does not have to be complex.** "The service request is waiting for your approval" is unique information if nobody else knows it.
- **A team cannot combine knowledge it does not know exists.** Unique information is the raw material of collective intelligence — and what makes situation awareness *shared*.
- Redundant information doubles the traffic and does nothing for performance.
- **The managerial habit:** ask what each person knows that the others may not — and, before you finish, "*who else needs to know this?*"
- Senior leadership teams are the worst offenders: each member has deep unique knowledge of their own function and routinely fails to share it in time for the decision.

Two human limitations that destroy unique information

Limitation	Mechanism	The fix
The "everybody knows" bias	We assume that because we know something, others do. Research shows people who have been explicitly told they are the only one who knows something still interact as if everyone knew it. What seems like common knowledge to you may not be common at all.	Build the habit of asking yourself and the team " who else should know this? "

Automaticity	Practice compiles expertise into a subroutine. A different part of the brain runs a task after automaticity than while learning it. The detail becomes hard to retrieve, so an expert asked "how did you do that?" gives a superficial answer — not because she is being difficult , but because the compiled code can't be read line by line on demand.	Ask "dig deeper" follow-ups; rephrase a question that produced a thin answer; help the expert unpack . Duffy & Chartrand: people who ask more questions, including follow-ups, are also seen as more responsive and likeable — provided the questions are relevant and not rude.
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Closed-loop communication and "the convey"

Three steps: 1 Call out — state the information or instruction. **2 Check back** — the receiver conveys what they understood. **3 Close** — the sender confirms or corrects.

Why it matters: "The single biggest problem in communication is the illusion that it has taken place." A teammate may share unique information on time, and if you misunderstood it, the misunderstanding still damages performance — worse if the sender assumes you understood. **Evidence:** high-performing flight crews use closed loops more than low-performing ones (Bowers et al.); across 89 paediatric trauma cases at Hofstra, tasks were completed **3.6 times faster** when communication was closed-loop. The two extra steps buy time back.

The convey — the step within your control. You cannot control whether the other person is clear; you *can* control whether you reflect your understanding back. Two types: **intellectual / head** ("So the deadline next Friday can't be changed") and **emotional / heart** ("And you're under a lot of pressure to deliver"). **Conveying is not agreement** — it is an attempt to show you understood, and it matters most precisely when you are about to disagree. Disagree without conveying first and anything you say reads as "you obviously don't get it" — which is why the other person then repeats their position slower and louder. Faulmüller et al.: when people feel understood they spend less time arguing their position, which frees the group to problem-solve. **The common failure:** everyone conveys — silently, inside their own head — and then just nods. That reassures nobody and gives the other person no chance to say "that's not what I meant."

Boundary spanning

Communicating and maintaining relationships with people outside the team, inside and outside the organisation. Ancona & Caldwell identified two purposes, a third was added later:

- **Ambassador** — secure resources, attention and cover from people with authority.
- **Coordinate tasks** — align with the other teams and units your output depends on.
- **Seek input** — pull in expertise the team does not hold. *Your kitchen had to leave the kitchen.*

Burke et al.'s meta-analysis: leaders of better-performing teams show higher-quality boundary-spanning behaviour. Need scales with external interdependence — a team waiting on another team's output needs constant clear channels; a skunkworks team in isolation needs far less. **Three questions to answer, first internally then with the outsiders:** who must we communicate with outside the team? what must we communicate about? **who owns the channel on each side?** — because with boundary spanning it is not enough to identify who needs to know what; you must name who is responsible for providing it. **Warning:** constant boundary spanning on top of a normal job causes burnout — distribute it.

Seven risk points where communication predictably breaks

Risk point	Why it breaks and what to do
New or changing membership	New members don't know how information moves here or who holds what; the "everybody knows" bias means long-timers don't tell them. Especially bad when the new member is experienced — the false assumption is that their knowledge is transportable and they are "ready to go". They need <i>more</i> communication for a period, not less. A departing member takes unique information with her, creating a knowledge void.
Changing tasks	Shared understanding has a shelf life; in dynamic work it expires faster, so situational updates matter more. It gets harder to run like the quiet kitchen.
Working at a distance	Fewer spontaneous conversations, weaker non-verbal cues, and knowledge fragments by location — each site builds its own common set. Each location should habitually ask "who might need to know this in the other locations?" Distance demands intentionality.
Heterogeneous composition	Different expertise, jargon and assumptions increase ambiguity. Same-field experts can use shorthand safely; mixed teams cannot. The convey and unpacking questions matter more here.
Hierarchy	Lower-power members hesitate to question, correct or admit uncertainty. The leader often does most of the talking. "Allowing" people to speak up is insufficient — leaders must actively ask for input and consistently encourage questions.
Handoffs	Responsibility moves between people, shifts or teams through a narrow window. What without why leaves the receiver stuck — someone told only what to do, not why, cannot handle the unexpected. Every handoff is a vulnerability.
Deviation from routine	The pattern that works normally fails under urgency. Sometimes you must talk to people you never talk to (the food-cost expert, the Italian Coast Guard); often you need a temporary <i>increase</i> in communication and a quick huddle. Emotions run high, misunderstandings multiply — this is exactly when closed loops earn their keep.

The eighth risk nobody designs for — incentives. If the person who knows the one thing becomes the hero, if sharing expertise makes you easier to replace, if knowledge behaves like a currency that loses value when spent — then **hoarding is the sensible move and people will learn to hoard**. Check what your recognition system actually pays for. *No amount of urging people to communicate will beat the incentive.*

Psychological safety — the information pipeline

Low safety sounds like: "I might look wrong." "I shouldn't question this." "I'll keep quiet." "I don't know enough to ask." What the team loses: unique information · questions that correct assumptions · alternative views · **early warning signals**. **Trust and communication are a cycle, not a sequence** — sharing builds trust, trust makes sharing easier; a breach spins it the other way. You can start the virtuous cycle from either end.

The evidence pair — Costa Concordia vs USAir 1549

Costa Concordia (2012)

Bridge crew did not warn the captain they were too close to shore — **a failure to speak up**. When the Coast Guard called, officers said "It's okay, it's just a technical problem" — **a failure to share unique information**. The evacuation order came so late the ship was listing too far to launch lifeboats — **a failure of timeliness**. (Compounding factor: most crew were entertainers or service staff, not qualified mariners, and passengers had not yet had safety training — a capability failure as well as a communication one.)

USAir 1549 (2009)

Sullenberger and Skiles had met three days earlier. "Brace for impact" told the crew to switch modes; they shouted "Brace, brace, brace, heads down, stay down." Skiles reaffirmed the captain's decisions and **called out speed and altitude**, letting Sullenberger focus on the landing. The cockpit was relatively quiet — **no superfluous communication**.

Chapter 9 layer — the hidden operating system of a group

Concept	Say it your way	Detail worth having
Cohesiveness	How much people actually want to stay in the group and see themselves as part of it.	Two routes: benefits/investments you can't abandon, and identification with the group's purpose. Propositions: cohesive groups communicate more and better · exert greater influence over members · achieve goals more effectively · members are more satisfied. Caution: a group that wants to stay united finds disagreement harder — high cohesion feeds groupthink.
Norms	Recurring patterns of behaviour or thinking that become "the usual way of doing things here".	Set and refined in the first few sessions; learned by new members through observation, trial and error, and interaction. Range from mundane ("no private conversations while someone is speaking") to serious ("voting required on every issue"). Norms decide what counts as acceptable communication.
Roles	Three families.	Task: information giver/seeker (agent), elaborator, initiator, administrator. Personal / socio-emotional: harmoniser (settles differences), gatekeeper (keeps members involved, may restrict information during overload), sensor (reads and expresses the group's mood). Problem: blocker, avoider, recognition seeker, isolator, dominator, free rider, detractor, digresser, socialiser. One person can embody several — a free rider is often also an isolator.
Conformity	Agreement with the group's ideas, rules or standards — in effect, negative consensus when it comes from pressure rather than persuasion.	Causes: interaction itself · time (raising an issue near the end draws hostility) · directive/authoritarian leadership · social pressure and the need to belong · high cohesion. It is not automatically bad: groups must eventually decide; emergencies don't allow the luxury of dissent; fundamentals (why the group exists, how it operates) must be agreed by everyone; and naturally contentious groups may need it to protect morale.
Group polarisation	Put like-minded people together and the group comes out more extreme than its members went in.	Sunstein's Boulder / Colorado Springs experiment: the consensus response was consistently more extreme than the individual responses. The question to ask: which of your standing meetings is a room of people who already agree with you?

Groupthink

Four conditions	Three symptoms	Countermeasures
Being out of touch — meeting long and away from normal routines; the big picture disappears. Being out of order — informal, non-standard decision procedures with no way back on course. Being overruled — criteria and procedures thrust on the group by a leader. Being short of resources or time — a critical problem, a short clock, no alternative to the leader's preference.	Illusion of invulnerability / omnipotence — prior success and superiority producing excessive risk-taking and decisions made without regard to moral consequences. Closed-mindedness — shutting out non-conforming information, rationalised as irrelevant or ill-sourced. Pressure toward uniformity — from the self (self-censorship, minimising your own doubts) and from the group (frowning, ignoring, then attacking deviants' motives and loyalty).	Assign critical evaluation to each member — constructive questioner, not destructive. Split into subgroups with similar tasks and compare. Ask outsiders — even friends or spouses — for an untainted view. Hold a "misgivings" meeting where doubts and second-guessing are the agenda. Increase diversity of perspective — gender, ethnicity, age, background — so one-track thinking is harder.

The worked case: Columbia, February 2003. Insulating foam struck the left wing at launch; NASA flight managers knew within a day and decided not to pursue repair options or even satellite imagery, because foam had come off before without consequence. The foam had in fact torn a fatal hole in the heat shielding. The Columbia Accident Investigation Board found all four conditions: *out of touch* — "organisational barriers that prevented effective communication of critical safety information and stifled professional differences of opinion"; *out of order* — an informal chain of command operating outside the organisation's rules; *overruled* — engineers presented concerns and solutions, and "management did not listen to what their engineers were telling them"; *out of resources* — the budget was inadequate for the programmes being run. The Board's own conclusion: **"NASA's organizational culture had as much to do with this accident as foam did."**

Building the dissent in

Method	What it is	How to run it
Advocacy	Presenting competing views on a contested issue. Surfaces alternatives, forces the group to weigh strengths and weaknesses, and prevents the drift to solutions that are personal favourites or easy to sell upward.	The umbrella term for the two below.
Devil's advocacy	Formal, structured dissent against the prevailing view — introduced deliberately where premature consensus is stopping assumptions being challenged.	A sequence: group commits to the value of dissent → a volunteer emerges or the role is assigned → the advocate must be competent and credible enough to be taken seriously → choose which phase to attack (problem identification, definition and analysis, or solution evaluation — strategic selection avoids being labelled a detractor) → prepare , researching what weakens the likely positions → issue the challenge on inconsistencies, irrelevancies, inaccuracies, or against previously agreed criteria. Only attacks.
Dialectical inquiry	Goes one step further: builds a counterplan on opposite assumptions, then debates both.	Four stages: identify the recommended plan and its data → surface the assumptions underlying it → construct a counterplan that is feasible, politically viable and credible but rests on opposite assumptions → hold a structured debate in which both are argued forcefully from the same data. Attacks and defends , which some researchers rate superior because a counterplan generates constructive alternatives — and because people resent an attacker who offers nothing of their own. The risk: groups can focus on the two plans' relative advantages and ignore the underlying assumptions, which is what devil's advocacy protects against. Use both.

The hypertension drug that grew hair: researchers wanted to shelve it, marketers wanted the baldness market, researchers said the side effect couldn't be contained — until someone asked why it couldn't be formulated as a topical treatment that grows hair only where applied. A new interpretation of the problem, produced by structured opposition.

Conflict

Conflict is what group meetings are for. It is not disorder — it is a sign people are actively discussing issues; a group that debates nothing has little reason to meet, since members might as well work alone. Leaders can use conflict to test ideas before anyone implements them, and to establish what is and is not an acceptable solution. **Conflict and advocacy are kindred spirits**, and avoiding conflict is one of the routes into conformity and groupthink. **The one limit:** debate the issue, not the participants. Arguments centred on people — questioning knowledge, motives or moral standing — stop a group being productive. When it happens, the leader's job is to refocus attention onto evidence.

Class-only layer — language, face and climate

Concept	Say it your way	Detail
Talk is not just information	Talk reflects people's thoughts and feelings, creates thoughts and feelings in listeners, and can enhance or inhibit problem-solving, relationships and learning.	The managerial shift: from "what do I want to say?" to " what do I want to accomplish? " Specific words reveal who feels included and whether people trust management — "Somebody ought to tell Management..." signals distance.
Problematic patterns	Six ways team talk goes wrong.	Emotion (anger, exasperation — escalates rather than solves) · person vs content (sarcasm, mockery — attacks the speaker, not the idea) · dialectic (saying vs doing — mismatch undermines credibility) · mindsets/goals (different assumptions; people argue past each other) · certainty ("That will never work!" — closes exploration) · provisionalism ("My guess is you'll run into problems..." — leaves room for inquiry).
Language-in-use	Five registers.	Affective (emotion expressed to evoke emotion — "It would be cowardly to back out now") · polarising (sweeping generalisations that close dialogue — "This is the only way...") · figurative (simile, metaphor, personification — "They are like vultures...") · language of logic (grounds + claims + assumptions) · high/low power language (hedging and hesitation vs self-assurance and dominance — "I think..." vs "This will never work").

Face and facework	Face = the social image a person wants maintained — approval, admiration, control. FTA = a face-threatening act. Facework = the effort to shape how others see us; face can be built, changed or lost through communication.	Orientations: self-face · other-face · mutual-face . Face concerns = maintaining others' face; face negotiation = changing it. <i>Instead of "you don't know what you're talking about," disagree without humiliating.</i> This is the bridge to S8 (identity) and S10 (face-saving is universal; only the degree varies).
Inquiry vs advocacy climate	Two opposed goals for a discussion.	Inquiry : goal is the best solution <i>together</i> ; surface relevant information and perspectives; others are collaborators; reveal gaps in your argument because others may help. Advocacy : goal is to <i>win</i> ; present your view strongly and seek agreement; others are competitors; hide gaps; winner gets points and power may get the last word. Note: this is a different sense of "advocacy" from Ch. 9's structured dissent — say which one you mean.
Confirming messages	People need to feel valued — particularly under stress and uncertainty.	Recognise ("I can see this has been difficult") · Acknowledge ("Last year was difficult for the sales team") · Endorse ("Your concern is worth considering").

Language choices that build the climate (the slide's table — one of the most directly usable things in the course)

Axis	Less constructive	More constructive
Evaluation → Description	"You need to take your responsibilities more seriously." / "You are not competent enough."	"The report was late this week, which affected client satisfaction." / "I can't use these slides because they don't include the quarterly results."
Control → Problem orientation	"Don't even think about doing that."	"The action proposed may not lead to the results we want."
Context-free → Contextual	"Show up by 8:30."	"Slides need to be set up by 8:45, so we need to be there by 8:30."
Neutrality → Empathy	"We all face problems; move on."	"Last year was a difficult one for the sales team."
Superiority → Equality	"When you're in my position, you'll understand."	"I'd like to hear how it looks to you; then I can tell you how it looks to me."
Certainty → Provisionalism	"That will never work."	"My guess is that you'll run into problems with that approach."

Sensemaking through questions

Type	Purpose	Examples
Exploratory	Open the story, gather detail	"Tell me more." "Can you describe the situation?" "What happened next?"
Diagnostic	Understand causes and perspectives	"How do you see the problem?" "What do you think caused this?" "Give me an example."
Action alternative	Move toward options	"What have you tried?" "Have you considered...?" "Advantages and disadvantages?"
Direct / confrontative	Challenge or surface an issue	"Define your goals more clearly." "What is keeping you from solving this?"

Leadership and participation

Lens	Content
Four approaches	Trait — leaders score higher on intelligence, scholarship, dependability, activity, social participation and socioeconomic status; also vision, power, embodying organisational values, risk-taking and entrepreneurial imagination. Negative traits: lack of knowledge, non-participation, extreme rigidity, authoritarian behaviour, offensive verbalisation. Style — behaviours: authoritarian / participative / laissez-faire; or Blake & Mouton's task-vs-relationship grid (emphasis on both works best in most situations). Situational — no single best style; either the leader adapts to the group, or the leader is matched to a group that fits their fixed style. Functional — leadership duties distributed across whoever rises to perform them.
Hersey & Blanchard	Maturity = the group's willingness <i>and</i> ability. Directing (high guidance, low autonomy) → Coaching (instruct, model, encourage participation) → Supporting (peer role: compliments, reassurance, minimising doubts) → Delegating (responsibility for tasks, solutions and decisions handed over). As readiness rises, guidance falls and autonomy rises.
Participation styles	Authoritarian — leader decides <i>for</i> the group. Justified in crises (no time) and when members lack the knowledge (asking wastes time and embarrasses people). Otherwise it lowers morale, reduces confidence in the leader, breeds suspicion about motives, and raises the chance of a poor decision because input never surfaces. Laissez-faire — leader decides nothing; the group gropes for direction and wastes time (FEMA's Michael Brown during Katrina: "made few decisions", few emails "taking charge or issuing tasking orders"). Participative — leader decides <i>with</i> the group.
Participation drivers	Approachability — effective listening and an accessible manner (eye contact, open posture); ask for opinions, comment on ideas, express positive regard. Commitment — caring personally about the group, loyalty to its mission, staying focused, high intensity, visible positive attitude; built by clarifying goals and showing members the difference their effort makes.

Facilitation — managing the styles that stall a discussion

Style	What it looks like	Facilitation move
Rambling	Much discussion, none on the subject; gets lost.	Raise a hand slightly, take the floor, refocus on the issue. Glance at the clock.

Verbose	Excessive talk, anxious to show off, very wordy.	Ask a difficult question to slow them down. Ask others to interpret their meaning. Ask for additional input.
Inarticulate	Can't put the thought into coherent form.	Paraphrase the comment. Ask whether others feel the same way.
Sidebar talk	Two people talking privately during the discussion.	Call one by name and ask for their view on the discussion.
Avoiding	Non-involvement, little participation.	Call on them by name. Ask for an opinion.
Blocking	Negative or disagreeable comments.	Ask why they feel that way. Have them compare their view with the others'.

Drop-in lines — Session 7

- ▶ "We communicated constantly and still missed it, because what moved around the team was redundant information, not unique information."
- ▶ "I assumed it was common knowledge. The 'everybody knows' bias is exactly this: I never asked who else needed to know."
- ▶ "The expert wasn't withholding — automaticity had compiled the detail out of easy reach, and I never asked a second, deeper question."
- ▶ "Nobody closed the loop, so 'I said it' was mistaken for 'we agreed it'."
- ▶ "I conveyed silently, in my head, and then nodded — which reassured her of nothing."
- ▶ "The handoff gave the next shift the what and not the why, which left them unequipped for the first surprise."
- ▶ "Urging people to share was never going to work while the reward system paid for being the only one who knew."
- ▶ "Formally the leader allowed questions. In a hierarchical team, allowing is insufficient — input has to be actively asked for."
- ▶ "The group's cohesion, which had been its strength, became the mechanism by which dissent stopped being expressible."
- ▶ "We were in advocacy mode when the decision needed inquiry: everyone was hiding the gaps in their own argument."
- ▶ "Assigning a devil's advocate attacks the plan; dialectical inquiry would also have given us something to compare it with."

Anticipated questions

- *"More communication is not better communication."* Discuss. → The two meta-analyses → the five quality tests → unique information as the real driver → the quiet kitchen and the quiet cockpit → then the nuance: quantity *should* rise at the risk points, particularly deviation from routine.
- *Why do teams fail to share what they know?* → Human limitations ("everybody knows", automaticity) → safety (fear of looking wrong) → structure (hierarchy, distance, heterogeneity, handoffs, membership churn) → incentives (hoarding pays) → recommendations at each layer.
- *How can a manager get the benefits of cohesion without groupthink?* → Cohesion's four benefits → the mechanism by which it suppresses dissent → the four conditions and three symptoms → Columbia → countermeasures, distinguishing devil's advocacy from dialectical inquiry → the conflict rule (issues, not people).
- *Analyse a team episode using communication concepts.* → Use the L'Atelier checklist as a scan: what unique information existed, did it move, was the loop closed, did anyone span the boundary, which risk point were you at, what did the norms and incentives reward?

SESSION 8

Difficult Communication & Negative Messages

The spine: avoidance is itself a communication act, and it compounds. Every difficult conversation is really three conversations at once — what happened, feelings, and identity — and the identity one is usually the reason the other two go wrong. On the written side, the direct/indirect choice is a judgement about the receiver's likely reaction, not about how uncomfortable the sender feels; and whichever you choose, **your first responsibility is clarity**.

Sources: "Negative Messages", *Essentials of Business Communication* (Cengage), ch. 7, pp. 186–206 (Reading 8.1) · Douglas Stone interview, "Difficult Conversations: How to Address What Matters Most", *Rotman Magazine*, Spring 2011 (Reading 8.2) · class slides (Prof. Avani Desai), using DeLong & Vijayaraghavan's *Crucial Conversations* HBS case (Scott and Todd).

The class case — the message Scott never sent

Earlier in the week: Todd is well paid but is *not* the top-paid associate. Scott tells him he is. *A negative message, avoided.*

Later: numbers come up in the bullpen. Todd concludes his boss lied to him and that he was taken for a fool. *The cost of avoidance, compounding.*

Tonight: end of a meeting, the night before a Chicago pitch. Todd opens with a resignation threat. *The conversation nobody planned.*

Anatomy of the breakdown — five stages, each provoking the next: **1 Stated issue** — "It might be time for a change." Todd names the Energy Group, not the bonus. **2 Indirect approach** — hints in place of the question: "You say that to everyone." **3 Identity threat** — "Why can't you be straight with me?" Dignity enters the room. **4 Certainty** — "It all comes down to money, and ego." Scott stops asking and starts concluding. **5 Breakdown** — Todd is moved out of the group; neither man names what happened.

Stone's line on it: a sugar-coated hand grenade still does damage. **Todd sugar-coated his.** And note the first-stage lesson: the stated issue is rarely the real issue.

Part 1 — Stone's model: every difficult conversation contains three

Conversation	What it is about	The questions to ask
1 "What happened?"	Whose story, and on what evidence. Disagreement over facts, who is right, whose fault it is.	What are the two stories? What data sits behind each? What did each person contribute ?
2 Feelings	What is present but unspoken.	What emotions are in the room? What impact did the situation have? What needs to be made discussable ?
3 Identity	What this says about me.	What self-image is threatened? What am I actually afraid of? What must I accept to stay grounded?

The three conversations mapped onto Scott and Todd — the class's own worked application

Conversation	Todd's side	Scott's side
What happened?	"Scott lied to me about my compensation ranking."	Compensation situations are not comparable; nothing he said was untrue on his own reading.
Feelings	Anger and betrayal — unspoken, and driving every line he says about the Energy Group.	Defensiveness and hurt — equally unspoken, and driving the shift from asking to concluding.
Identity	"I am a top performer." The ranking threatens that self-image, which is why the conversation cannot stay factual.	"I am a fair manager." Being called dishonest threatens that, which is why he stops enquiring and starts diagnosing Todd's motives.

Reading it this way explains the escalation mechanically: neither man is arguing about what he is actually defending, so more facts cannot settle it.

Both people have all three — and the manager's identity is on the line too. This is the point most answers miss. Giving negative feedback challenges how the giver sees himself ("I'm not the kind of person who hurts people"; "if I were a better boss it would never have come to this"), which causes stress and degrades the feedback. Played out at organisational scale this produces a **"culture of nice"** — fine, unless it stops people having important and honest conversations.

Difficult conversation → learning conversation

	Difficult (unproductive)	Learning (productive)
What happened	"Whose story is right?" — either/or. "They meant to have this impact." "This is their fault."	"Why do we see this so differently? What is each of our data and reasoning?" "I don't like the impact they're having — I wonder what they intended?" "We have each contributed ; let's identify how and fix it."

Feelings	"My feelings are their fault; I should either let them have it or keep quiet."	"My feelings say something about me and something about their actions. I can share them without blame, and acknowledge theirs with empathy — without conceding their story is right."
Identity	"They're attacking my identity unfairly!"	"Realistically, some of what they're saying makes painful sense. What am I really afraid of? How can their story have validity without negating who I am — and vice versa?"

Stone's one-sentence definition of a learning conversation: one where both people learn how the other sees things and how the other feels. It entails **moving from certainty about your own stance to curiosity about theirs** — from "How can she think that?!" to "I wonder what information she has that I don't?"

Four tools

Tool	How it works
The "And Stance"	We assume we must accept or reject their story, and that accepting theirs means abandoning ours. Who is right between the person who sleeps with the window open and the one who prefers it closed? The question makes no sense. The And Stance is not "pretend both stories are true" — it recognises that <i>how each of you sees it matters, and how each of you feels matters</i> , regardless of what is eventually decided. It moves the conversation from certainty to curiosity.
The Third Story	Every conflict has three sides: how I see it, how you see it, and how an independent mediator or neutral observer would frame it. A neutral party frames it not as right/wrong or good/bad but as difference — "the two of you have different views, interests, priorities and preferred outcomes." Reframing from right/wrong to "we see this differently" changes the purpose of the conversation from winning to " how do we best manage this difference? " — a frame both people can sit in comfortably that still doesn't gloss over the conflict. You don't need an actual mediator , and it works even if the other person won't play: "We disagree on how to handle this problem; you feel strongly we should do it this way and I feel strongly we should do it that way; let's think about how we move forward." If they insist they're right: "Yes, we both think we're right. We see things differently and want different things. Given that, here's how I think we should move forward."
Role reversal	All humans share one limitation: we cannot see ourselves. We have an image of how we come across, but we can't see our own face or body language and are mostly deaf to our own tone. Simply asking "how am I affecting this person?" yields something; <i>actually imagining yourself to be the other person</i> yields far more — it unlocks a door in your mind that is usually shut.
The Observer's Insight	Same move, but rather than the other person's point of view you take a mediator's — role-reversing into the position of a neutral third party.

Feelings, and the decision to raise or avoid

- **Suppress or express? It depends on your purpose.** Not therapy-in-the-meeting — but key workplace feelings (**autonomy, inclusion, appreciation, fairness**) that are treated as outside the boundary of discussable things *will end up getting in the way*. Avoiding or suppressing them **makes us less efficient, not more**. Set the purpose as "let's make this relationship more effective" and talking about feelings is often the fastest route. Listening ability improves remarkably once you have expressed your own strong feelings.
- **People who can't suppress usually don't know it — it's a blind spot.** Stone's executive believed she was being well-mannered and friendly on a call; the message came out sarcastic and attacking and she was oblivious. Hidden feelings leak through tone, body language and facial expression anyway, *which compounds the problem*. **The fix is not to hide them better but to make your style explicitly discussable:** talk about your personality style, acknowledge that you sometimes get frustrated, and make it okay for colleagues to tell you when you're being difficult.
- **Avoiding vs raising.** Reframe "confronting" as **raising the issue skilfully** — "confronting" carries connotations of attack. The answer to "is raising it always right?" is no. Life is short and some things are inconsequential, and the instinct to raise something is often not based on any forward-looking purpose. **"Make a smart choice."**
- **The systematic thinking error.** Thinking about raising it makes us anxious and we focus on the *immediate pain of having the conversation*; deciding to avoid brings *relief* — "if I don't raise this today nothing bad will happen." We are therefore only weighing half the equation: the costs of raising and the benefits of avoiding. **We never notice the benefits of raising and the costs of avoiding** — and the costs of avoiding accumulate. In six months you may no longer have a relationship with that person because you've been avoiding them. Weigh all four, short and long term.

Delivering a tough message — the hand grenade

We want to sugar-coat it. **But even coated with sugar, a hand grenade still does damage — and avoiding or choosing not to deliver it is like hanging on to a grenade once you've pulled the pin.** Most of Stone's advice is to move away from thinking of the conversation as *delivering a message* and toward a two-way learning conversation. But there are times you really must deliver ("you're fired"). The professional-services firm whose client wasn't paying said they'd given ultimatums; the ultimatum turned out to be "if they didn't pay us, we'd have to think about what to do." That is not an ultimatum. Sugar-coating of this kind is remarkably common.

The rule: when you have to deliver a tough message, **your first responsibility is clarity.** Don't try to control or manage the other person's reaction. Don't try to get them to like you. It is their right to react however makes sense to them. Caring, empathy and human connection matter — **but if you are not clear, nothing else matters.**

Stone's five-step checklist

1. **Walk through the three conversations.** Sort out *what happened* — where does your story come from (information, past experience, rules)? theirs? what impact has this had on you? what might their intentions have been? what have you each contributed? **Understand emotions** — explore your emotional footprint and the bundle of emotions you're carrying. **Ground your identity** — what's at stake for you about you, and what do you need to accept to be better grounded?
2. **Check your purposes and decide whether to raise it.** What do you hope to accomplish? If necessary, shift your stance to support learning, sharing and problem-solving. Is this the best way to achieve that? **Is the issue really embedded in your Identity Conversation?** Can you affect the problem by changing your own contributions? If you don't raise it, what can you do to help yourself let go?
3. **Start from the Third Story.** Describe the problem as the difference between your stories, including both viewpoints as legitimate. Share your purposes. Invite the other person in as a partner in sorting it out.
4. **Explore their story and yours.** Listen to understand their perspective. Ask questions. Acknowledge the feelings behind the arguments and accusations. Paraphrase to check. Try to unravel how the two of you got here. Then share your own viewpoint, past experiences, intentions and feelings. **Reframe, reframe, reframe** — from truth to perceptions, blame to contribution, accusations to feelings.
5. **Problem-solve.** Invent options that meet each side's most important concerns and interests. Look to standards for what should happen — including the standard of **mutual caretaking**, since relationships that always go one way rarely last. Talk about how to keep communication open going forward.

Part 2 — Negative messages in writing (Cengage, ch. 7)

Five goals when delivering bad news

Explain clearly and completely — the reader should not need to follow up to understand. **Project a professional image** — stay calm and polite even when the receiver is hostile and overstating. **Convey empathy and sensitivity** — reduce bad feelings; accept blame and apologise where appropriate *without creating legal liability*. **Be fair** — show the decision was impartial and rational. **Maintain friendly relations**, especially with customers.

The underlying finding: bad feelings are reduced if the receiver (a) knows the **reasons**, (b) feels the news was revealed **sensitively**, and (c) believes the matter was treated **seriously and fairly**.

Direct or indirect — the decision

	Direct: bad news → reasons → pleasant close	Indirect: buffer → reasons → bad news → close
Use when	The news is not damaging or doesn't affect the receiver personally (a small cost increase) · it may be overlooked and needs boldness (service changes, new policy requirements, legal announcements) · the organisation or person prefers directness · firmness is required (the last in a series of collection letters).	The news is personally upsetting (a layoff) · it may provoke a hostile reaction — a blunt opening makes the receiver stop reading · it threatens a customer relationship · it is unexpected , and people totally surprised by bad news react more negatively than those who expected it.
Argument for	Saves time; some consider it more professional and even more ethical. In social media, bluntness dominates and directness is equated with honesty, hedging with deceit.	Keeps the reader's attention until the reasons have been explained; softens the blow; shows sensitivity. Despite the social-media shift, the majority of negative messages are still conveyed indirectly .

The ethics test — indirect is not evasive

The test is the motive of the sender, not the shape of the message. Indirect structure is *preparation* — a way to make the receiver receptive to the explanation, to soften impact while the truth still arrives, to be compassionate and effective at once. It is **not** concealment: not a tactic for deception, not a way to misrepresent or dodge the truth, and not a substitute for clarity. "*If the why of my no is clear and understandable, it's less likely the other person will take it as a no to them.*" Unethical communicators intend to deceive; delaying the main idea to be compassionate is not that.

The four parts, in detail

Part	Job	Craft
Buffer	A neutral but meaningful opener that makes the reader continue, is relevant and concise, and provides a natural transition into the reasons.	Seven options: best news · compliment (honest and sincere) · appreciation (but never thank them for the thing you're about to refuse) · agreement (a statement you both accept) · facts (objective information that introduces the news) · understanding (showing you care about the reader) · apology . Traps : the trite opener ("Thank you for your e-mail") and the buffer that doesn't transition — a buffer that leads nowhere is padding.

Reasons	Explain the causes before the decision lands. Without sound reasons the message fails however well organised.	Explain clearly if not confidential or legally risky. Cite reader or other benefits if plausible — but not if it sounds insincere ("to improve our service to you, we are increasing our brokerage fees"). Explain company policy, don't hide behind it — "we prefer to promote from within because it rewards loyalty and internal people contribute faster" beats "company policy prevents us". Choose positive words: avoid <i>cannot, claim, denied, error, failure, fault, impossible, mistaken, misunderstand, never, regret, rejected, unable, unwilling, unfortunately, violate</i> . Show fairness and serious intent — that you investigated carefully and decided impartially. Never make unrealistic or dangerous promises to be the good guy.
Bad news	State it clearly, then place it so it does not dominate.	Six cushioning techniques: position it strategically — sandwich it between other sentences, never at the start or end of a paragraph, where the eye lingers · use a subordinate clause beginning <i>although, as, because, if, since</i> ("Although another candidate was hired, we appreciate your interest...") · use the passive voice to depersonalise ("Cash refunds are not given because..." rather than "We don't give cash refunds") · highlight the positive — say what you <i>can</i> do ("We are now selling gasoline at discount cash prices" not "we will no longer allow credit card purchases") · imply the refusal where the reasons make it unmistakable · suggest a compromise or alternative .
Close	Personalised, forward-looking and pleasant. Do not return to the bad news.	Options: a forward look · an alternative with follow-through advice · good wishes · freebies (coupons, samples) · resale — mentioning the product favourably to reinforce the customer's choice · sales promotion . Avoid endings that are canned, insincere or self-serving, and don't invite further correspondence ("if you have any questions, do not hesitate...").

The implied-refusal trap — where the two readings collide

Cengage lists "imply the refusal" as a legitimate cushioning technique, **and warns in the same breath** that an implied refusal can be so subtle the reader misses it — you must still make the bad news clear or the correspondence continues. Stone says the first responsibility is clarity.

The class slide's synthesis, using Scott's closing line — *"I think it might really make more sense for your career for you to go add value over there. If you'll excuse me, I've got to make some calls before I head out to Chicago."* — **nobody names the decision**. Todd may not know he has just been moved out of the group; Scott may not know he decided it. Neither man can act on a message neither of them said. **The resolution to write in an exam: Cengage says imply; Stone says be clear. Both are right, for different channels.** A written refusal to a customer can afford implication because the reader can re-read and reply; a face-to-face decision about someone's career cannot.

Apology and empathy

A strong apology — names the problem	A weak apology — names your regret
Prompt and sincere · accepts responsibility where responsibility is yours · says what will be done to prevent recurrence · weighs the legal and organisational implications first (check with a superior or counsel before formally admitting fault). <i>"I apologise for the frustration our delay caused you. As soon as I received your message, I began looking into the cause and realised our delivery tracking system must be improved."</i>	"We apologise if anyone was affected." · "We regret that you are unhappy." · Focuses on the receiver's reaction instead of the failure · conditional wording signals that nothing has actually been conceded. Evidence that it matters: CEOs who appeared genuinely sad rather than merely contrite in apology videos saw their companies' share prices rise; those who smiled while apologising were perceived as insincere and prices dropped.

Empathy means recognising the receiver's experience — "You have every right to be disappointed. I am truly sorry that..." **It does not mean accepting their account of it.** Apologies cost nothing; hollow ones cost a great deal.

Delivering bad news in person — the six-point checklist

The class used it to show what Todd did *not* do: **gather all the information** (Todd acted on bullpen numbers and never asked what Alan's package actually was) · **prepare and rehearse** (he opened with a resignation threat he hadn't thought through) · **explain past, present, future** (he gave no account of what he wanted to happen next) · **consider taking a partner** (a pay conversation with no HR presence and no record) · **think about timing** (end of a meeting, night before a Chicago pitch — and the general rule: never when someone is already stressed, and not Friday afternoon when they have the weekend to dwell on it) · **be patient with the reaction** (he apologised the moment Scott pushed back, then stopped talking; give the receiver time to vent, think, recover and act wisely).

Also from the reading: first decide whether the negative information is **newsworthy** — trivial, non-criminal mistakes and one-time bad behaviours are best left alone; fraudulent travel claims, consistently hostile behaviour and failing projects must be reported.

Bad news inside the organisation and to the public

Keep communication open and honest — in an age of social media, damaging information can rarely be contained and can be counted on to leak; executives who don't communicate proactively end up on the defensive. **Choose the channel** — morale is destroyed when employees learn of events affecting their jobs from the grapevine or the news rather than from management; individuals deserve a personal delivery, large groups need multiple channels (intranet posts, email, video,

webcasts, blogs, voicemail; a hard-copy memo on the board where some workers have no company email). **Be positive but don't sugarcoat; use objective language.** The Titanium Industries health-benefit example: the weak draft announced a \$119 increase in the first sentence, offered no explanation, sounded insincere and arbitrary, and failed to take credit for the company absorbing the previous year's rise; the revision buffered with the value of the benefits package, gave the cost history with figures, embedded the increase mid-paragraph, and closed on the company's own (larger) share.

Handling complaints online: verify the situation (if the complaint is legitimate and you fouled up, fess up) · respond quickly and constructively, offering to follow up offline with contact details · consider freebies — dissatisfied customers often write a second, more positive review after a refund · treat complainants as a real-time focus group and learn · accept the inevitable: some negativity is unavoidable; respond constructively and move on.

Drop-in lines — Session 8

- ▶ "The avoidance was itself a communication act, and it set the terms of the conversation that eventually happened."
- ▶ "I weighed the cost of raising it against the relief of avoiding it — which is only half the equation."
- ▶ "The stated issue was the project. The real conversation was about identity, and mine was as exposed as his."
- ▶ "I opened from my own story rather than the third story, so the first thing he had to do was defend himself."
- ▶ "Moving from blame to contribution changed the question from who was at fault to how we each got us here."
- ▶ "I sugar-coated it so thoroughly that he left the room without knowing a decision had been made."
- ▶ "I chose the indirect structure because the news was unexpected and personally costly — not because I was uncomfortable saying it."
- ▶ "The apology named my regret rather than the problem, and the conditional wording conceded nothing."
- ▶ "Cengage would say imply the refusal; Stone would say clarity is the first responsibility. In a face-to-face conversation about someone's career, Stone wins."
- ▶ "The timing did most of the damage: the end of a meeting, the night before a pitch."

Anticipated questions

- *Why do managers avoid difficult conversations, and what does it cost?* → The asymmetry in how we weigh costs and benefits → identity threat and the culture of nice → the Scott-Todd compounding sequence → the hand-grenade image → the decision test (weigh all four quadrants, short and long term) → and the honest caveat that not raising it is sometimes the right call.
- *"Every difficult conversation is three conversations." Explain and apply.* → The three → the difficult/learning table → the And Stance and the third story → role reversal and the observer's insight → apply to a case with specific lines.
- *When should bad news be delivered directly, and when indirectly?* → The four-and-four criteria → the four-part structure → the six cushioning techniques → the ethics test → the implied-refusal risk → the cross-cultural layer from S10 (British direct, Thai barely has the word, Latin American reluctance to report bad news upward).
- *Draft a message refusing X, and justify your choices.* → Format 3 in Part A. Write the real message, then design notes naming buffer type, reason strategy, cushioning technique used, and close type.

SESSION 9

Persuasive Communication

The spine: persuasion is not a hard sell but a learning and negotiating process in which the persuader leads colleagues to a shared solution — which means **the persuader's own position may have to move**. Order matters: nobody weighs your evidence until they have decided you are worth listening to. And aim where movement is actually possible: opinions shift, beliefs rarely do.

Sources: Jay A. Conger, "The Necessary Art of Persuasion", *HBR*, May-June 1998 (Reading 9.1) · O'Rourke, "Persuasion", *Management Communication: A Case Analysis Approach*, pp. 154–180 (Reading 9.2) · class slides (Prof. Avani Desai), adding Sussman's framing model (1999) and the Cosmos Electronics and Lindsey examples.

Four ways not to persuade (Conger)

Mistake	Why it fails
1 The up-front hard sell	Conger calls it the John Wayne approach — state a strong position at the outset, then push with persistence, logic and exuberance. Setting out a strong position at the start hands potential opponents something to grab onto and fight . Better to present your position with the finesse of a lion tamer, who engages his "partner" by showing him the legs of a chair — don't give colleagues a clear target to set their jaws in.
2 Resisting compromise	Too many managers see compromise as surrender; it is essential. Before people buy into a proposal they want to see you are flexible enough to respond to their concerns. Reardon's point: a persuader rarely changes another's behaviour or viewpoint without altering his or her own in the process . Not compromising sends the message that persuasion is a one-way street. The best persuaders enter with judicious compromises <i>already prepared</i> .
3 Trusting the argument alone	Great arguments matter — but they are one part of the equation. Credibility, framing, emotional fit and vivid language carry the rest.
4 Treating it as one shot	Persuasion is a process, not an event. It runs: listen → test a position → develop a new position reflecting the group's input → test again → incorporate compromises → try again. Slow and difficult, and the results are worth it.

The class framing of the same point: the common model — state your position, present your arguments, push toward a close — **is one-way transmission**. Aim at a shared solution, not at compliance.

The process: discovery → preparation → dialogue

Conger's process runs for weeks; the meeting is the small part. **Discover** — learn the audience: their opinions, concerns, goals and the history they carry into the room. **Prepare** — test your own position from every angle: what investments of time and money does it require from others? is the supporting evidence weak anywhere? are there alternative positions to examine? what compromises will you offer? **Dialogue** — discuss, debate, listen, revise; invite the objection before it is raised behind your back. The two questions to carry: *before I persuade, what do I need to learn? during, what am I willing to change?*

The four essential steps

Step	What it requires	Evidence and examples
1 Establish credibility	Two sources: expertise (a history of sound judgement, real command of the proposal, a track record people can name) and relationships (demonstrated over time that you listen and work in others' interests; strong emotional character and integrity; not known for mood extremes or inconsistency). Most managers considerably overestimate their own credibility . Assess honestly on both axes and test your answers with colleagues you trust. If expertise is thin: learn more (formal or informal); hire or borrow an expert whose credibility substitutes for yours; use outside sources — respected periodicals, independent reports, lectures; launch a pilot to demonstrate value on a small scale. If relationships are thin: meet one-to-one with every key person — <i>not to outline your position but to collect perspectives</i> , and offer help with their issues; involve like-minded coworkers who already have strong relationships with your audience.	Tom Smith , new COO of a large retail bank, an outsider from financial services with no personal connections and no perceived market knowledge, believed overheads would jeopardise the bank in a more competitive era; colleagues saw no danger after years of success. He (i) hired an external consultant with respected industry credentials who showed in interactive presentations how competitors were containing costs, then circulated the findings in writing; (ii) visited all 135 branches in his region over three months, listening to branch managers on strengths, weaknesses, competitor moves and customer trends — building a perspective few in senior management had, and dozens of relationships; (iii) launched a small, visible pilot — no mortgage payments for 90 days — which succeeded and made him look like a savvy retail banker. All of it <i>before</i> he made his case. Fries & Linnett at Microsoft (the BOB project): Fries had relationship credibility (she had recruited many of the people who would decide); Linnett had technical expertise. Neither had a track record in social-interface software, so they found substitutes — hired respected internal guru Darrin Massena, built prototypes, market-tested them, and brought in two Stanford professors expert in human-computer interaction to present rigorous research to Gates and senior management.

2 Frame for common ground	Describe your position in terms that show their advantage. It is a process of identifying shared benefits — and when no shared advantage is readily apparent, effective persuaders adjust the position itself. At its heart is a solid understanding of the audience, gathered through conversations, meetings and questions well before the pitch.	Monica Ruffo and the fast-food franchisees: headquarters wanted bundled low pricing to fix a price-perception problem; franchisees were trading well and feared margin loss. Instead of rationalising headquarters' view she reframed it as <i>franchisee</i> profit — a Tennessee pilot showing fries and drinks (the two most profitable items) rising sharply; an 80%-of-outlets rollout where those sales jumped 26%; research that a 10% rise in perceived value lifted sales 1%, and her estimate that the plan would double perceived value. She closed with the founder's old letter about the franchisees' importance and low-price leadership. Standing ovation; unanimous vote. The jet-engine manager: he had redesigned turbine-maintenance workflow to cut turnaround time and planned to pitch speed and efficiency, asking for new funding. A friend who was VP of engineering told him the president's prime concern was profitability, not speed. He changed the design itself so it needed no new investment and instead drove costs down, documented the savings, and got it approved. <i>Framing may require changing the proposal, not merely the wording.</i>
3 Provide vivid evidence	Ordinary evidence won't do. Supplement numerical data with examples, stories, metaphors and analogies. Reports of market research and financial projections are perceived as not entirely informative — too abstract to be meaningful or memorable; the numbers don't make an emotional impact. Research shows listeners absorb information in proportion to its vividness, and readily draw lessons from comparable cases.	The BOB supermarket analogy: today's software is a supermarket — overstuffed aisles with cryptic headings like "sundries" and "condiments", and you still have to assemble the meal yourself; if you're a good cook it'll be fine, if you're a novice it won't. "We've been selling under the supermarket category for years, and we think there's a big opportunity for restaurants... you sit down, we bring you a menu, we do the work, you relax." Computer-literate colleagues would never have related to a literal description of menu-searching frustration. Mary Kay Ash linking her weekly unit meetings to the followers of "the great teacher from Bethlehem" who survived the Roman legions by meeting weekly and standing side by side — which simultaneously asserts that collective support drives success, that solidarity defeats powerful oppressors (the competition), and that the sales force's work is a heroic mission.
4 Connect emotionally	Two things at once: show your own emotional commitment (too much and people doubt your clearheadedness; too little and they doubt you believe it yourself) and match the tone of your argument to the audience's actual emotional state. The best persuaders canvass key individuals beforehand on the mood of those about to be persuaded, and gather it informally in hallways and at lunch.	What failed: an aeronautics president showed his senior team a smiling pilot in an open-topped biplane, then uncovered the rest of the image — the plane flying into a wall — and said "this is what I see happening to us," then lectured them on the steps needed. The team had just closed the best year in the company's history and had come expecting thanks. They left calling it scare tactics. He had never asked anyone what mood the room was in. What he should have done: a separate session devoted to praising the achievement, then a second meeting expressing his anxieties and asking the team to help develop initiatives. What worked: Robert Marcell at Chrysler showed leadership photographs of his boarded-up hometown, Iron River — the school, the ironworks, the empty railyard, closed churches — repeating three words after each: "<i>We couldn't compete.</i>" Then he stopped, and challenged the team to build the car in America, ending with "if we dare to be different, we could be the reason the U.S. auto industry survives." He offered hope, not doom. Iacocca stayed two hours and approved the Neon.

Aristotle's triad underneath it: ethos (credibility — shared values, background, expertise) → step 1; **logos** (evidence — logical order, data, facts) → step 3; **pathos** (emotional connection — vivid language, shared experience) → step 4. **Class applied example — "How did Lindsey gain trust?"** *Ethos*: created dissonance in the jury's mind, recognised and addressed audience biases ("all lawyers are crooks!"), signalled that she was honest and guileless. *Pathos*: recognised grief, tapped anger, leveraged existing biases, used the right analogies and visuals, tonality and facial expression, and **liking** — "we like those who like us", one of the least-used but most powerful levers. *Logos*: supported claims with statistics and authoritative bodies, addressed gaps in the warrants, made the opposition look unreasonable, used two-sided counter-arguments.

Diagnosis: aim where movement is possible (Rokeach, via O'Rourke)

Layer	What it is	Persuasive implication
Beliefs	At the core, acquired early from highly trusted sources — parents, relatives, teachers, coaches, religious instructors. Formed before children can reason as adults do, so they respond to emotional need and direct instruction. Self-defining.	Change slowly, if at all. Goal: neutralise. You will not convert committed opponents; the realistic aim is to limit their reach among the undecided, and to get to the uninformed first.

Attitudes	Outgrowths of belief, dependent on and consistent with it; shaped by experience, education and events. A navigational term — your position relative to the world. One belief can generate dozens of attitudes.	Move with new evidence from credible sources, but slowly. Goal: crystallise latent opinion — give people with no position enough to form one, before someone hostile gets there first.
Opinions	At the fringe; least stable; outgrowths of many attitudes; dependent on little more than preference.	Most susceptible to persuasion. Goal: reinforce — strengthen agreement, stop backsliding, and turn agreeers into advocates who carry the argument to the undecided.

Five principles governing the system: change in one layer may expose a deeper layer to re-examination but does not require changing it · **change in a basic layer forces change in all higher layers** (stop believing smoking is cool and every attitude and brand preference above it goes) · the more basic the change, the more profound the reordering · **the less rational the basis for adoption, the harder the change** — emotionally acquired attitudes are especially resistant to logic · the closer a structure is to the centre, the more central it is to self-concept, and such beliefs become self-defining.

Three outcomes of the attitudinal formation process: reinforcement of existing attitudes · modification or shifting of existing attitudes (possible but slow; evidence that doesn't fit the frame gets rejected, but enough evidence from trusted sources can tip it) · **creation of new attitudes** — the hardest, best done by *linking the new position to an existing belief*.

Cialdini's six principles of influence

Principle	Mechanism	Managerial use
Liking	We agree more readily with people we like — and we like people who are <i>like</i> us.	Uncover real similarities; offer genuine praise; cooperate. "We like those who like us."
Reciprocity	People repay what they receive. The Japanese call it <i>giri</i> , a kind of mutual indebtedness.	Give first, and meaningfully. If you want colleagues' time and help, be prepared to give yours. Unilateral concessions create a felt need to reciprocate and build goodwill.
Social proof	People follow the lead of similar others. The closer the comparison, the stronger.	Show that comparable others already did it — testimonials, surveys, opinion polls; strongest from opinion leaders your audience admires.
Consistency	People align with their own clear commitments, especially public and voluntary ones.	Connect your ask to something they already committed to. The campaign button isn't there to get <i>me</i> to vote for your candidate — it's there to stop <i>you</i> voting for someone else.
Authority	People defer to expertise. Being an authority beats being in authority — expertise travels across hierarchies.	Explain your own expertise (people often don't recognise it) or bring in an expert whose standing they already accept.
Scarcity	Value rises as availability falls; people want things partly <i>because</i> they are scarce, and weigh loss more heavily than gain.	Highlight genuinely unique benefits or exclusive information. The ethical line: do not manufacture scarcity, and do not misrepresent facts. Faking it destroys credibility once discovered.

The class's ethical test, worth quoting: the difference between influence and manipulation is **whether the other party would still agree if they saw your reasoning**.

Supplementary tactics from class: **loss aversion** — frame around what they stand to lose by not accepting, or the risks of the alternative, rather than what they'd gain · **anchoring** — people rely heavily on the first number they hear and interpret everything later relative to it · **consistency & commitment** elaborated — people want to be seen as consistent with past statements, especially public voluntary ones.

Sussman's framing model (1999) — four steps to one sentence

Step	What to do
1 Specific objective	What must the decision-maker DO ? State it behaviourally, with a threshold. "Approve" is an objective; "understand" is not.
2 SWOT the other party	Their position, not yours. One factor per dimension — the most significant one, right now.
3 Their core values	Explicit commitments and implicit patterns. What do they protect, measure and repeat?
4 Write the frame	One sentence linking all three. Under fifteen words. Simple, vivid, evaluative.

Two tests: does the frame raise thoughtful questions rather than trigger immediate dismissal? Can the other party repeat the exact wording **two hours later**?

Worked example — Cosmos Electronics

Situation: Tanya Edwards needs \$250,000 for a working prototype of a hand-held communicator. Stock is down 11%, sales are flat, customers are leaving. The committee is in maintenance mode, not growth mode. The last R&D effort is still called "the \$500K sink hole". She is grudgingly given twenty minutes.

Objective: secure \$250,000 for a working prototype. **Their weakness:** no appetite for risk after a public failure. **Their values:** they call themselves innovators and act on fear.

The frame that won the funding: *"Our paralysis and fear is our competitors' greatest asset."* — nine words · simple · vivid · evaluative · **never names the money**.

Planning by resistance level (class table)

Audience	Your goal	Core tactic	Example
Strongly opposed	Create uncertainty	Cognitive dissonance; target core assumptions	Instead of arguing the new system is better, ask: "How much time does our current system lose to daily crashes?" — making them question their reliance on it.
Opposed	Reduce resistance	Cognitive dissonance + new data	Budget cuts: acknowledge their frustration, then show data proving that cutting travel now directly prevents layoffs later.
Neutral / unsure	Change attitude	Two-sided counter-argument	"While the new interface has a learning curve, it automates 80% of our manual reporting, saving you hours every week."
Favourable	Amplify attitude	One-sided message	"Your donations last year saved 500 animals. Let's double our impact this year."

One-sided vs two-sided arguments

One-sided works when...	Two-sided works when...
The audience already agrees and you only want to intensify agreement · they know very little about the topic, or are not well educated / have low self-esteem on the issue · no counter-persuasion is coming · they are not closely involved with the issue.	They start out disagreeing · counterarguments are certain to arrive · their knowledge or involvement is low and your position is far from theirs · you want the attitude change to last.

Rule of thumb: if the audience is likely to hear the opposing case anyway, address it yourself first. **Hard limit:** misrepresenting facts will be found out — and credibility, once lost, is the hardest thing to rebuild. There is also an ethical duty: an agreeable, poorly informed audience who would *benefit* from knowing the counterarguments should be told them.

Durability — designing for what happens after you leave

Information decays; emotional appeals decay fastest. Your audience will meet the next message without you in the room.

Three moves:

- **Refute** — raise the strongest opposing argument yourself, then show where it breaks.
- **Commit** — get something tangible and visible. People defend positions they have stated publicly. *Collect the commitment while the emotional momentum lasts.*
- **Forewarn** — tell them someone will come for their decision, and name what that pitch will sound like.

And in organisational change: create a new **frame of reference** through which information is interpreted (we work with stories and narratives, not facts — W. L. Gore's new hires refuse to believe there are no job titles because it doesn't fit their frame) · **manage emotions and expectations** (Goleman: the goal is balance, not suppression — Aristotle's "appropriate emotion, feeling proportionate to circumstance") · **provide constant reinforcement to prevent backsliding** (Garvin & Roberto: the toughest challenge in a turnaround is avoiding backsliding into dysfunctional routines triggered automatically by familiar circumstances; effective leaders reinforce values constantly, with actions backing words, aiming to change behaviour and not just thinking).

Deutschman's five myths about changing behaviour

Myth	Reality
Crisis is a powerful impetus for change	90% of coronary bypass patients don't sustain the lifestyle changes that would stop the disease killing them. Nine in ten refuse to change even facing a personal crisis.
Change is motivated by fear	It is far too easy to go into denial about bad things that <i>might</i> happen. Compelling, positive visions of the future inspire more strongly. (Which is exactly why Marcell's hope beat the biplane-into-a-wall.)
The facts will set us free	Thinking is guided by narratives, not facts . A fact that doesn't fit our conceptual frame gets rejected. Emotional appeals inspire change better than factual statements.
Small, gradual changes are easier to sustain	Radical sweeping changes are often easier to implement and sustain because they quickly yield visible benefits; the results of small changes are often imperceptible.
We can't change — our brains are hardwired early	Brains have extraordinary plasticity ; we keep learning complex new things throughout life if we stay active and engaged.

Related and quotable: Lewandowsky's finding that people continue to rely on misinformation even when they demonstrably remember and understand a subsequent retraction — "by the time they receive a retraction, the original misinformation has already become an integral part of that mental model, and disregarding it would leave the world view a shambles." Kotter: *"The central issue is never strategy, structure, culture, or systems. The core of the matter is always about changing the behavior of people."*

Head, heart, hands — the test any persuasive case must pass

	Head — why should I believe this?	Heart — why should I care?	Hands — what exactly do I do?
Delivers	Evidence they respect. Facts and research that stay defensible when someone checks them.	Emotion that matches the room. Resonance in personal terms — what this means for the person hearing it.	A clear, immediate action, with timing and a channel that lets people ask questions back.

How	Framed around what they stand to gain, not what you want.	Enough feeling to move people — not enough to alarm them.	Say exactly what you want done; make it easy to do now.
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Best Buy: six hundred employees were moved to an outsourcing partner. Information sessions, roundtables, brown bags and a transition site ran throughout, **all of them two-way. Ninety-eight percent stayed.**

Seven questions, in order (the class close)

1 DEFINE — what outcome do I need? · **2 DIAGNOSE** — what do they believe, want, fear? · **3 ESTABLISH** — why should they trust me? · **4 FRAME** — where is the common ground? · **5 DESIGN** — what evidence, emotion, structure? · **6 DIALOGUE** — what will I listen for and revise? · **7 ACTIVATE** — what exactly do they do, and by when?

O'Rourke's "being persuasive" precepts, useful as a closing list: know your audience · know what you want *and* what they want · select your evidence carefully (know which sources they respect and which frame they'll interpret through) · keep the argument simple (the more complex, the lower the probability it is acknowledged, understood, internalised and acted on) · listen before you speak · manage your emotions as well as theirs (an "emotional hijacking" ruins the attempt) · connect personally — answer "can I trust you? what do I know about you? do you know something I need to know? can you help me?" **Also in the reading:** the four steps of a successful attempt — **gain attention** (selective perception; stimuli with inherent attention-getting properties, and stimuli relating to the audience's needs and goals) · **provide motivation** (Maslow's hierarchy: physiological → safety/security → belonging → esteem → self-actualisation, with later "peak experiences" allowing self-actualisation earlier; Alderfer's **ERG** compression into existence / relatedness / growth; Packard's eight hidden needs — emotional security, reassurance of worth, ego gratification, creative outlets, love objects, a sense of power, roots, immortality) · **channel the motivation into action** (recommend a specific proposition; show a high probability the promised satisfactions will follow) · **induce resistance to counter-persuasion** (refute, commit, forewarn). On **fear appeals:** a highly credible source gets a better response; a threat to a *loved one* works better than a threat to the audience itself; poorly educated or low-self-esteem audiences are more easily moved by direct threat; and arousal depends on convincing the audience both of the **probability** and of the **magnitude** of the consequence — it is much easier to sell home fire insurance than asteroid-collision insurance.

Drop-in lines — Session 9

- ▶ "I opened with a fully formed position, which is the John Wayne approach — it gave them a target before they had heard the reasoning."
- ▶ "I treated it as one attempt. Persuasion is a process: listen, test, revise, return."
- ▶ "I had expertise credibility and no goodwill credibility, and I badly overestimated both — as Conger says most managers do."
- ▶ "Rather than rewording the pitch I should have changed the proposal, because there was no shared benefit in it to find."
- ▶ "The numbers were accurate and forgettable. What the room would have remembered was one comparable case told vividly."
- ▶ "I never asked anyone what mood the room was in, so I matched my intensity to my own anxiety rather than their expectation."
- ▶ "I was arguing against a belief, where the realistic goal is to neutralise; the persuadable group was the undecided majority I ignored."
- ▶ "The position was held for emotional reasons, which is precisely why a better argument didn't move it."
- ▶ "The frame should have been one sentence, under fifteen words, that they could repeat two hours later."
- ▶ "I won the room and lost the week, because I collected no visible commitment while the emotional momentum lasted."
- ▶ "They would still have agreed if they had seen my reasoning — which is the line between influence and manipulation."

Anticipated questions

- "*Persuasion is not selling.*" *Explain.* → The four failure modes → discovery/preparation/dialogue → the compromise point (Reardon) → the four steps in order → land on: it is a negotiating and learning process leading to a shared solution, and the persuader's openness is itself persuasive.
- *How should a manager with low credibility persuade a sceptical senior audience?* → Diagnose on both axes → the substitution tactics (borrow expertise, build relationships, demonstrate value via pilot) → Tom Smith in full → frame for their benefit → vivid evidence → emotional match → then Munter's **five credibility factors** from S10 (rank, goodwill, expertise, image, shared values) as a richer diagnostic.
- *Why do facts often fail to change minds?* → Rokeach's layers and the five principles → emotionally acquired positions resist logic → Deutschman's myth 3 and the Lewandowsky retraction finding → framing and narrative → implication: aim at opinions, link new attitudes to existing beliefs, and use vivid evidence over abstract data.
- *Design a persuasive approach for [a specific audience].* → Seven questions in order → resistance-level table to pick the tactic → Sussman's four steps to produce the frame sentence → head/heart/hands to check completeness → refute/commit/forewarn for durability.

SESSION 10

Culture & Communication

The spine: culture changes *who the audience is* — so every choice from the objective onward has to be re-examined. Munter's seven issues are the spine; Hall's high/low context is the single most useful axis; and the two warnings come before the tools: position on any dimension is **relative, never absolute**, and we reliably assume others are more like us than they are.

Sources: Mary Munter, "Cross-Cultural Communication for Managers", *Business Horizons*, May-June 1993 (Reading 10.1) · Smeltzer et al., "Intercultural Managerial Communication", ch. 12, pp. 209-222 (Reading 10.2) · class slides (Prof. Avani Desai), which add the relative-position critique (after Meyer 2014), the Ford-Ferrari channel exercise and the Global English table.

Take the critique before you take the tools (the class insisted on this order)

1. **Position is relative, never absolute.** No culture is hierarchical or direct in the abstract. **India is hierarchical next to Denmark and egalitarian next to Japan.** A scale means something only against a named comparison. Never write "India is a high-power-distance culture" — write "relative to X".
2. **We reliably assume others are like us.** Burger and Bass asked managers in 14 countries to describe a foreign colleague's work and life goals. **In every case the managers assumed the colleague was more like themselves than the colleague actually was.**
3. **Convergence is happening, but not where you think.** Child's review found organisations worldwide growing more similar in *structure and technology*, while the *behaviour of the people inside them* holds its cultural distinctness. Laurent found national differences **strengthening** inside a single multinational — German workers became more German, Americans more American, Swedes more Swedish.
4. **Under the skin we are not all alike — the universality myth.** Asked whether most people can be trusted, agreement ran from **55% in the United States to 49% in the UK, 30% in Mexico, 19% in West Germany and 1% in Italy.** Short visits produce the opposite conclusion: you first notice the differences, then the similarities, and leave concluding we are all the same under the skin. The short visit simply never reached the level where beliefs, values and mores differ. (Also the *global village myth*, after McLuhan: some argue technology and transport have only produced greater *proximity*, and proximity has *enhanced* perceived differences.)

Definition to use: culture is the values, attitudes and behaviour of most of the people in a given group most of the time — and the same analysis applies to the culture of a region, an industry, an organisation or a work group, not only a country.

Munter's seven issues — the answer spine for any cross-cultural question

Issue	The question to ask	Content
1 Setting communication objectives	Is my objective realistic given the culture? Is my timeframe realistic given the culture?	Locus of control: internal (people control events — the American "can do") vs external (events predetermined — Islamic <i>insha'allah</i> "if Allah wills", Filipino <i>bahala na</i> "God wills it"). An objective like "construct the building on schedule" may read as irreligious where human effort is seen as determined by God's will. Concept of time: exact and precise (Germany, Switzerland) vs relative and relaxed (Latin and African countries) — the Cameroon meeting called for 9:00 a.m. where people began arriving at 1:00 p.m., and the man who arrived at 2:00 was admonished by the other Cameroonians for being late.
2 Choosing a communication style	What is the cultural attitude to authority ? Do people define themselves as individuals or as a group?	Four styles: Tell (inform or explain; you control the content and need no audience involvement) · Sell (persuade people to do something differently; needs some involvement) · Consult (interact; you need their input) · Join (collaborate or brainstorm; their ideas form the content). Tell/sell fits high-power-distance and individualist cultures; consult/join fits low-power-distance and collectivist cultures. Americans are comfortable with their usual range in Australia, GB, the Netherlands, Canada and New Zealand; in South American and Asian cultures they may need tell/sell for a large power distance and consult/join for group loyalty.

3 Assessing and enhancing credibility	Which of the five credibility factors does this culture weight?	Rank — matters more in high-power-distance cultures; establish it via family status in South America, village chiefs in Samoa, schooling in France. Goodwill — personal relationship and track record; critical in high-context cultures, where business relationships are built entirely on social and personal trust, so you socialise <i>before</i> business. Expertise — weighted more in low-context cultures (German, Swiss, Scandinavian); you may need to prove competence rather than build rapport. Image — audience desire to look like you: age is an advantage in Korea and many parts of Africa, upper-class standing in Britain and India, being male in Iran. Shared values — classic American appeals (next quarter's bottom line, making more money, meeting a challenge) are not universally admired; look for the good of the society, organisation or department, status or prestige, or excellence and moral correctness.
4 Selecting and motivating audiences	Should I include different people ? What will appeal to them?	Who counts as primary and secondary audience shifts: the tribe in much of Africa (a source of social, moral, political and physical security, often more important than nuclear family or nation), the family in some South American countries, class in Egypt. Reconsider who the real decision-maker is; you may need to add officials, power brokers, contacts, sect or family members. Appeals by dimension : security appeals in high uncertainty-avoidance cultures (Japan, Portugal, Greece); risk and challenge in low (Singapore, Hong Kong, Denmark); material reward in "masculine" cultures (Austria, Switzerland); quality-of-life in "feminine" ones (Sweden, Norway). Work centrality (MOW index): high in Japan, average in the US, low in Great Britain — so appeals to corporate affiliation travel differently. Reserve classic American appeals — material wealth and achievement — for masculine, low-uncertainty-avoidance cultures. Hofstede's note: "achievement" is hardly translatable into any language other than English.
5 Setting a message strategy	What structure, channel and format ?	Structure : low-context cultures (German, Swiss, Scandinavian, North American, British) favour direct — conclusion first, read as openness and honesty; high-context (Chinese, Korean, Japanese, Vietnamese, Arabic) favour indirect — build to the point, bottom line last. Where directness isn't the norm it reads as abrupt, demanding or intrusive and can cost the other party face . And direction matters : in authoritarian cultures managers often go <i>more direct than usual downward</i> and <i>more indirect than usual upward</i> . Channel : high-context cultures prefer oral communication and oral agreements; low-context prefer written. In a high-context culture, confirming an idea in writing can imply you think their word is no good. Format : paper sizes, memo conventions and report length differ by country — Japanese memos are neither as common nor as long as American ones; presentation length, number of visuals and how much the audience interrupts all shift.
6 Overcoming language difficulties	Four levels at which language breaks — and fluency on both sides closes none of them.	Semantics — words that don't translate: Korean <i>kibun</i> (roughly inner feelings or mood; communicate in a way that damages it and you can end the relationship), Finnish <i>sisu</i> ("guts", against-all-odds stamina, encapsulating two centuries of Finnish history). Even inside English: <i>billion</i> once meant a million million in Britain; <i>to table a motion</i> means discuss it now in Britain and postpone it in the US. Connotation — words that translate and mislead: Spanish <i>mañana</i> and Arabic <i>bukara</i> both mean "tomorrow" and can mean "some time in the future"; Japanese <i>hai</i> translates as "yes" and often means "yes, I am listening", not "yes, I agree"; Polish <i>nie ma</i> can carry "there hasn't been any in a long time and there probably never will be". Tone — formal/informal, polite/offhand, impersonal/personal, dry/colourful. Decide deliberately whether to adjust yours. Perception — the world the language builds: Hopi does not separate past, present and future tenses; Japanese has a grammatical form (adversative passive) for reporting unpleasant events; Thai has no direct equivalent of "no". If you're not fluent : use simple English without jargon (non-native speakers are often embarrassed to admit they didn't understand), or a well-briefed interpreter, pausing after every short paragraph. For stays over a year, learn the language.
7 Using non-verbal behaviours	Body language and voice · space · greetings.	Knapp's estimate that 65–90% of what we communicate is non-verbal (treat with the S4 caution). Details in the table below.

The frameworks

Framework	Content
Hall's high / low context (the spine of the session)	High context — establish social trust first · value personal relations and goodwill · agreement rests on general trust · negotiations slow and ritualistic. Low context — get down to business first · value expertise and performance · agreement rests on a specific, legalistic contract · negotiations as efficient as possible. Placement on the continuum (Munter Fig. 3, restored on the class slide): Chinese · Korean · Japanese · Vietnamese · Arab · Greek · Spanish · Italian · English · North American · Scandinavian · Swiss · German. The credibility corollary : goodwill credibility carries weight on the high-context side, expertise credibility on the low-context side.

Hofstede's four dimensions (116,000 questionnaires, 40 countries, one US multinational)	Power distance — the extent to which unequal, centralised, autocratic power is accepted by all members. <i>Highest</i> : Philippines, Venezuela, Mexico. <i>Lowest</i> : Israel, Denmark, Austria. <i>US</i> : somewhat low (15/40). Drives communication style and audience selection. Individualism / collectivism — do people define themselves as individuals or as part of a larger group? <i>Most individualist</i> : United States (highest of all), Australia, Great Britain. <i>Most collective</i> : Saudi Arabia, Venezuela, Colombia, Peru. In individualist cultures value standards apply to everyone; in collectivist cultures they differ for in-groups and out-groups. <i>Radius of trust</i> : how many count as "us" who deserve decent treatment, and how many as "them". Uncertainty avoidance — how threatened people feel by ambiguity; met with career stability, formal rules, resistance to odd ideas, belief in absolute truths and expertise. <i>Highest</i> : Japan, Portugal, Greece. <i>Lowest</i> : Singapore, Hong Kong, Denmark. <i>US</i> : fairly low (9/40). Drives audience motivation. Masculinity / femininity — assertiveness and material acquisition vs people, care and quality of life. <i>Most masculine</i> : Japan, Austria, Switzerland, Italy. <i>Most feminine</i> : Sweden, Norway, Netherlands, Denmark. Drives audience motivation.
Monochronic / polychronic time (Hall — see the correction below)	Monochronic — one thing at a time, punctuality, schedules followed strictly, "time is money", measured in small units, long-term means three to five years. Germany, the US, Switzerland. Polychronic — several things in parallel, a relative and relaxed attitude, relationships outrank schedules, long-term means generations, people are more patient and more willing to wait for rewards. Spain, Latin America, most Asian and African cultures.
Kluckhohn & Strodtbeck's cultural values system (Munter Fig. 1)	Five orientations, each with a communication implication. Nature : submit to nature (life determined by God/fate) ↔ harmony with nature ↔ mastery over nature → shapes the communication objective . Time : past tradition ↔ present moment ↔ future goals → shapes the communication objective . Social relations : by rank or class (authoritarian decision-making) ↔ by the entire group ↔ by the individual → shapes audience selection . Activity : <i>being</i> (minimise work; accomplishing is not what matters) ↔ inner development ↔ <i>doing</i> (accomplishment, maximise work) → shapes audience motivation . Humanity : basically evil (control needed) ↔ mixed ↔ basically good (initial trust, control unnecessary) → shapes audience motivation . <i>Saudi Arabia (external control, past-oriented) and the USA (internal control, future-oriented) sit at opposite poles. Raising Mexican workers' salaries may reduce the hours they want to work; overtime pay may not move Malaysian workers who prefer extra time with family.</i>
Universalists vs particularists (class, after Trompenaars)	Universalists : common rules for everyone; trust in systems; standardisation, fairness, objective measurement; "people assigned to tasks." Particularists : obligations to specific people and relationships come first; trust in networks; customisation, contextual appropriateness, subjective judgement; "tasks assigned to people."

The attribution correction — free marks

Chapter 12 lists **high/low context** and **monochronic/polychronic time** among Hofstede's dimensions. **Both are Edward Hall's**. The class slide flags this explicitly: "check the attribution before you cite it." Getting it right — and better, *noting* that the textbook gets it wrong — is a visible signal of careful reading. Hofstede's four are power distance, individualism/collectivism, uncertainty avoidance and masculinity/femininity.

Channel against the other party's context — the Ford–Ferrari exercise

The case (Copeland & Griggs, quoted in Munter): Ford agrees to acquire the production side of Ferrari and use the Ferrari name in the United States. **The deal is made on handshakes between gentlemen.** Soon after, Ford's attorneys arrive in Italy with contracts and a crew arrives to take inventory. This is normal business procedure to the Americans; Ferrari is disgruntled — **to his thinking he had an understanding with a gentleman, not with a group of attorneys and accountants.** The deal falls through.

	Counterpart is high context	Counterpart is low context
Oral	Strongest fit. Preserves the relationship-first norm and matches how trust was already established.	Warm, undocumented. Feels good in the room; an efficiency-minded counterpart will still want it in writing afterwards.
Written	Highest risk. Confirming in writing can imply their word was never going to be enough. <i>This is what derailed the deal.</i>	Strongest fit. Matches the expectation of a specific, legalistic agreement that protects both sides.

The class note: the 2019 film tells a fuller story in which Enzo's objection was about racing autonomy. Park that — the exam question is the communication one. **And the general principle:** face-saving is not an Asian phenomenon. It operates everywhere; only the degree and the nuance change.

Non-verbal and etiquette specifics — high-yield examples

Domain	Examples worth carrying into an answer
Greetings	Handshake pressure varies — the high-pressure American grip may read as aggressive where a lighter grasp is traditional; the hearty Australian shake vs the gentle single shake of the French. Japanese older businesspeople still bow, sometimes bowing and shaking hands to respect both cultures, with different levels of bow carrying different meanings. The Latin and Mediterranean <i>abrazo</i> — handshake, hug and shoulder pats; in Algeria anything less can be alienating. The Hindu <i>namaste</i> , Thai <i>wai</i> and Laotian <i>nop</i> all use a palms-together praying motion with a bow. Japanese bowing conventions are complex enough that most non-Japanese should stick with a handshake.
Business cards	In Japan handed and received with both hands , information facing the receiver, studied carefully and arranged on the table during the meeting — never put away hastily or scribbled on. Printing the reverse in the local language is courteous anywhere non-English-speaking.

Gestures — the danger zone	The "OK" circle is vulgar in Brazil, Paraguay, Singapore and Russia. Thumbs-up is an obscenity in Australia. Nodding the head up and down means "no" in Bulgaria, Yugoslavia, Iran and Sri Lanka. Pointing with the index finger is rude from Sudan to Venezuela to Sri Lanka (and in Ethiopia the "come here" finger is used only with children and dogs). The reversed V-sign is an insult in Britain. Crossing ankle over knee is rude in Indonesia, Thailand and Syria. Pointing the index finger at yourself insults the other person in Germany, the Netherlands and Switzerland. Avoid an open hand over a closed fist in France, "tsk tsk" in Kenya, whistling in India.
Reading others' gestures	Chinese stick out their tongues to show surprise and scratch ears and cheeks to show happiness; Japanese suck in air, hissing through the teeth, to indicate embarrassment or "no"; Greeks puff air after receiving a compliment; Hondurans touch a finger below the eye for caution or disbelief.
Resisting your own reading	Vietnamese may look at the ground to show respect , not shiftiness. Russians may show less facial expression and Scandinavians fewer gestures without being unenthusiastic. Latin and Mediterranean gesticulation and touch is not pushiness. Southern US slowness is not stupidity; northern speed is not arrogance. Brazilians may interrupt more, Asians may respect silence more, Arabs may speak more loudly.
Touch	Never touch the head in Buddhist cultures, Thailand or China — it is sacred, and objects should not be passed over it (in Tonga it could carry the death penalty). Never use, pass, receive or eat with the left hand in Muslim cultures. Never show the sole of your shoe in Muslim cultures — so don't cross ankle over knee or put your feet on the desk. Touch frequency study (Knapp): one hour of café conversation produced 180 touches in San Juan, 110 in Paris, 1 in Gainesville, Florida and 0 in London. In Iran, Palestine, China and Indonesia two men may hold hands walking as a sign of close friendship, while a man and a woman doing so would be frowned upon.
Space	American zones as above (0–18 in intimate, 18 in–4 ft personal, 4–12 ft social, 12 ft+ public). Latin Americans and Arabs stand much closer — face to face, close enough to smell your breath; Venezuelans may consider it rude if you back away. The British prefer more distance and may consider it rude if you move too close.
Food	Refusing a host's offering is a serious insult in many cultures — sheep's eyes in Saudi Arabia or Kazakhstan, shark's fin soup in China, a live fish carved at the table in Japan. Conversely, visitors to the US criticise processed foods and snacking; corn is animal food in much of the world; the Japanese do not eat on the street or standing.
Gifts	Important in Japan, generally inappropriate in Germany, Belgium or the UK. Tipping is an insult in China. Chrysanthemums have funeral associations in many European countries; white flowers carry the same message in Japan, purple in Brazil and Mexico. The number four is bad luck in Japan (seven in Kenya, though lucky in the Czech Republic); the triangle is a negative shape in Hong Kong, Korea and Taiwan. Company-logo gifts may read as "too cheap to buy a real gift" rather than as a symbol of the relationship. (And the Foreign Corrupt Practices Act 1977 makes bribery in the conduct of business illegal — \$2m corporate fine, \$100,000 and up to five years for individuals.)
Names and titles	Don't use first names unless invited. Surname order varies — Hungarian <i>Bartók Béla</i> , Chinese <i>Mr Zhou</i> (Zhou Enlai); in Spain <i>Miguel Ortega Gonzales</i> is <i>Señor Ortega</i> ; Brazil and Poland use polite-familiar forms (<i>Senhor Enrique</i> , <i>Pan Stanisław</i>). Iceland uses first names officially, with patronymic last names. Titles are relatively unimportant in Sweden or Israel and very important in Germany or Austria (a German professor's wife carries <i>Frau Professor</i>); in Korea titles often replace names because of Confucian attitudes to saying names aloud.

Global English — do not simplify your thinking, simplify your language

Move	Why
Plain over jargon	Replace business-speak with literal words.
Skip idioms	"Out of the park" and "off the cuff" do not travel.
Explain acronyms	Spell out first use; abbreviate sparingly after.
Name the person	Say "Marco" or "Suzuki", not an ambiguous "he" or "they".
Drop the sarcasm	It works by saying the opposite of what you mean.
Say we and us	Inclusive language beats insider references.

Swaps from the handout: lots of moving parts → several connected steps · put out some feelers → ask a few people informally · key takeaways → important points · pain points → challenges · firm up a plan → finalise a plan · draw up a document → draft a document.

The test: would a competent non-native speaker have to guess at any word in your version? If yes, it isn't finished. **Speed of reading is not the goal; certainty of meaning is.** If the rewrite is longer than the original, that is fine.

Translation disasters worth one line: Parker Pen's ink advertised in Latin America as preventing unwanted pregnancies; "Come alive with Pepsi" rendered in German as "come alive from the grave"; GM's "Body by Fisher" as "Corpse by Fisher" in Flemish; the Chevrolet Nova ("no go") and the Ford Fiera ("ugly old woman") in Spanish.

Saying "no" across cultures — ties directly to Session 8

Culture	Pattern
British	Straightforward; little softening needed.
German	Occasional buffers, but the bad news is given directly.
Latin American	Reluctant to report bad news upward — doing so can be seen as disrespectful.
Thai	The word "no" barely exists; refusal is implied extremely subtly.
Many Asian and Latin cultures	Read between the lines: " <i>We will consider...</i> " often means "not a chance".

What makes a good intercultural communicator

Above all, **avoid ethnocentrism** — seeing your own country as best and looking down on others as inferior for having different customs, which builds resentment rather than relationships. The reading's image: behave like a well-behaved guest in someone's home, who does not say "we have more bathrooms at our house" and is genuinely appreciative of whatever hospitality is offered. Then be: **non-defensive about your homeland's flaws** (discuss the problems and what is being done, rather than denying their validity) · **curious and brave** about other places and people, knowing the creature comforts of home are not always available · **empathic, understanding and non-judgemental**, seeing the world through your partners' eyes and recognising that initially strange behaviours have locally justifiable, long-standing reasons · **patient and industrious** — living with ambiguity, expecting the unexpected, and finding alternatives when plans change · **genuinely personable**, truly liking and respecting the people. *It cannot be faked.*

Munter's four closing rules: **read and discuss** the culture before you go — economics, industry, politics, government, religion, philosophy, history, symbols, traditions, social structures, cultural achievements, language, sports, food · **listen, react and interpret** while you are there; stay alert, be flexible, use your new associates as resources — most people are happy to explain their customs to interested foreigners · **imitate group members** to learn by example, especially for non-verbals, and watch how group leaders behave · **maintain an open attitude** — patience, tolerance, objectivity, empathy and respect.

Context worth one sentence: Black & Mendenhall found more than 70% of US expatriates and 90% of their families are sent overseas with no cross-cultural training at all, and between 16% and 40% return early; direct costs of failed expatriate assignments exceeded \$2 billion a year. Effective training is a necessity not a luxury, is a family affair, and must be experiential, participative and behavioural.

The closing case from class — the Indian IT services firm in Europe

Inside one organisation sit four groups: engineers and delivery managers at headquarters in Bangalore; Indian expatriates posted to Europe; newly hired German, French and British managers; and European customers. The country head has to hold all four together. **The answer that was asked for:** select the three to five frameworks the brief actually gives you *evidence* for; quote the sentence that earns each one; name two lenses you have *no basis* to judge and the question you would ask; then one recommendation using only what you selected.

The resolution: he did not want one Wipro Europe. He wanted Wipro Germany, Wipro France, Wipro UK — **integration without erasure** — and roughly sixty per cent experienced expatriates to forty per cent local hires to get there.

Why this matters for your exam: it models the highest-scoring cross-cultural move — *naming what you cannot judge*. Saying "I have no evidence on this group's uncertainty avoidance, and the question I would ask is X" scores better than confidently applying a dimension the case does not support.

Drop-in lines — Session 10

- ▶ "Position on these dimensions is relative, not absolute — the team was hierarchical relative to the Dutch office and egalitarian relative to the Japanese one."
- ▶ "I assumed my counterpart's goals resembled mine, which is exactly the error Burger and Bass documented across fourteen countries."
- ▶ "Sending the confirmation in writing was efficient by my standards and read, by his, as doubting his word."
- ▶ "Both are Hall's, not Hofstede's — the chapter misattributes high/low context and monochronic time."
- ▶ "I had expertise credibility and needed goodwill credibility, which in a high-context setting is built before the business starts, not during it."
- ▶ "'We will consider it' was a refusal. I logged it as a maybe and planned around it for three weeks."
- ▶ "The objective itself was unrealistic given the culture's locus of control, so no amount of message design would have rescued it."
- ▶ "Face-saving is not an Asian phenomenon; only the degree and the nuance change."
- ▶ "Convergence was happening in our structures and systems and not at all in our behaviour — which is precisely Laurent's finding."
- ▶ "I have no evidence about this group on that dimension, so rather than apply it I would ask [specific question]."

Anticipated questions

- *Analyse an intercultural episode using relevant frameworks.* → Take the critique first (relative position, the universality myth) → run Munter's seven issues as the spine → bring in Hall on context for the channel and structure decisions and Hofstede for motivation and style → **name the dimensions you have no evidence for** → one recommendation using only what the evidence supports.
- *Why did the Ford-Ferrari deal collapse, and what should have happened?* → The channel/context matrix → goodwill vs expertise credibility → oral vs written agreement → the redesign: a relationship-preserving oral confirmation followed by documentation framed as a shared record rather than a safeguard, with the lawyers arriving later and by invitation.
- *"Cultural frameworks are stereotypes." Evaluate.* → Concede the risk and state the four critiques → then defend the frameworks as *hypotheses to test* rather than descriptions: they generate the right questions (is

my objective realistic? which credibility factor is weighted here? who is the real audience?) → conclude with the relative-position rule and the "name what you can't judge" discipline.

- *How should a manager communicate bad news across cultures?* → The saying-no table → direct/indirect from S8 mapped onto high/low context → the up/down direction shift in authoritarian cultures → face as the underlying mechanism → connotation traps (*hai*, "we will consider").

PART C

Cross-cutting

The material that does not belong to any one session: where the authors contradict each other (and what to say about it), the combinations that turn a good answer into a strong one, who said what, worked model answers, and a single page to read in the last ten minutes before you go in.

C1 • Where the authors disagree — and how to handle it

Examiners reward students who notice tension between sources. Each of these is a ready-made paragraph.

The tension	The two positions	How to resolve it in writing
Imply the refusal ↔ clarity first	Cengage (S8) lists implying the refusal as a cushioning technique — and warns it can be so subtle the reader misses it. Stone (S8) : when you must deliver a tough message, your first responsibility is clarity; don't try to manage their reaction.	Channel decides. A written refusal to a customer can afford implication — the reader can re-read and reply. A face-to-face decision about someone's career cannot: Scott's implied refusal left a decision nobody could act on because neither man had said it.
Outline ↔ idea chart	Bell & Smith (S3) teach the numbered outline. Munter (S3) , after Flower and Minto, argues the visual idea chart beats it.	Stage of work decides. The idea chart while you are still working out the argument (it exposes missing links and generates ideas); the outline once content is settled and the document is long (it converts directly into headings and topic sentences).
"Advocacy" means two different things	O'Hair ch. 9 (S7) : advocacy = structured dissent, a good thing that fights groupthink. Class slide on team climate (S7) : advocacy = playing to win, hiding gaps, treating others as competitors — the <i>opposite</i> of inquiry.	Say which one you mean. Structured advocacy is a procedure deliberately introduced into a decision; the advocacy mindset is a default stance people fall into. The first is designed dissent; the second is undesigned competition.
Conflict is bad ↔ conflict is the point	Everyday managerial instinct treats conflict as a sign a meeting is going wrong. O'Hair (S7) : conflict is what group meetings are <i>for</i> ; a group that debates nothing has little reason to exist.	The object of the conflict decides. Conflict about ideas, evidence, assumptions and consequences is productive; conflict centred on participants — their knowledge, motives or moral standing — is not. The leader's job is to move it back onto evidence, not to remove it.
The 7/38/55 figure	Smeltzer (S4) cites it; Munter (S10) cites Knapp's 65–90%; the class slide takes both apart.	Keep the insight, drop the arithmetic. Mehrabian tested judgements of <i>attitude</i> from deliberately <i>conflicting</i> single-word cues. The surviving claim — conflicting signals get resolved in favour of the body — is the managerially useful one.
Hofstede's dimensions	Chapter 12 (S10) lists six, including high/low context and mono/polychronic time.	Both are Hall's. Hofstede's four are power distance, individualism/collectivism, uncertainty avoidance, masculinity/femininity. Correct it explicitly.
Indirect structure and ethics	Indirectness looks like evasion; in S8 it is a compassion technique, and in S3 a persuasion structure.	Motive, not shape. Indirect is preparation when the truth still fully arrives, and concealment when it doesn't. Both Munter and Cengage are explicit that the test is the sender's intent.
Feedback ↔ feedforward	Goldsmith (S6) lists six reasons feedforward beats feedback.	He is explicit that it complements rather than replaces feedback and appraisal; the claim is that it is preferable in day-to-day interaction. Never write that feedforward should replace feedback.

C2 • Combination plays — the answers that score highest

Single-session answers cap out. These are pre-built bridges between sessions; each is worth a paragraph in almost any long answer.

Combination	The argument
Listening → Feedback → Difficult conversations	All three fail at the same point: the giver's own state. The manager who won't listen has decided in advance (willingness, S5); the manager whose feedback is too soft is managing his own anxiety (S6); the manager who avoids the conversation is protecting his identity (S8). The common fix is the same too: name your own state, then make it discussable rather than hiding it.
Floor (S3) + psychological safety (S7) + power distance (S10)	Three vocabularies for one phenomenon. The floor tests tell you <i>which</i> part of speaking failed (invitation, entry, continuity, audibility, credibility, uptake, consequences); psychological safety tells you <i>why</i> people don't try; power distance tells you how much of it is cultural rather than personal. Using all three on one incident is a strong move.
Unique information (S7) + the interpretive model (S1)	Sharing unique information is necessary but not sufficient — it still has to be <i>decoded</i> . That is exactly what closed-loop communication is for: it turns transmission into shared meaning, which S1 says was never automatic.
Framing (S3) + common ground (S9) + Sussman (S9)	Framing decides what the audience sees; Conger's step 2 says frame around <i>their</i> benefit, and change the proposal if no shared benefit exists; Sussman gives the mechanics that produce the actual sentence. Run them in that order and the persuasion section of any answer is complete.

Non-verbal design (S4) + timing (S8) + setting (S6)	Every difficult conversation has a physical design: private setting (S6), timing that isn't Friday afternoon or the night before a pitch (S8), and the four levers of space, time, artefacts, body and voice (S4). Most answers describe what was <i>said</i> ; describing what was <i>arranged</i> is distinctive.
Content/relational (S1) + face (S7) + identity (S8)	Three levels of the same insight. The relational dimension is what a message says about the relationship; face is the social image a person wants maintained; identity is what the situation says about who I am. Escalating through them in one paragraph shows depth: the argument was on content, the injury was to face, and the reason it wouldn't resolve was identity.
Grapevine (S5) + Benoit repair (S2) + bad news to employees (S8)	Rumours = Ambiguity × Interest, so the cure for a damaging grapevine is reducing ambiguity through formal channels. Employees prefer formal channels and turn to informal ones only when the formal dry up. Announce badly and morale is destroyed by people learning from the news instead of management.
Miller/Barrett (S2) + listening system (S5) + psychological safety (S7)	The complete answer to "why did employees resist a change that was clearly communicated?" Miller tells you which precondition was absent; Barrett tells you which practice was skipped; the listening system tells you why nobody upward knew resistance was coming. Compliance was available; acceptance was not.
Context 1 / Context 2 (S1) + framing (S3) + high/low context (S10)	Three scales of the same idea. Context 1 asks whether an event registers as a signal at all; framing decides which aspect of it becomes visible; Hall's context tells you how much of the meaning was expected to live outside the words in the first place. Running all three on one incident is a strong opening to a cross-cultural answer.
Deduction/induction (S3) + evidence (S9) + overclaim (S3)	Persuasive evidence must be both <i>vivid</i> (Conger) and <i>valid</i> (Munter). An answer that recommends storytelling without noting the overclaim risk is incomplete; the qualifying remark is what preserves credibility.

C3 · Author & source roll-call

Name	Session	Attach them to
Mary Munter	S3, S10	Thinking vs structuring · idea hierarchy · Audience Memory Curve · direct/indirect · the seven cross-cultural issues · five credibility factors
Bell & Smith	S3, S5	The inspiration fallacy · five planning questions · idea circle & Classic Questions · 16 patterns · claim–reason–evidence · details as hidden persuaders · the five reasons managers fail to listen · non-listening behaviours
Barbara Minto	S3	The Pyramid Principle · "tell the reader <i>about</i> something or <i>to do</i> something"
Linda Flower	S3	Issue trees · "nutshelling" · the outline only arranges what you already know
Stephen Toulmin	S3	Claim, data, warrant, qualifier, rebuttal, backing
O'Hair, Friedrich & Dixon	S1, S7	Interactive communication process · ten causes of failure · four organisational theories · group fundamentals, conformity, polarisation, groupthink, advocacy, leadership
Taylor · Weber · Mayo · McGregor	S1	Scientific management · bureaucracy and three authority types · Hawthorne · Theory X / Theory Y
Chaffee	S2	Linear / adaptive / interpretive models of strategy
Miller (1997)	S2	Backing · accessibility · specificity · cultural receptivity · propitiousness
Barrett (2002) · Roberts	S2	Five practices of effective employee communication; executive involvement as the critical factor
Benoit (1995)	S2	Deny · evade · reduce offensiveness · corrective action · apologise — not ranked
Sturges · Englehart · Post	S2	Crisis message stages · five planning steps · modes of corporate response (reading depth, lower class priority)
Paul Ekman	S4	Emblems, illustrators, affect displays, regulators, adaptors · "most people just don't know what cues to rely on"
Edward T. Hall	S4, S10	Four proxemic zones · high/low context · monochronic/polychronic time (not Hofstede)
Albert Mehrabian	S4	7/38/55 — and what it actually tested
Smeltzer et al.	S4, S5, S10	Six functions and redundancy · leakage and the baseline · seven listening barriers · listening climate · grapevine distortions · intercultural myths and etiquette
Manny Steil	S5	The LAW of listening: Listening = Ability + Willingness
Yip & Fisher (HBR 2025)	S5	Five pitfalls: haste, defensiveness, invisibility, exhaustion, inaction
Bryant & Sharer (HBR 2021)	S5	The information bubble · success theatre · the Amgen listening ecosystem
Elghanayan, Gallego & Ribera (IESE)	S6	Givers' emotions · relevant/no surprises/engaged · ask–tell–ask and bridge · strengths-based approach
Brown, Kulik & Lim	S6	Five tactics for negative feedback and how managers choose between them
Marshall Goldsmith	S6	Feedforward
Jackman & Strober (HBR 2003)	S6	Fear of feedback · five maladaptive responses · five adaptive techniques · the four-step proactive process
Tannenbaum & Salas	S7	More is not better · unique information · "everybody knows" · automaticity · closed loop and the convey · boundary spanning · the risk points
Ancona & Caldwell	S7	Boundary spanning: ambassador, task coordination, seeking input
Cass Sunstein	S7	Group polarisation
Hersey & Blanchard · Blake & Mouton	S7	Situational leadership (directing/coaching/supporting/delegating) · the task–relationship grid

Douglas Stone	S8	Three conversations • learning conversation • And Stance • third story • role reversal & observer's insight • the hand grenade • clarity first • the five-step checklist
Essentials of Business Communication (Cengage, ch. 7)	S8	Direct vs indirect • buffer-reasons-bad news-close • cushioning techniques • apology and empathy • in-person checklist
Jay A. Conger (HBR 1998)	S9	Four ways not to persuade • four essential steps • Tom Smith, Ruffo, BOB, Marcell, the biplane
Milton Rokeach	S9	Beliefs / attitudes / opinions and the five principles governing the system
Robert Cialdini	S9	Liking, reciprocity, social proof, consistency, authority, scarcity
Lorne Sussman (1999)	S9	Four steps to a frame • the two tests • Cosmos Electronics
Alan Deutschman • John Kotter	S9	Five myths about changing behaviour • "the core of the matter is always about changing the behavior of people"
Maslow • Alderfer • Packard	S9	Hierarchy of needs • ERG • the eight hidden needs
Geert Hofstede	S10	Power distance • individualism/collectivism • uncertainty avoidance • masculinity/femininity
Kluckhohn & Strodtbeck	S10	Nature, time, social relations, activity, humanity — and the communication implication of each
Trompenaars	S10	Universalists vs particularists
Child • Laurent • Burger & Bass	S10	Convergence in structure, divergence in behaviour • national differences strengthening inside one multinational • managers assume foreign colleagues are like themselves

C4 • Anticipated questions across sessions

Session-specific questions sit at the end of each session. These are the cross-cutting ones, with the spine of an answer.

Question	Answer spine
"The biggest problem in communication is the illusion that it has taken place." Discuss.	Shared meaning is an outcome, not a property of sending (S1) → the interpretive model → closed-loop communication and the convey (S7) → paraphrase vs repetition (S5) → the "everybody knows" bias → recommendation: design confirmation into the process rather than relying on the receiver to volunteer confusion.
What makes a manager credible, and how is credibility built?	Conger's two sources, and the finding that managers overestimate (S9) → Munter's five factors and their cultural weighting (S10) → the substitution tactics → congruence as credibility (S4) → the relationship track record inside feedback (S6) → note that credibility is audience-specific, not a personal attribute.
"Silence in an organisation is a management failure." Evaluate.	Seven functions of silence (S4) → psychological safety and what the team loses (S7) → floor tests (S3) → the information bubble and success theatre (S5) → fear of feedback (S6) → incentives that reward hoarding (S7) → concede: silence is also thinking time and a legitimate support move, and in some cultures a norm rather than a symptom (S10).
How should a manager communicate a decision people will not like?	Decide direct vs indirect on receiver reaction (S8) → the four parts and cushioning → buffer that transitions → reasons before the news → clarity as the first responsibility (S8) → channel choice and why individuals get a personal delivery → timing, setting and the six-point in-person checklist → cross-cultural adjustment (S10) → follow-up so the grapevine doesn't fill the gap (S5).
What does "audience-centred communication" actually require?	Competence = understanding the audience + adaptability + empathy + self-monitoring (S1) → Bell & Smith's audience checkpoint (S3) → structure chosen by the audience's likely attitude (S3) → framing for their benefit, and changing the proposal if there is none (S9) → the cultural layer that changes who the audience even is (S10).
Diagnose a communication failure at three levels.	Individual (ability vs willingness, assumptions, competence) → interpersonal (face, relational dimension, floor, trust) → systemic (norms, incentives, channels, structure, psychological safety, culture). Then one recommendation per level, sequenced, with owners.

C5 • Worked model answers

Model A — reflective analysis (extract from a Part 2)

The situation being analysed: the writer, a summer intern, raised a data problem in a client review and was talked over; the issue surfaced three weeks later as a client escalation.

1 • What kind of problem this actually was. On the surface this was an information problem — a bad data assumption that nobody corrected. It was not. The information existed, it was in the room, and it was spoken aloud. What failed was **uptake**: the last of the seven tests a contribution has to pass before it counts as having been made. I had invitation (I was asked to join the review) and I had entry (I got a turn). What I did not have was continuity — I was interrupted twice — or uptake, because when the same concern was restated by the engagement manager eight days later it entered the minutes under his name and was acted on. The content of my contribution was never rejected. It was simply never attributed, and therefore never treated as a live issue while there was still time to fix it.

2 • Why nobody, including me, treated the silence as a signal. The team's norm was that juniors summarise and seniors interpret. Norms are the recurring patterns a group comes to accept as the usual way of doing things, and they decide what counts as acceptable communication — which means my second attempt would have been a norm violation, not merely an awkward interruption. Underneath that sat a hierarchy problem of the kind Tannenbaum and Salas identify as a predictable risk point: lower-power members hesitate

to question, correct or admit uncertainty, and the leader does most of the talking. The partner running the review would have said, accurately, that anyone was free to speak. But in a hierarchical team **allowing people to speak up is insufficient** — input has to be actively asked for. Nobody asked, so the room's most junior person, who happened to be the only one who had opened the raw file, said it once and stopped.

3 · The information that was lost was the only kind that mattered. What I knew was **unique information** — not complex, not expert, simply the fact that the extract covered eleven months and not twelve. A team cannot combine knowledge it does not know exists, and the volume of communication in that meeting was very high: an hour of discussion, most of it redundant. This is the clearest illustration I have of quality beating quantity. More talk actively buried the one fact that changed the answer.

4 · My own contribution. Stone's move from blame to contribution is uncomfortable here and it is the honest reading. I stated the problem once, in a hedged, low-power register — "I might be reading this wrong, but..." — which invited the room to treat it as a question rather than a finding. I never closed the loop: I did not check that anyone had registered it, and I read the absence of a response as agreement rather than as non-receipt. Had I conveyed — "so we're proceeding on the twelve-month figure, is that right?" — the gap would have surfaced in one sentence.

5 · What I would do differently. Three things, in order of leverage. Stated as claim, reason and evidence rather than as a hedge: "the extract is eleven months, which understates the run rate by roughly eight per cent — here is the row count." Asked a closed question that calls for commitment rather than an open one that invites digression. And written it, to the engagement manager alone, within the hour — because a written channel preserves attribution in a way that a contested meeting does not, which is the practical answer to a failure of uptake.

*Concepts used and evidenced in five paragraphs: floor tests (invitation, entry, continuity, uptake) · norms · hierarchy as a communication risk point · "allowing is insufficient" · unique information · quality over quantity · blame to contribution · closed-loop communication and the convey · high/low power language · claim-reason-evidence · open vs closed questions · channel choice. **Twelve concepts, each anchored to a specific detail.** That density, not the prose, is what scores.*

Model B — case diagnosis (compressed)

Scenario: a plant manager emails 400 staff announcing a shift-pattern change. The email opens "Effective Monday, all shifts move to a 6 a.m. start." Up roar follows; the union is involved within a day.

Diagnosis. Three named failures. **(i) Strategy mismatch.** The news is personally upsetting, unexpected and certain to provoke hostility — all four of Cengage's indirect-strategy conditions — and it was delivered in the shape reserved for news that is minor or might be overlooked. **(ii) No reasons, therefore no fairness.** Bad feelings reduce when the receiver knows the reasons, feels the news was revealed sensitively, and believes the matter was treated seriously and fairly. The email supplied none of the three, so a defensible operational decision arrived looking arbitrary. **(iii) Channel error.** Morale is destroyed when employees learn of events affecting their jobs impersonally; the reading's rule is that individuals and small groups get a personal delivery and large groups get multiple channels, with face-to-face privileged.

The systemic layer. Treating this as a drafting error would miss the cause. The absence of any prior signal means this was a *surprise*, and surprise is a symptom of a macro listening climate in which upward information does not flow — so the manager had no read on how the floor would react, and the floor had no expectation that a change was coming. Ambiguity multiplied by interest is exactly the condition that manufactures a grapevine, and the union filled the vacuum the formal channel left.

Recommendation, sequenced. *Within 24 hours:* the plant manager holds two shift-side briefings, in person, opening from the third story — "we see the schedule differently and both readings are legitimate; here is the constraint I am working from." *Within the week:* a written follow-up that documents the reasoning, uses buffer-reasons-news-close, embeds the change mid-paragraph, and offers the one genuine alternative that exists (phased start dates by line). *Structural, within the month:* a standing shift-representative forum with published minutes, which converts a private-listener organisation into a visible one and gives the next change a channel to travel down before it becomes news.

Trade-off. Briefing in person before the reasoning is fully settled risks committing the plant to a position it may need to revise, and it costs two shifts of production time. I would still do it: the cost of the alternative — the union setting the interpretation first — is higher and harder to reverse, and Stone's point holds that the costs of avoiding are systematically under-weighed precisely because they arrive later.

C6 · Fresh example bank — the transfer play

The class example lets you **name** the concept; a fresh one proves you can **transfer** it. Each row below pairs the class anchor with an original example you can adapt to whatever case appears. Use the pattern: "This is [class example]'s problem in a different setting — [your example]."

Concept

Class anchor

Fresh example to adapt

Shared meaning	IKEA — "freedom with responsibility" survives retelling; its meaning does not.	A firm tells teams to "take ownership." One reads it as deciding without approval; another as being accountable after approval. Identical phrase, different local cultures, partial shared meaning.
Context reverses content	"Mr Y has moved from Sales to Customer Support" — elevation or managed exit.	"Meet me at 4 p.m. to discuss the project." After a won pitch it reads as recognition; after two missed milestones, as discipline.
Poor timing	A discount expiry shared after it expired.	A price change announced after sales has already quoted customers at the old rate.
Channel failure	Role eliminations sent to a large distribution list.	Performance criticism posted in a project group chat.
Assumption gap	Ashwatthama — a true sentence missing its qualification.	"The client approved the budget," read by finance as the full annual budget when only Phase 1 was signed.
Induction, over-extended	Two acquaintances' jobs generalised into a claim about a profession.	Five customer interviews suggest onboarding friction — they do not prove the whole base has the problem.
Buried conclusion	Munter's widget memo.	A three-page recommendation where the actual ask appears in the middle of paragraph four, after the methodology.
Point-first vs build-up	The widget line, two ways.	Moving the weekly client review from Friday to Wednesday. <i>Point-first</i> to a time-pressed COO: "Move it to Wednesday — it gives us two days to fix issues before the weekend." <i>Build-up</i> to a team attached to Friday: "We all want fewer last-minute escalations. Friday leaves no recovery time and Monday is too late. Wednesday gives us two working days."
Non-verbal contradiction	"Yes — I'll have it on your desk by Friday," said six ways.	A manager says "take your time" while standing at the door, checking a watch and speaking quickly. Chronemics, kinesics and vocalics all contradict the words; the employee believes the urgency.
Chronemics	Who is kept waiting, and for how long.	One department's monthly review is rescheduled every time a conflict arises. Nothing is said about priority; the calendar says it.
Intention vs inference	You think about the deadline; they infer unwillingness.	A manager goes silent after a leave request because she is mentally checking staffing cover. The employee reads the silence and frown as disapproval. One verbal bridge — "I'm checking coverage in my head; the request itself is fine" — closes the gap.
Hearing without listening	The Refrigerator — "Okay, okay. Get it sorted."	An analyst reports repeated failed logins from one external IP. The manager, rushing to a meeting, says "keep monitoring." Next day, a breach. Hearing happened; nobody probed significance, urgency or the next action.
Paraphrase vs repetition	"They've stopped believing our timelines, and the delay is only the trigger."	Employee: "Every urgent task ends up with me." Paraphrase: "So the issue isn't one deadline — it's that urgent work is being allocated to you without discussion, and it's becoming unsustainable. Is that it?"
Information bubble	Sharer at Amgen before the Epogen crisis.	A country head receives only green status reports because regional managers fear escalation. Churn is rising and every region calls it temporary. The system rewards reassurance, so information abundance produces a blind spot.
Systemic & visible listening	Dr Nair cross-references the data, brings a draft, names the four ignored reports.	After complaints about an expense tool, a CFO analyses ticket data first, brings two draft process options, has employees test them, assigns owners and dates, then publishes what changed and why.
Giver anxiety distorting feedback	Managers soften the message to manage their own discomfort.	A consultant suspects the partner dislikes her client handling, avoids asking, and spends two days polishing slide formatting instead of fixing the client issue.
Ask-Tell-Ask	Self-assessment → observed gap → their plan.	"How do you think yesterday's client call went?" → "You answered before the client finished twice, and we missed two requirements." → "What will you change on the next one?"
Denial (fear of feedback)	Angela fixes each stated barrier and is given a new one.	An employee keeps completing certifications and never asks whether the real barrier is weak stakeholder management.
Self-sabotage	Nancy's audible remark about her manager.	Told his updates are unclear, a manager sends a deliberately over-detailed twelve-page memo to prove the criticism unreasonable.
Unique information	Only one person in the kitchen knows truffles.	In a product launch, only the compliance analyst knows approval is still pending. The fact is trivially simple and entirely unique; if it doesn't surface, everyone acts on a false assumption.
Closed loop	Call out → check back → close; 3.6× faster in paediatric trauma.	Warehouse lead: "Hold shipment 24." Dispatcher: "Hold order 24 only, release tomorrow at 10 — correct?" Lead confirms. Two extra seconds, no wrong truck.
Automaticity	The expert who gives a thin answer.	A senior engineer says "just restart the service" and omits three checks that are automatic to her and unknown to the new hire.
Psychological safety	Hesitation as a decision nobody sees.	A junior doctor notices a dosage mismatch and says nothing, because the consultant mocked a question the previous week.
Handoff failure	What without why.	An outgoing nurse assumes the incoming team already knows about the dosage change, and passes on the task without the reason for it.

Avoidance compounds	Scott's week-one silence produces the resignation threat.	A manager avoids telling an employee promotion is unlikely; the employee learns the role was filled from an internal announcement.
Stated vs real issue	Todd talks about the Energy Group; the issue is fairness.	An employee asks for a transfer; the underlying concern is repeated exclusion from client-facing work.
Identity threat	"Why can't you be straight with me?"	"You never support the team" turns a workload disagreement into a challenge to the manager's identity as a good leader — which is why the next twenty minutes are about something else entirely.
Four-part indirect message	Buffer → reasons → bad news → close.	"Your proposal addressed the client's key concern [buffer]. Because the budget is already committed to regulatory work this quarter [reasons], we cannot fund the full rollout now [bad news]. Let's use the next six weeks for a smaller pilot and review in November [close]."
Cushioning that became concealment	Scott's "add value over there."	"Perhaps another project would suit you better," said without ever stating that the employee is being reassigned.
Credibility substitution	Tom Smith: consultant, 135 branches, mortgage pilot.	A new sustainability lead uses audited data, a respected plant engineer as co-presenter, and a small energy pilot before asking for company-wide capex.
Common-ground reframe	The jet-engine manager switches from speed to profitability — and changes the design.	HR reframes a wellbeing proposal from "employee happiness" to "reduce avoidable absence and manager overload" for an operations audience.
Sussman frame	"Our paralysis and fear is our competitors' greatest asset."	For a stalled automation decision: "Every manual workaround is a recurring cost we have chosen to keep." Eleven words, evaluative, never names the budget.
Emotional match	The biplane into the wall, to a team expecting thanks.	After a difficult restructuring, a leader opens a transformation pitch by naming the exhaustion in the room and offering control over the next phase — rather than more urgency.
Audience-specific framing	The three-day return-to-office, pitched four ways.	A cybersecurity investment framed as loss exposure for the CFO, operational resilience for engineering, and client trust for sales — same spend, three proposals.
Context and channel	Ford's lawyers arrive after the handshake.	A low-context headquarters sends a formal legal memo immediately after a relationship-based partner meeting. The partner reads the formality as suspicion, not efficiency.
Connotation	<i>Hai</i> means "I am listening."	A global manager hears "we will try" as commitment; the speaker intended a polite signal of difficulty. A global team agrees to deliver "soon" and each member attaches a different horizon — replace the elastic word with a date and a time.
Evidence before framework	The Wipro exercise: quote the sentence that earns each lens.	A missed deadline explained as "polychronic culture" with no evidence about that person's actual time norms or the project's constraints. That is a stereotype wearing a framework's clothes.

The one-sentence rule. Use class examples to *recognise* the theory; use fresh examples to *demonstrate* it. An answer built entirely from class examples reads as recall. One built entirely from invented examples reads as unmoored. The top band does both, in that order, in the same paragraph.

C7 • Drop-in line bank — general purpose

Session-specific lines sit with each session. These work almost anywhere.

Opening an analysis

- ▶ "The surface problem was [X]. The mechanism underneath it was [concept], and the two are worth separating because they have different remedies."
- ▶ "Three things failed here, at three different levels, and only one of them is about anyone's communication skill."

Escalating depth

- ▶ "Framed as an individual failure this is a training problem. Framed as a recurring one it is a norm, and norms are set by what the group tolerates rather than by what it announces."
- ▶ "No amount of urging people to communicate will beat the incentive."
- ▶ "The question is not whether the message was clear but whether it was received the way it was meant — and those are two different achievements."

Conceding well

- ▶ "The framework is useful here as a hypothesis, not a description: it generates the right question rather than the right answer."
- ▶ "I have no evidence about this, so rather than apply the dimension I would ask [specific question]."
- ▶ "There is a real cost to this recommendation — [cost] — and I would accept it because [priority]."

Closing

- ▶ "The transferable rule is not 'communicate more'. It is: decide what the audience must end up believing, and then design backwards from that."
- ▶ "What I would carry forward is the habit of asking, before I speak, who else needs to know this — and after I speak, how I will know that they do."
- ▶ "Clarity was designed before it was worded, or it was not designed at all."

C8 • The one-page cheat sheet

Session	The one idea	The framework to name
S1	Meaning is constructed, not transmitted; shared meaning is a matter of degree.	Interactive model • three noises • Context 1 / Context 2 / Content • content/relational • interpretive model • levels of perception • the eight failures • the sender's half • four organisational lenses
S2	Compliance can be imposed; acceptance must be earned.	Chaffee linear/adaptive/interpretive • plural audience • communication as transaction • Miller's five conditions • Barrett's five practices • Benoit's five repair strategies (not ranked) • interpretive and critical lenses
S3	Clarity is designed before it is worded — and framing decides what the audience sees.	Thinking (assumptions, deduction/induction, logical defects) • structuring (hierarchy rules, memory curve, point-first vs build-up) • claim-reason-evidence • Form/Frame/Floor • the seven floor tests
S4	You are always transmitting; when channels conflict the receiver believes the body.	Eight channels • cue-expectation-inference • five gestures • six functions • six principles • Hall's four zones • baseline problem • design the four levers
S5	Listening = Ability + Willingness, and willingness is decided before the conversation starts.	Steil's LAW • five pitfalls • seven barriers • casual/factual/empathic • paraphrase vs repetition • three question axes • information bubble • the 2x2 • grapevine distortions
S6	The giver's unmanaged emotion distorts the message; the receiver's unasked question gets filled with a worst case.	Behaviour→impact • relevant/no surprises/engaged • ask-tell-ask • bridge • five tactics • strengths-based • feedforward • five maladaptive responses • the four-step process
S7	More is not better; unique information plus a closed loop is what moves performance.	Five quality tests • unique information • "everybody knows" • automaticity • call out-check back-close • the convey • boundary spanning • seven risk points • incentives • cohesion/norms/roles • groupthink • devil's advocacy vs dialectical inquiry • inquiry vs advocacy
S8	Avoidance is a communication act, and clarity is the first responsibility.	Three conversations • learning conversation • And Stance • third story • the cost asymmetry • direct vs indirect • buffer-reasons-news-close • six cushioning techniques • strong vs weak apology
S9	Nobody weighs your evidence until they've decided you're worth listening to.	Four failure modes • credibility/common ground/vivid evidence/emotional match • beliefs-attitudes-opinions • reinforce/crystallise/neutralise • Cialdini's six • Sussman's frame • one- vs two-sided • refute-commit-forewarn • head/heart/hands
S10	Culture changes who the audience is — and position on any dimension is relative, never absolute.	Munter's seven issues • Hall's high/low context • Hofstede's four • mono/ polychronic • Kluckhohn & Strodtbeck • five credibility factors • tell/sell/consult/join • saying no across cultures • Global English

The five moves that raise any answer

- ▶ **1 Name the mechanism, not the adjective.** "A failure of uptake", not "poor communication".
- ▶ **2 Evidence every concept.** Which behaviour, by whom, when.
- ▶ **3 Escalate the level.** Individual → interpersonal → systemic. The third level is where the marks are.
- ▶ **4 Attribute.** One surname per framework costs four words and reads as mastery.
- ▶ **5 Concede one cost.** Name what your recommendation sacrifices and why you accept it.

PART D

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